



CE Altafulla 2026/2027

S15 Game Model Overview

Ryan Heflin

Overview • **OOP** • **IP** • **Transitions** • **Set Pieces**

We value Strength, Discipline, Teamwork, and Respect

We aim to control the ball, the space, the opponent, and ourselves.

We are attack-minded. Get the Ball, Keep the Ball, and Be Dangerous.

When things break down, we reset, stay organized, and return to our structure.



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Core Values

STRENGTH

- Mental and Physical Strength. We do our jobs no matter the score or our emotions. We don't get pushed around, we fight for every loose ball from the first second until the final whistle

DISCIPLINE

- We do our jobs. Whether that's to make the unrewarded run, track back to cover the far side, show up on time, bring our shin guard to the game, or finish the run to the end of the line, we always do our jobs.

TEAMWORK

- We work as a team at all times. In attack, we support each other, make the run, and communicate. In defense, we move as a unit, communicate, help each other. Off the field we work hard to make each other better players and people.

RESPECT

- We respect each other, the opponent, the referee, and the game. We behave with class, win or lose. We control what we can control and we adapt to the rest with maturity and strength.



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We are focused on creating, exploiting, and controlling space on the field.

Space exists when:

- We have a free player.
- We have a numerical advantage.
- We have a superior athlete in a favorable matchup.
- We have an isolated 1v1.
- We can arrive before the opponent.
- The opponent's structure is disorganized.

**Every page of this document should answer:
How does this help us create, exploit, or control space?**

In Possession
Create or exploit space.

Out of Possession
Control space to regain possession.

Transitions
Exploit disorder before structure returns.



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In Possession

- Space is the objective, not possession.
- Use possession when it creates space.
- Go direct when space exists behind.
- Play through when space exists between lines.
- Switch play when one side becomes overloaded.
- Attack quickly once the space is identified.
- Tempo varies based on available space.

Out of Possession

- High press when organized.
- Mid-block when disorganized or recovering.
- Defend space first.
- Maintain compactness.
- Force opponents into predictable areas.

Defensive Transition

- Immediate 5 second counterpress if conditions are favorable.
- If the ball isn't won quickly, recover shape.
- No emotional chasing.

Personnel Priorities

- Ball-playing CB initiates attacks.
- Winger creates superiority.
- Striker threatens depth.
- Midfield exists to connect and protect.
- Fullbacks create width and balance.



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S15 Game Model Overview

Principles Hierarchy

In Possession

1. Exploit space behind
2. Exploit space between lines
3. Create numerical superiority
4. Switch play
5. Recycle possession

Attack Transition

1. Attack space
2. Secure possession
3. Build attack

Out of Possession

1. Delay
2. Control space
3. Force predictable action
4. Regain possession

Defensive Transition

1. Counterpress
2. Delay
3. Recover shape

Non Negotiables

Without the Ball

- Compress space
- Communicate
- Recover immediately
- Win aerial duels
- Delay before diving in

With the Ball

- Look forward first
- Support the ball
- Create width
- Attack space
- Be brave in the final third

Transitions

- Counterpress immediately
- Attack chaos immediately



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About This Game Model Document

This game model document is made specifically for CE Altafulla S15 Boys 2026/2027

This is called “Player Centered Game Model” because the goal is for the players to solve problems as best they see fit.

These boys need/want freedom to express themselves by finding solutions, so this model is merely to be used as a way to create a shared ideology and set of solutions, rather than a strict manual for how to play. Each solution can realistically be used to solve any problem.

Offense:

- This team excels in space on the attack. We have some strong, fast, physical players. The model emphasizes the need to create and exploit space.
- This team struggles in tight areas where close control and speed are needed. This model present solutions where needing to play in these spaces is limited.

Defense:

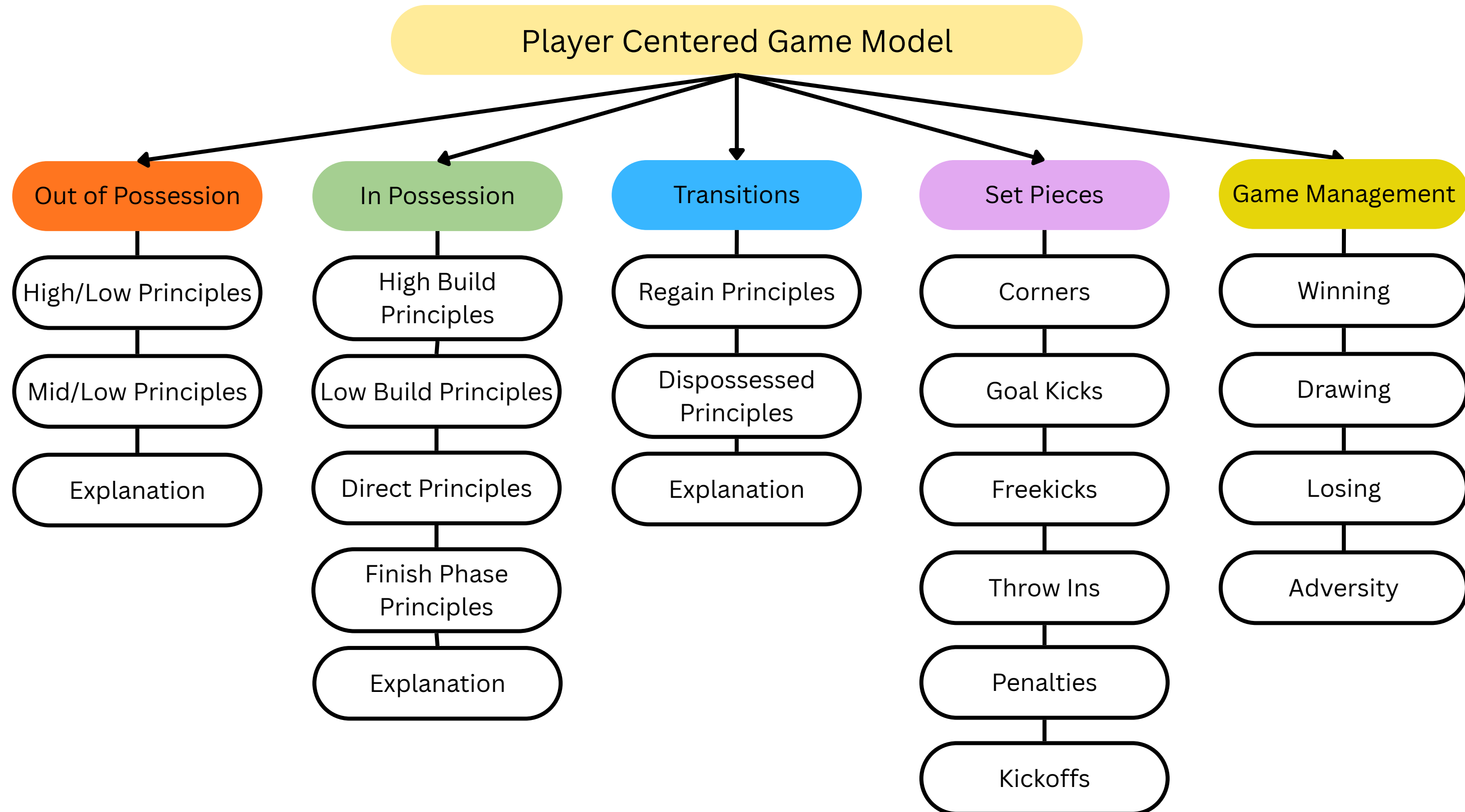
- This team is better at dictating where the opponent should play than reacting to lateral ball movement. This model focuses on pressing traps and triggers.
- This team struggles in individual defending and reactive movements. This model emphasizes aggression and team defending.



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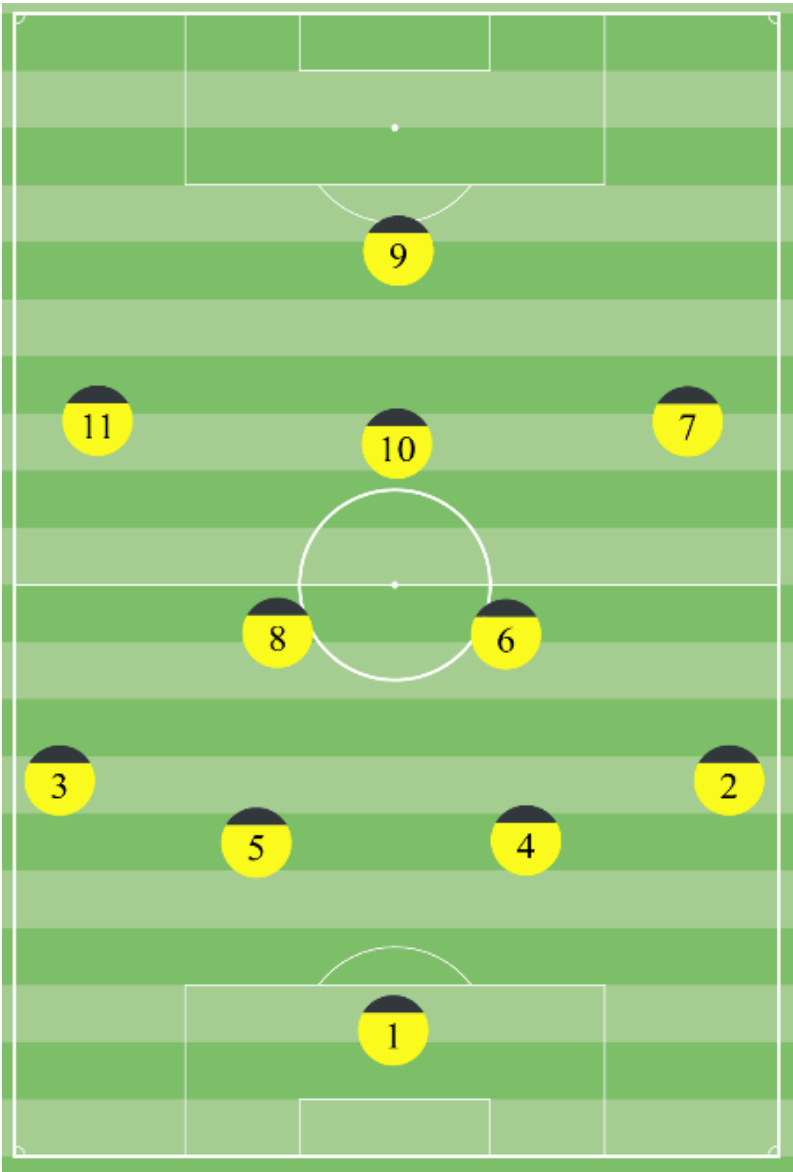
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S15 Game Model Overview

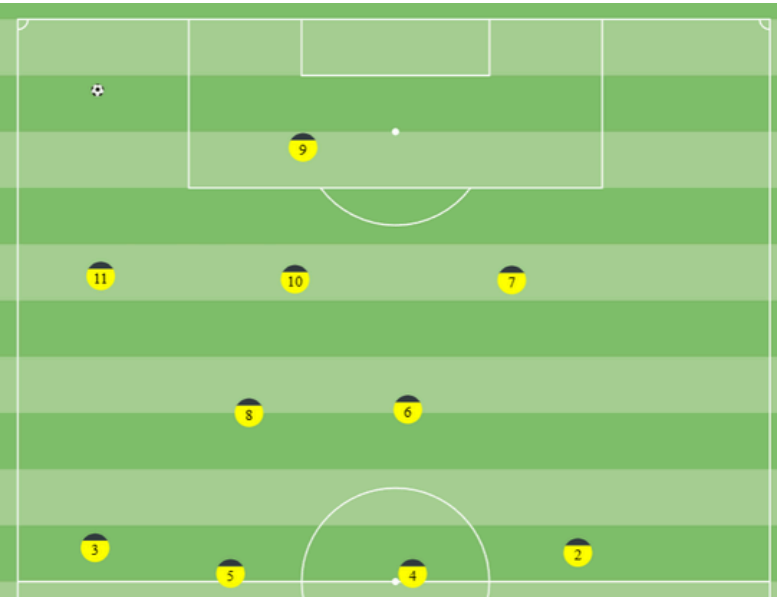
Formation Graphics - 1-4-2-3-1 In and Out of Possession General Overview

Overview

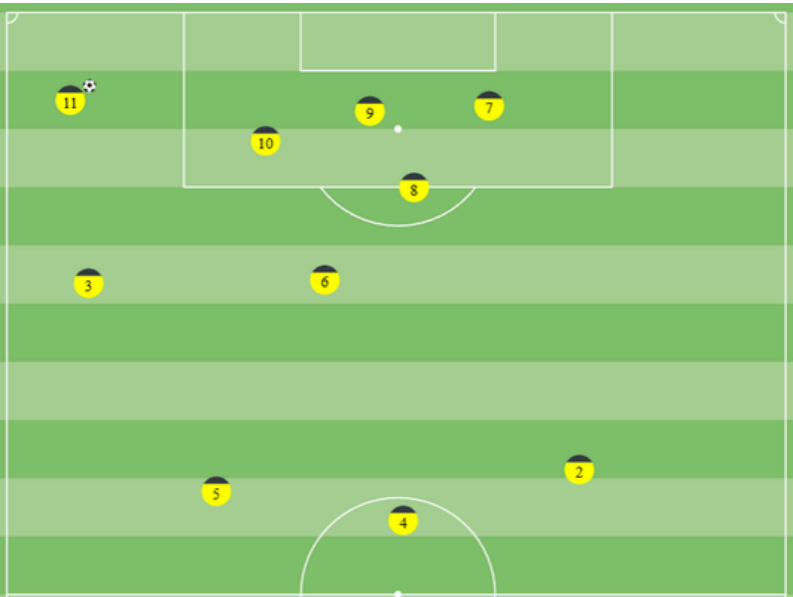
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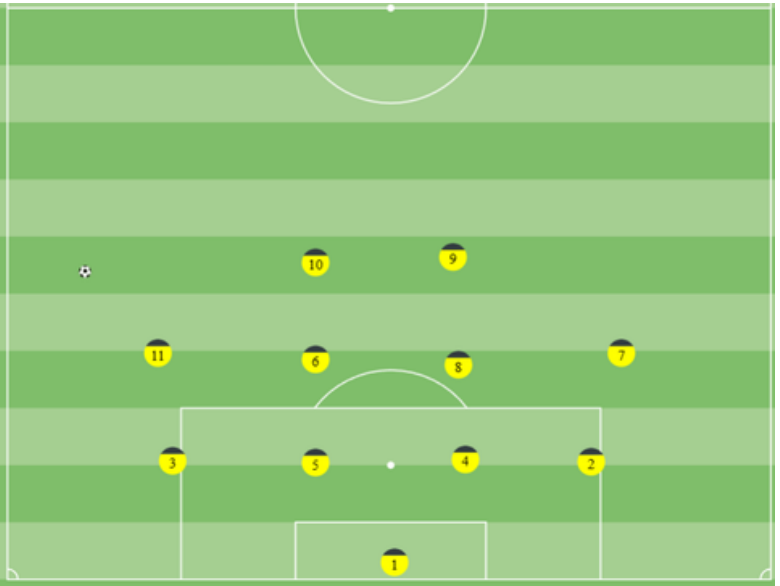
1-4-2-3-1 Double Pivot, Single 10, Aggressive NSFB, Solid Rest 3 Defense, Exploit Wide Areas



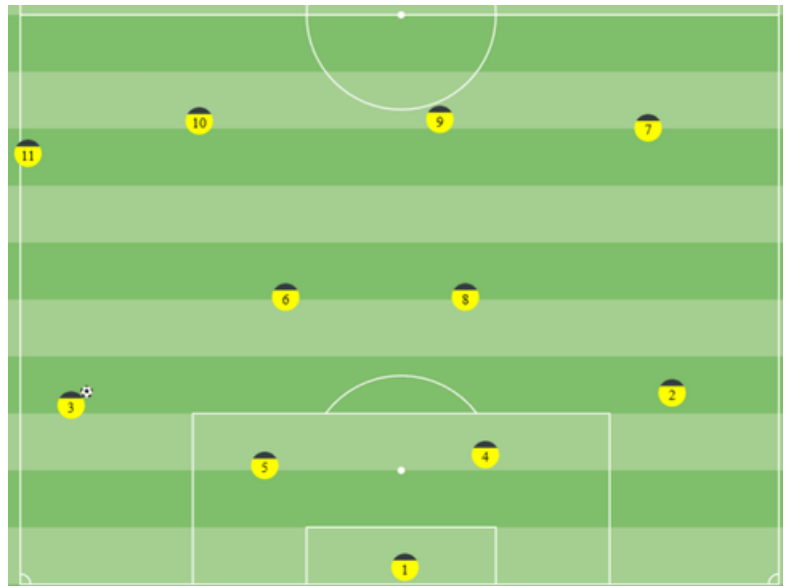
High Press - High 1, Central Block 4, Aggressive FBs, CBs Compressing Space



High Attack - 4 In Box, 2 Support, 3 Rest Defense



Low Block - Solid 4-4-2 with Compression but Depth between Lines



Low Build - Front Line High and Rotate Through Red Zone



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Positional Roles and Responsibilities

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1 - GK

Comfortable with the ball. Distributes short to the CBs to start buildup if possible. Knows when to go long, reads the high press and beats it with a direct ball behind. Owns the area, collects crosses.

4/5 - Center backs

Ball-playing. Split wide to give the keeper two clean options. Set the defensive line and own the low block. Comfortable under pressure, know when to go long. The first step of the press escape.

2/3 - Fullbacks

Attack-minded when we have the ball. Overlap to combine and cut the winger free inside. One goes at a time. When we lose it, immediate recovery track. Key to the low block's width.

6 - Anchor

Screens the back four. Never gambles. Covers the space behind the press, first to recover when we lose the ball. In the high press, holds slightly deeper so there's always a safe exit.

8 - Progressor

Receives from the CBs and drives. Looks to play the 10 between the lines or split the defense directly. More mobile, pushes higher in possession. In the high press, they push up to condense the middle.

7/11 - Wings

Start wide, drifts inside to shoot or combine. The 2/3 fills the width behind. Always has the 10 inside them, never isolated. Takes risks, dribbles at defenders. Press trigger on the near side in the high block.

10 – ACM

Eliminates isolation, permanently available between the lines. Drops to receive, drives forward, finds the splitting pass. Links the wingers and the striker into one connected unit. Never caught flat. The 10 is the connector and space creator of the attacking unit.

9 - Striker

Press leader and reference point. Triggers the high press from the front, sets the trap. Holds the ball and links to the 10 for combinations. Makes runs in behind when the 10 has the ball. Attack depth when space exists. Create a platform when space doesn't.



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In Possession

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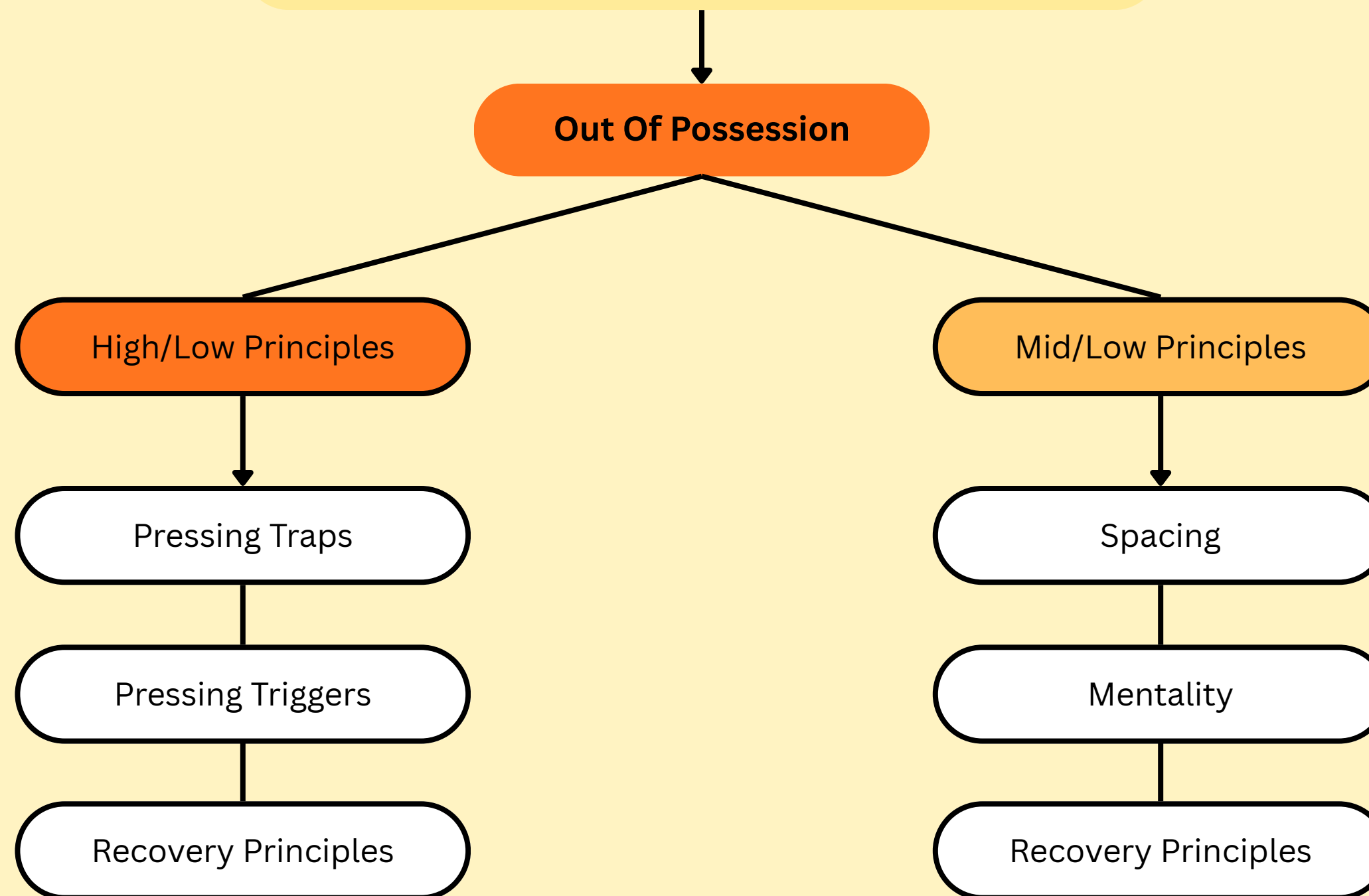
Set Pieces

Game Management

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Out of Possession

Player Centered Game Model





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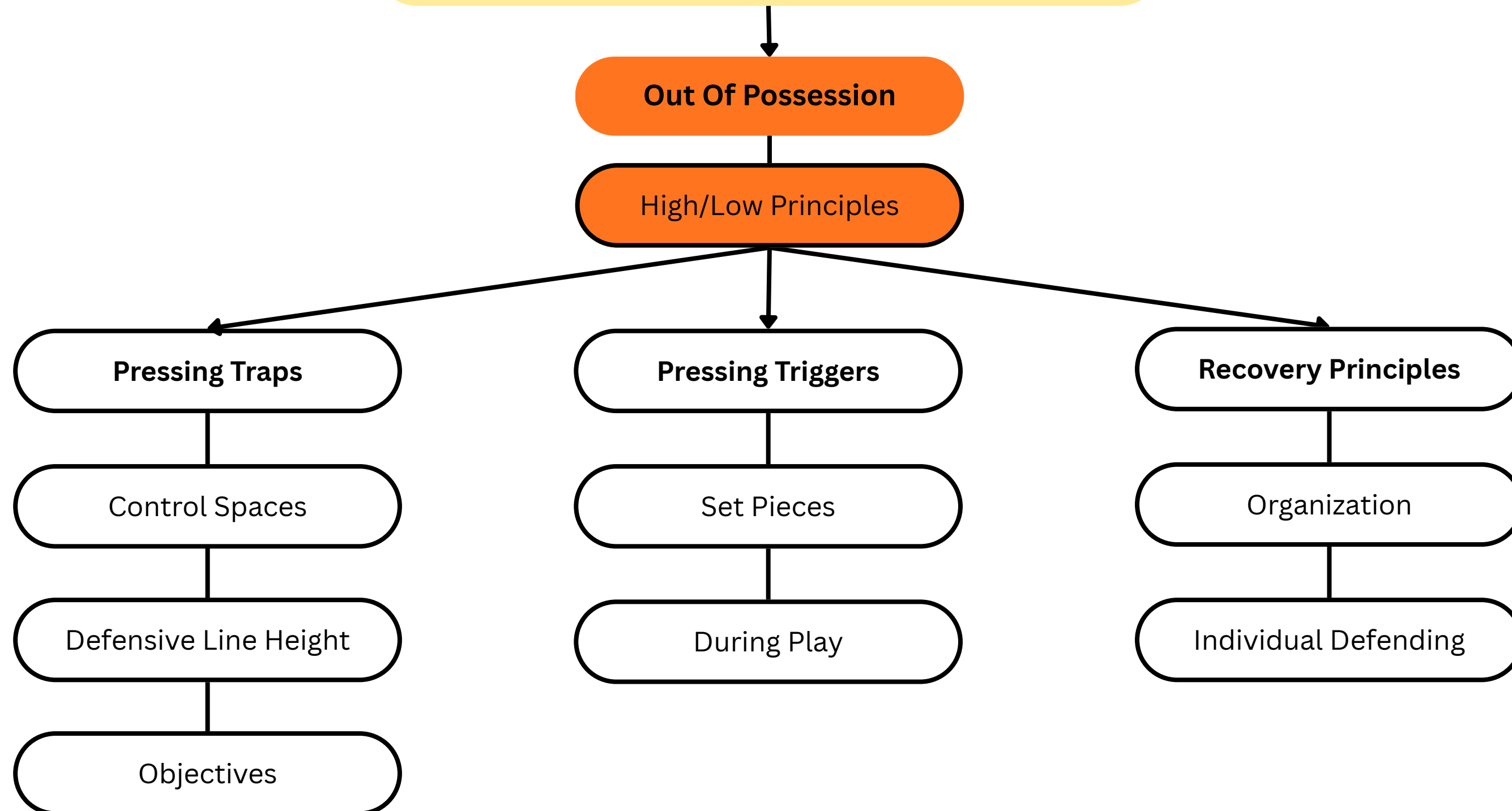
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High/Low Principles

Pressing Traps

Pressing Triggers

Recovery Principles

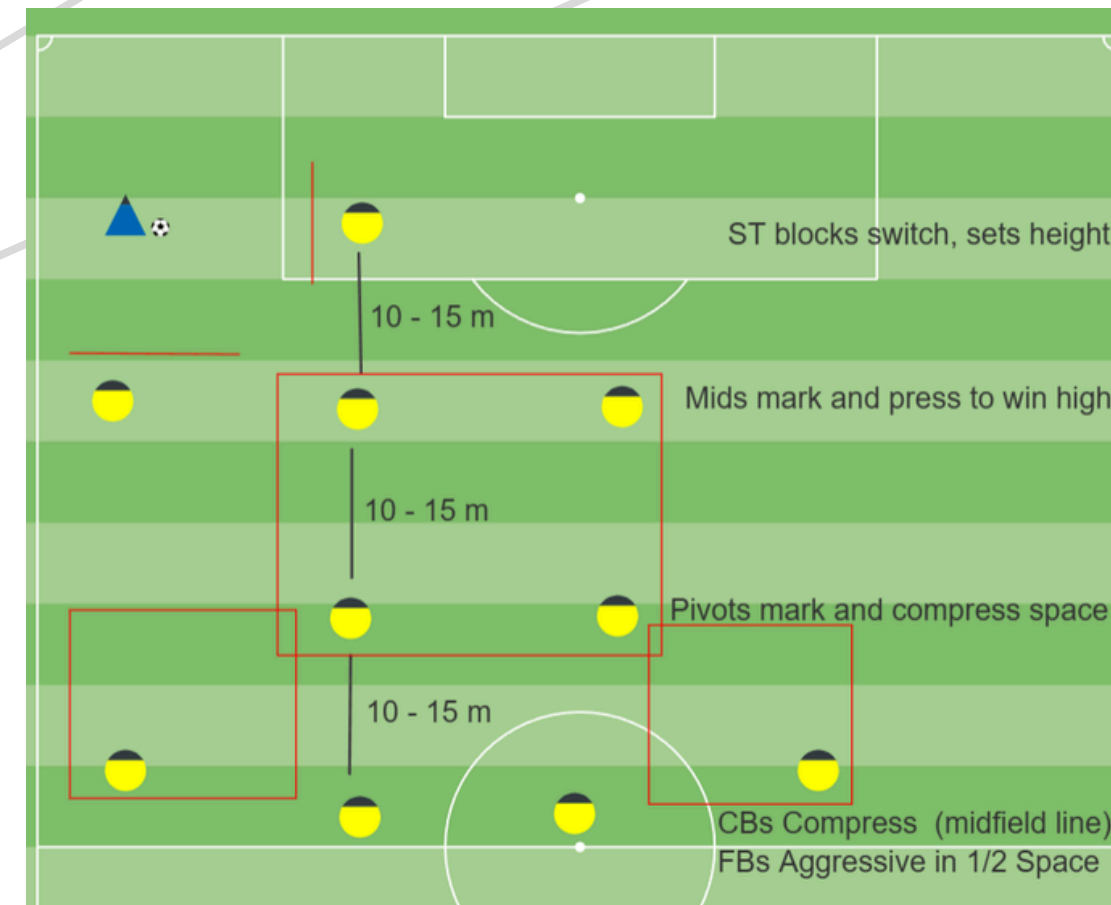
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Out of Possession

Control Spaces



Defensive Line Height



Objectives

- Never let passes down the line
- Attempt to cut of switch to 1 or 4/5, force forward
- 10 and FS7/11 on 6/8
- 6/8 on 10 and FS7/11
- 2/3 Aggressive into halfspace for NS7/11 or 9
- 4/5 watch for long balls
- Goal is to force a risky pass centrally, or an aerial ball
- WE WIN AERIAL BALLS
- Swarm second ball, go to reset transitions
- Keep compressed vertical space

See Page 13 for variations



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High/Low Principles

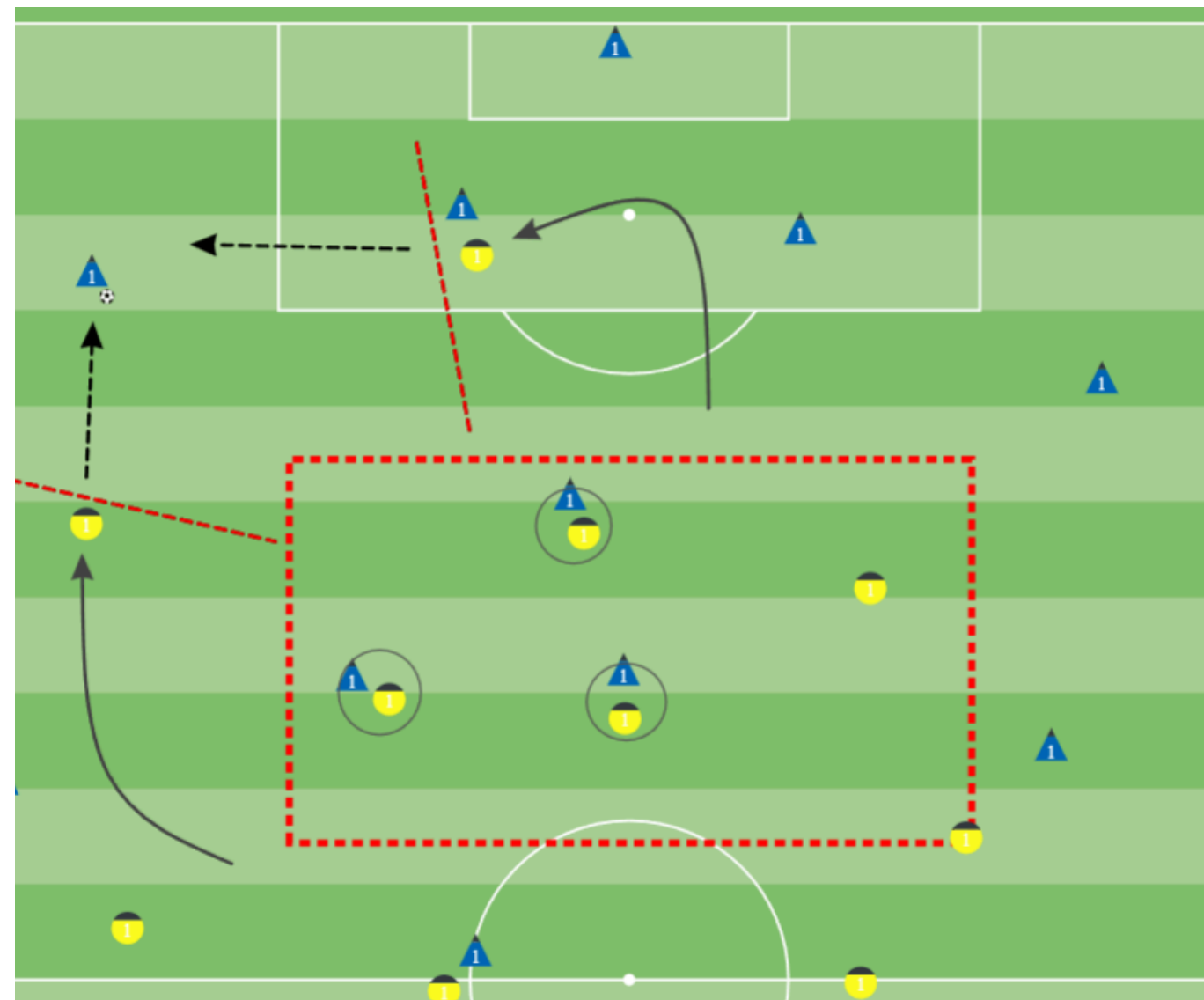
Pressing Traps

Pressing Triggers

Recovery Principles

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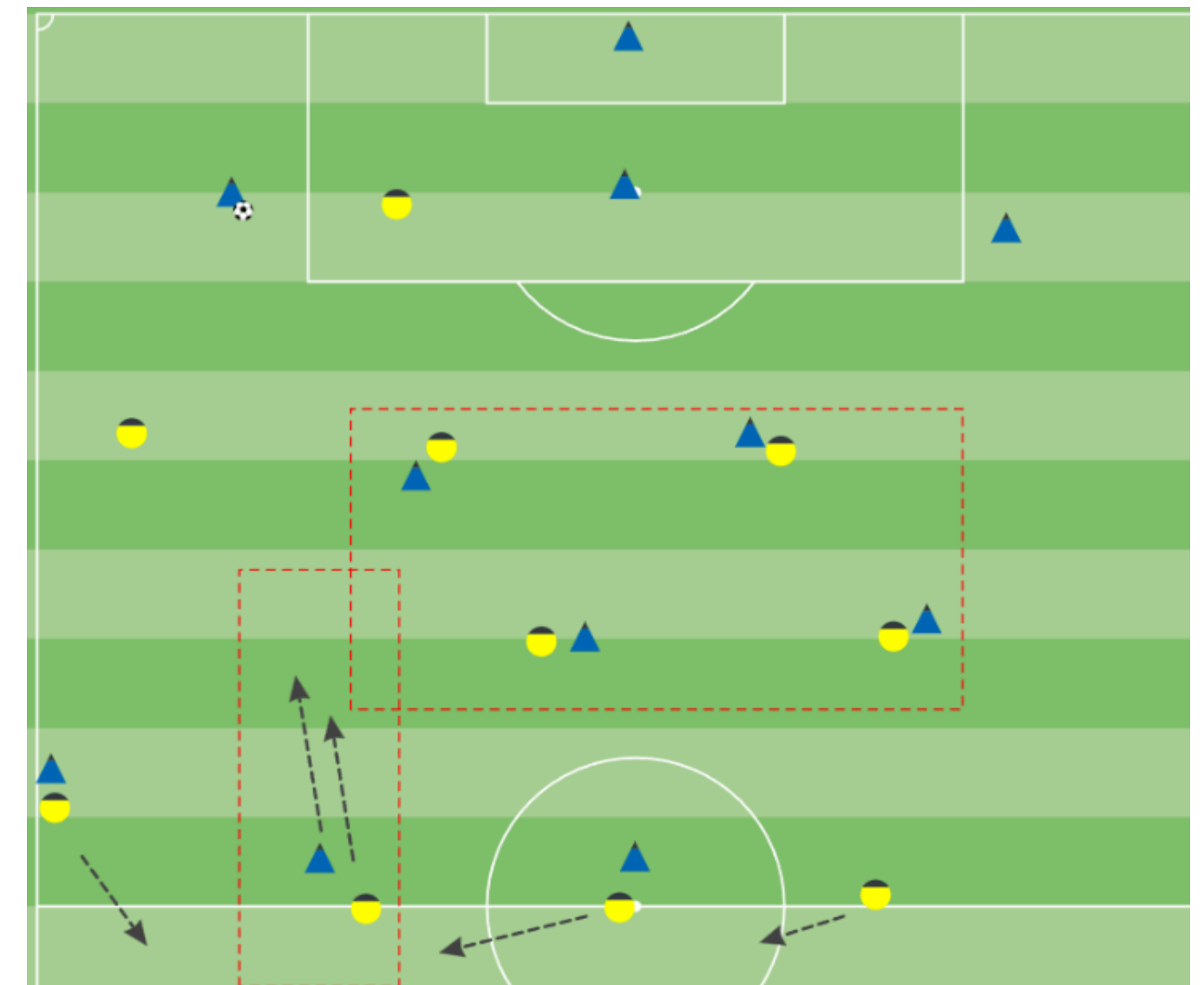
Out of Possession



Standard back four, ball played to 2/3

- 2/3 receives
- NS7/11 cuts off line
- 9 cuts off switch
- FS7/11 to central box
- 6/8 mark and press up
- NS2/3 mark half-space
- 4/5 communicate and press up

In any situation, goal is to force central and/or aerial. Midfield overloads need to be covered by NS2/3 or 4/5, depending on opponent movement. 6/8 handoff is important if player drops into midfield line.



Modern back three, ball played to 4/5 wide

- 4/5 receives
- NS7/11W cuts off line
- 9 cuts off switch
- FS7/11 to central box
- 6 or 8 aware of dropping 10/9
- 4/5 Follows dropping 10/9 into midfield
- Back 3 pinch to cover



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Out of Possession

Set Pieces

Goal Kicks - High Press with 2

- If played long, back up
- If played wide - close player cuts off, far player drops to 6 in box, high trap engaged.

Our Corners - High Press to Trap Opponent

- Rest Defense of 4 and 5 and 1 6/8 and 1 2/3 prevent counter attacks
- Immediate recovery into usual high-pressing zones for each player

Free Kicks

- Treat like Goal Kicks - bait into short, then trap

During Play

Pass Back to GK

- If Pivots are in Attacking Half - Press

Other Triggers for Press

- 2/3 turns back from pressure to pass to 4/5 or 1
- 6/8 turns back from pressure to pass to 4/5 or 1
- Opponent Switches Play Across Back Line Twice
- Second Ball is lost and opponent passes back
- Striker Senses Opportunity (Communicate)

Pressing is game state dependent, see section 5

Vertical Space Compression



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Out of Possession

Organization

High to Low means that when the high-press is broken, the team retreats immediately into a low block.

This means:

- Forward Line of 2 at midfield or base of circle
- Midfield Line of 4 between area and circle
- Back line of 4 at the top of the area

Nearest player to the ball is responsible for slowing the play down and allowing teammates to recover.

See Page 20 for Diagram

The **Mentality** of the Recovery is Important

The high press/trap does not work all the time. If one player is out of position, everyone will have to retreat. It is critical that the nearest player delays, and the team resets into their **ZONES** first.

When we are on defense, we are always looking to win the ball back. We want to force the opponent backwards, into safe areas for us, and together force them into playing risky passes that we have a high chance of winning.

But we cannot try to win the ball first - no diving or jumping in. Priority one is delay and force back, be in a good disciplined shape, then jump on loose touches or passes.



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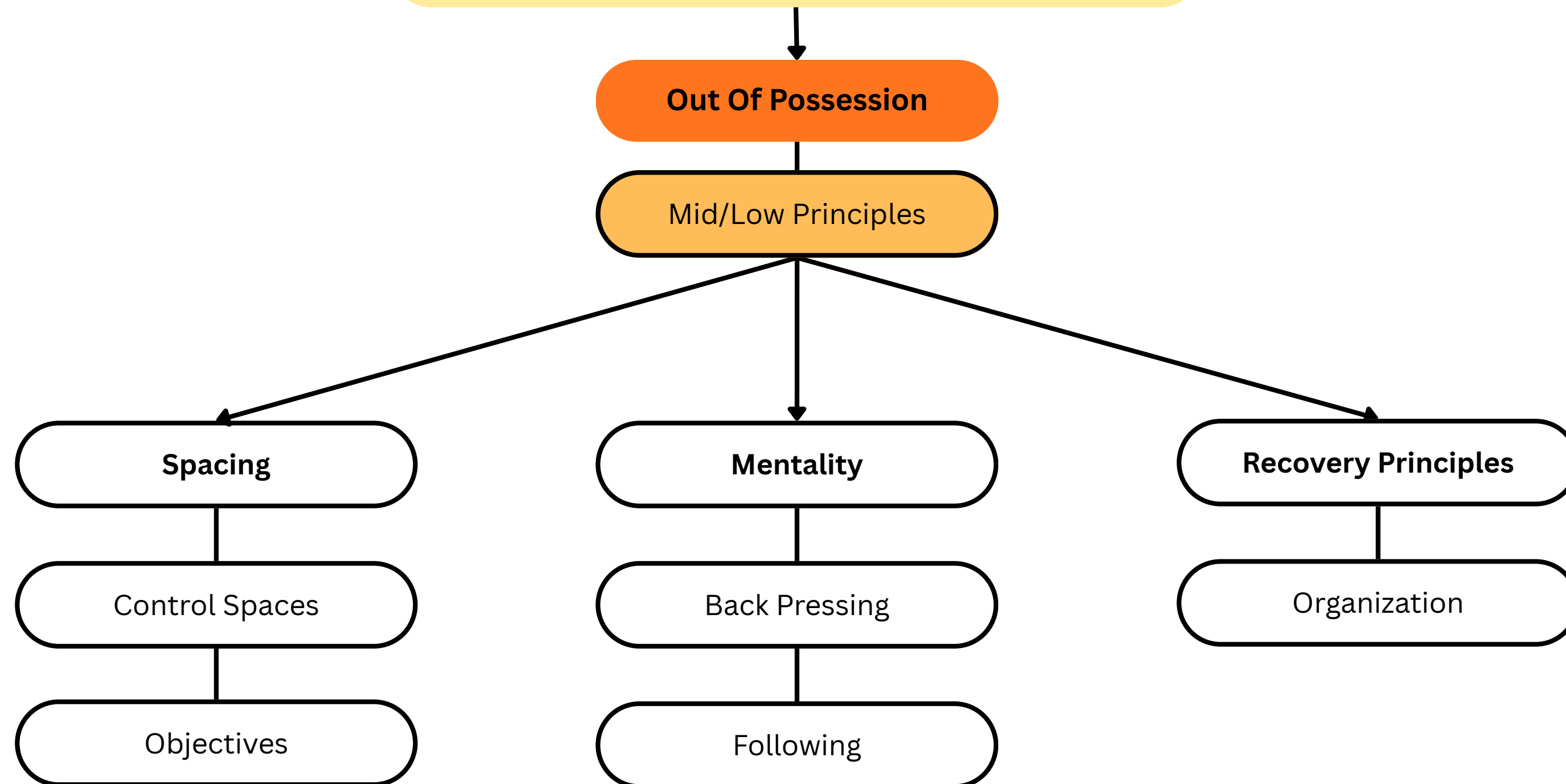
Set Pieces

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Out of Possession

Player Centered Game Model





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Mid/Low Principles

Spacing 1

Mentality

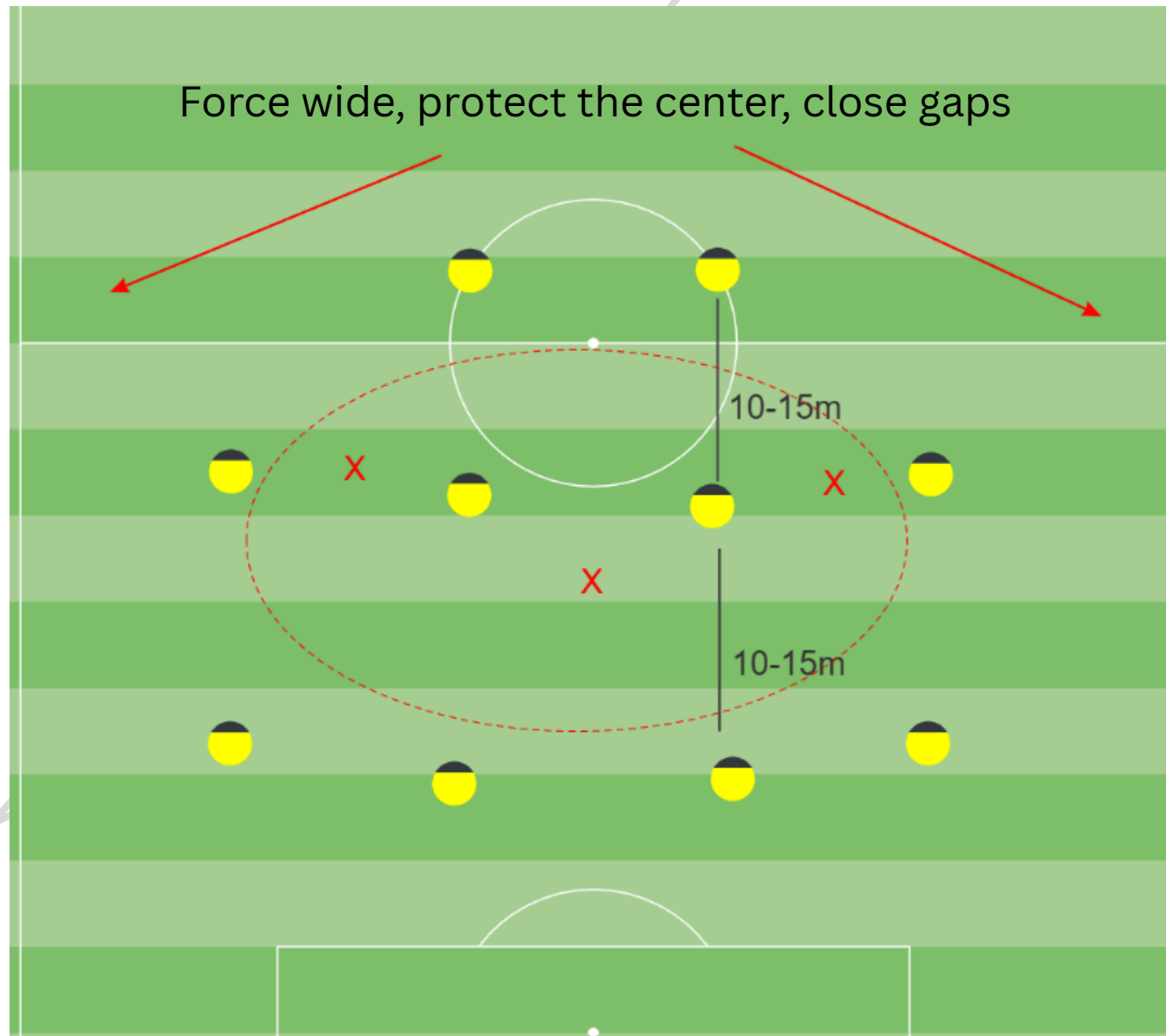
Recovery Principles

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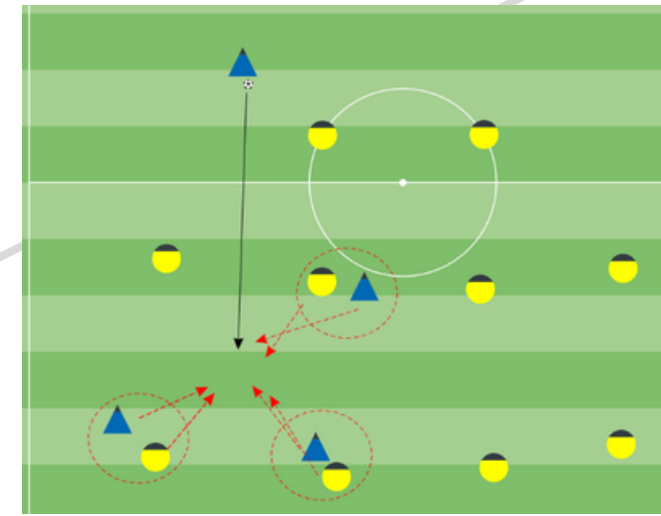
Out of Possession

Control Spaces

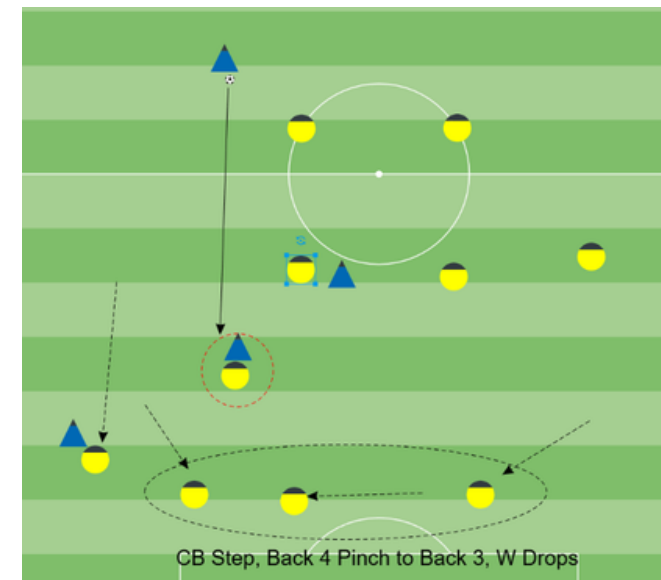
Objectives



Protect Red Zone Gaps, Rotate and Communicate



Protect Half-Space Gap



Shift to Back 3 if CB Steps

- Force Backward into Opp Half
- Condense Shape and Force Wide
- Keep Vertical Distances
- Aggressive Zonal Coverage
- COMMUNICATE about players rotating through half-space zones
 - Opp 7/11 Inverts - 2/3
 - Opp 10/9 Drops - 4/5
 - Opp 8/10 Forward - 6/8
- Pressure/Cover/Communicate
- Force Long Shots and Crosses, Fight without Fouling



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Mid/Low Principles

Spacing 2

Mentality

Recovery Principles

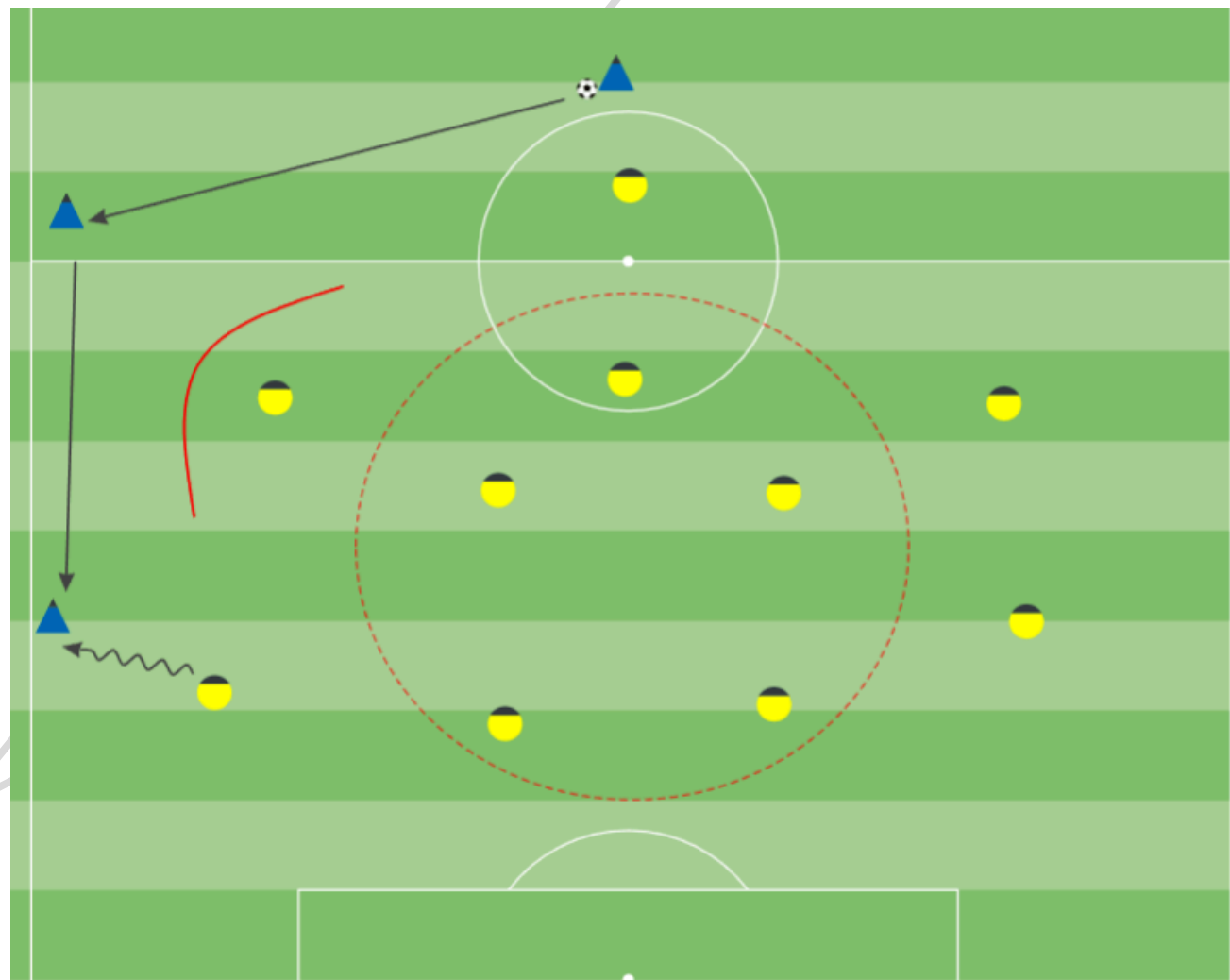
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Out of Possession

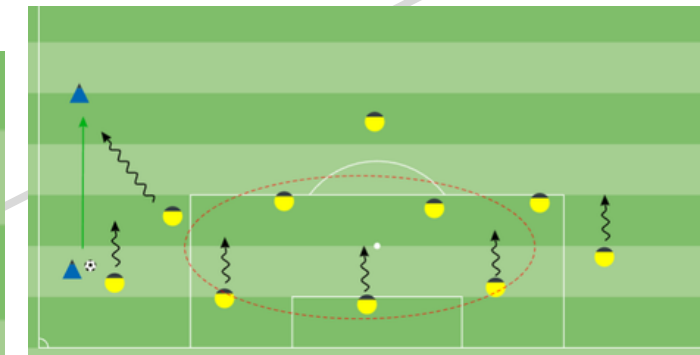
Control Spaces (2)

Objectives (same)

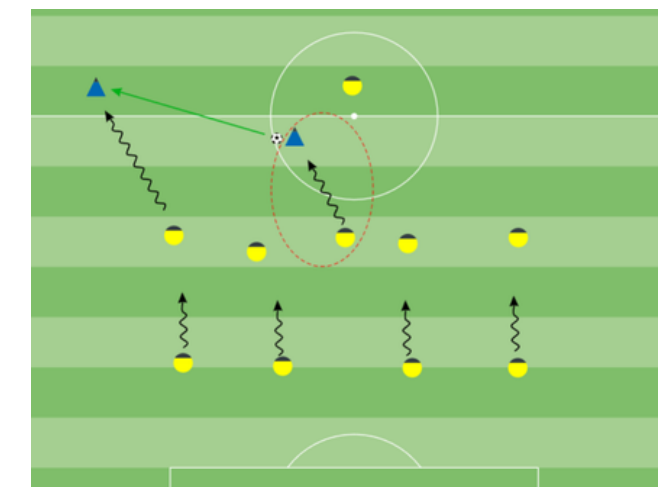
Force wide, protect the center, close gaps



Drop 10 between 6/8 to create 4-5-1
Protect core, force wide, aggressive 2/3



Force Pass Backwards
Team Step on Every Drop Pass



From 4-5-1, 10 very
aggressive centrally.
Every pass back, team
steps

- Force Backward into Opp Half
- Condense Shape and Force Wide
- Keep Vertical Distances
- Aggressive Zonal Coverage
- COMMUNICATE about players rotating through half-space zones
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Spacing

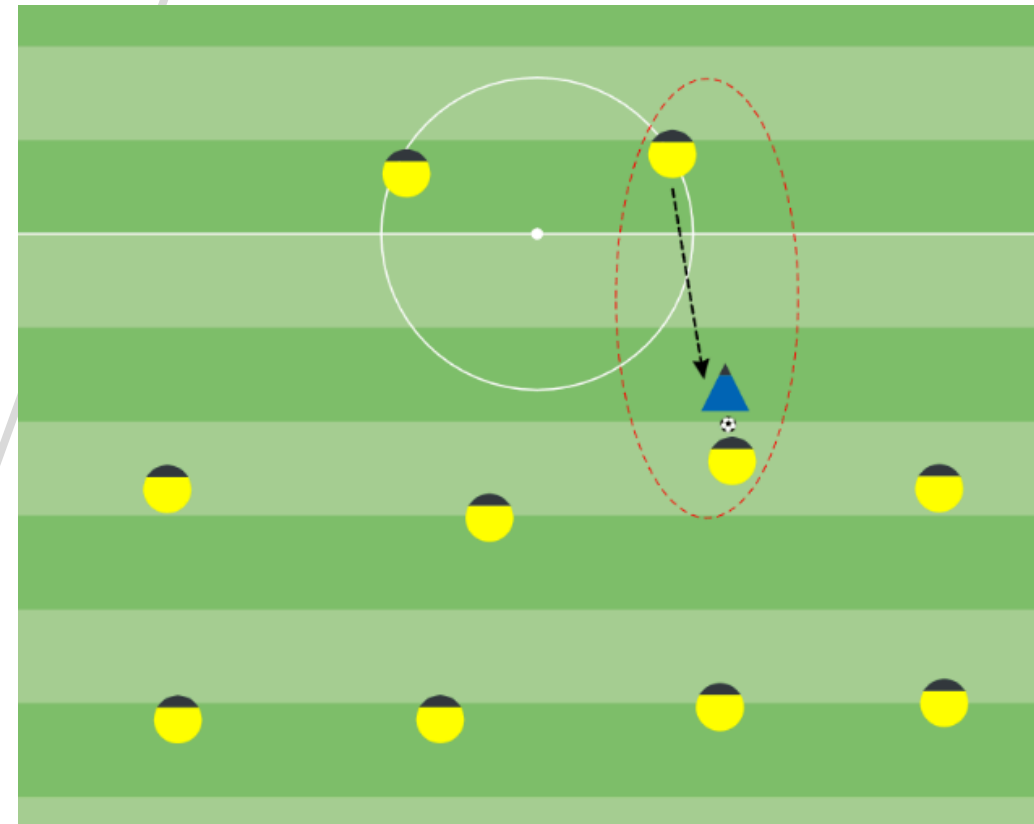
Mentality

Recovery Principles

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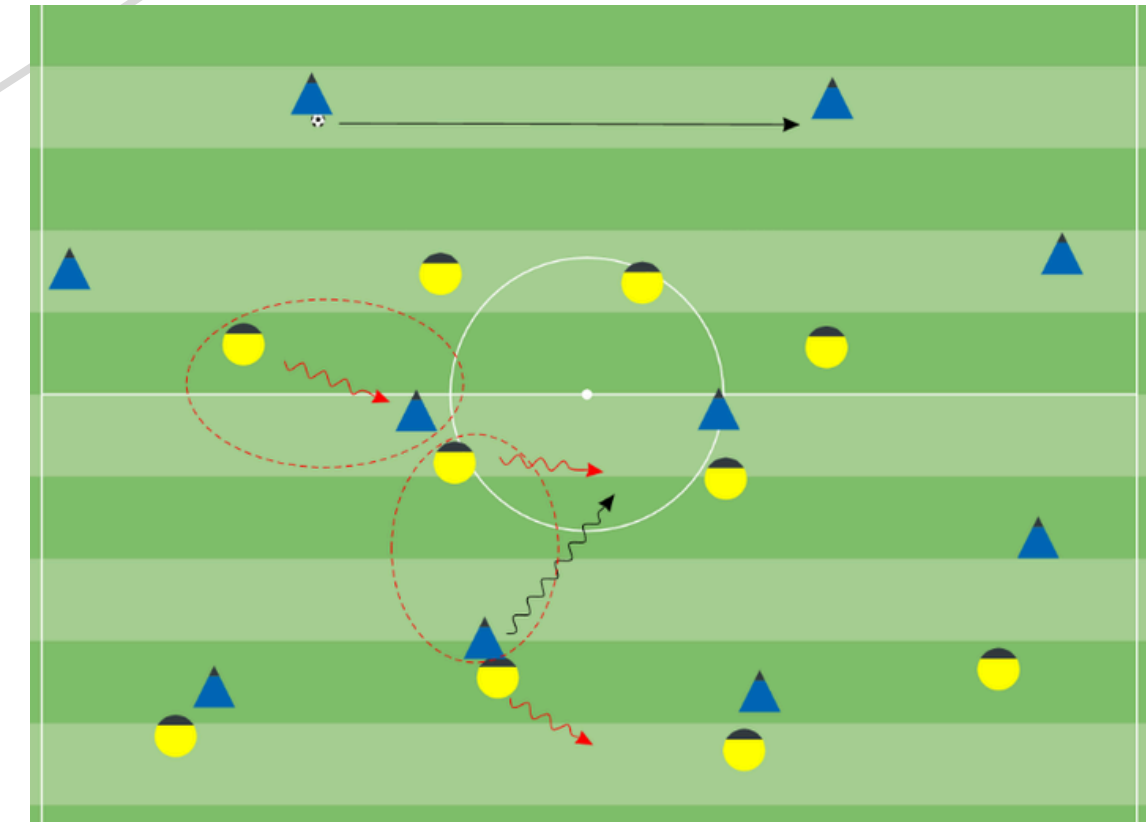
Out of Possession

Back Pressing



When you are ahead of the ball, backpress with intent. Leave free players back, try to win possession and allow back pass if they can

Following



When the opponent shifts the ball from side to side, rotations will occur into and out of zones. The team needs to communicate and hand players off when they enter your zone instead of following them around the field. In the example above, the opp 10 drops - our 4/5 hands to 6/8, the FS7/11 compresses to cover FS6/8, releasing our FS6/8 to cover dropping 10.



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Mid/Low Principles

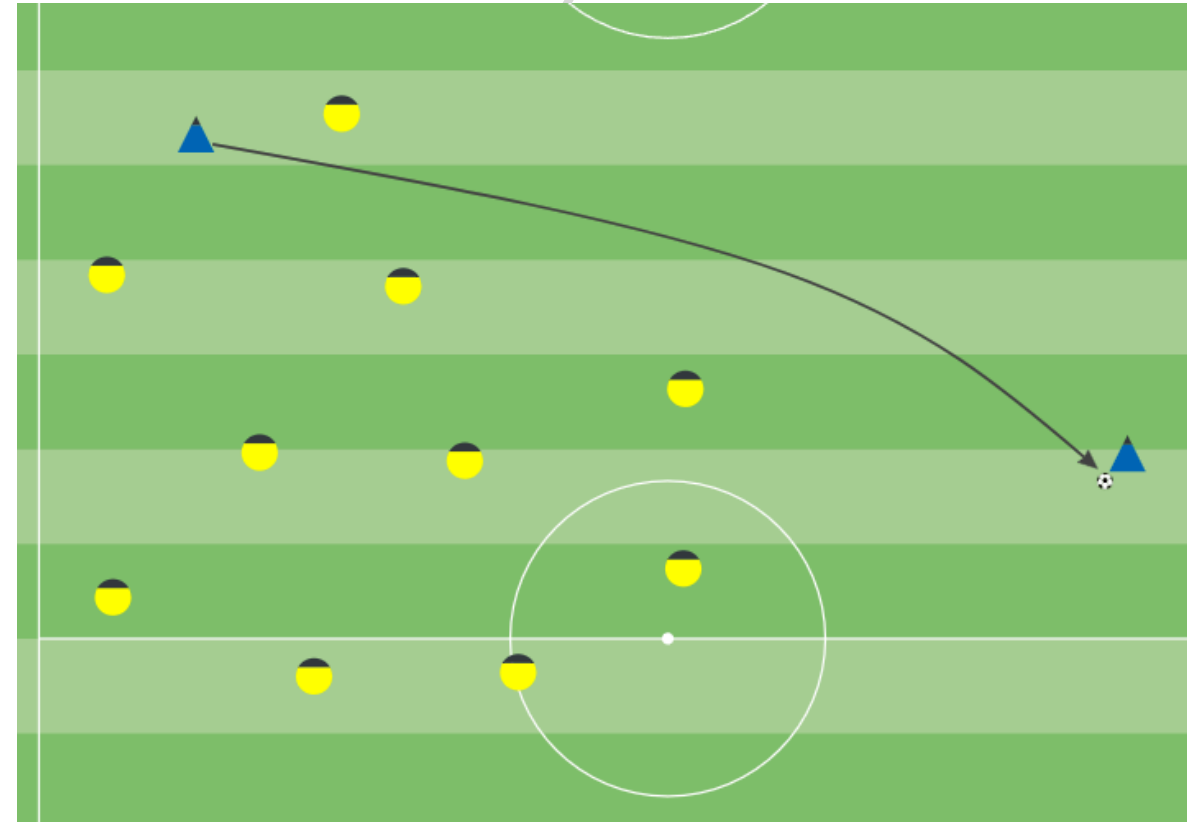
Spacing

Mentality

Recovery Principles

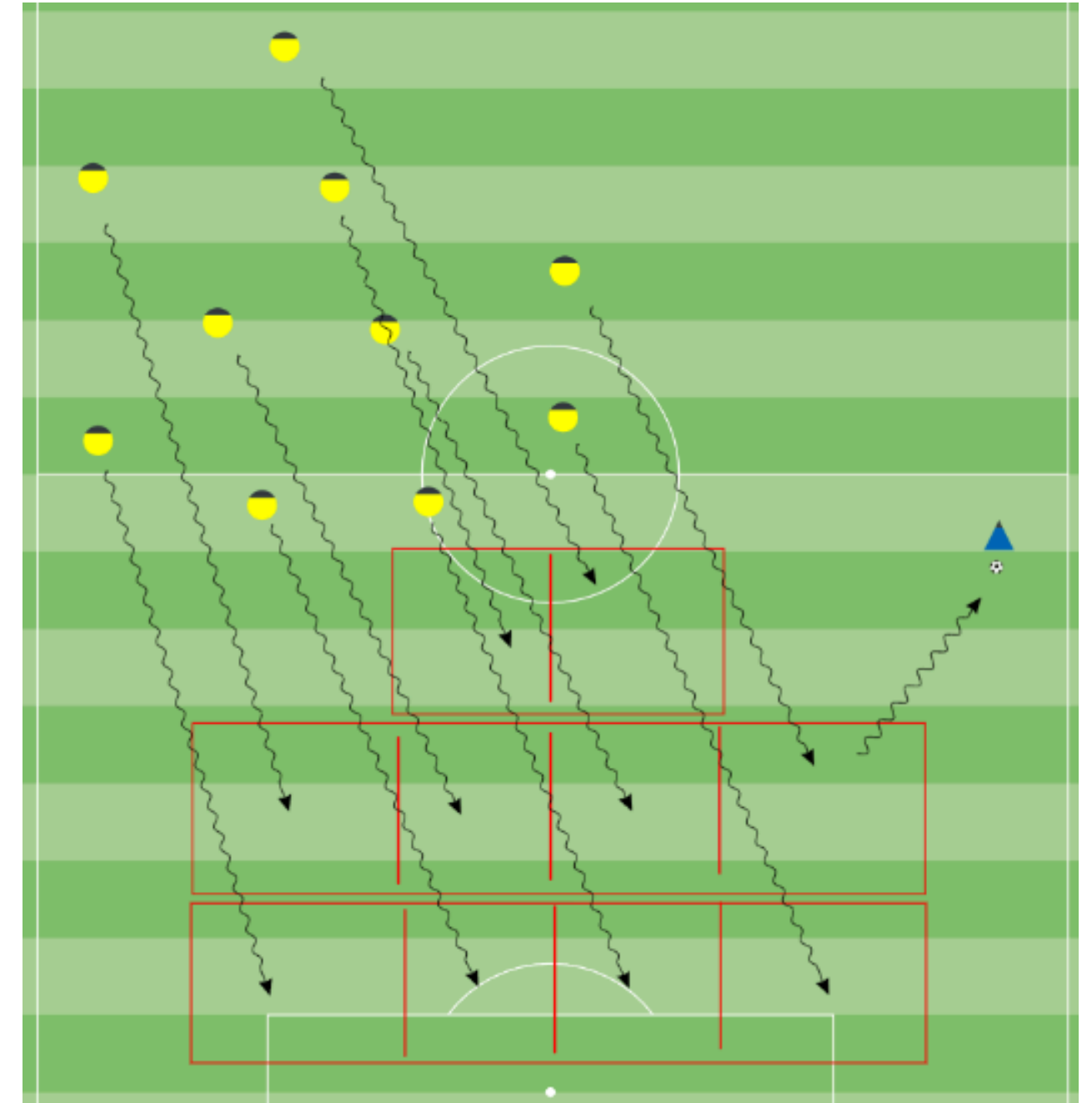
CE Altafulla 2026/2027 Out of Possession

Organization



These traps can be vulnerable to long switches of play. After the press is broken, it is important to recover as a unit into our LOW BLOCK zones. First, recover zonally, then pick up your man, then apply low-block pressure from our 4-4-2.

See Page 15 for Mentality





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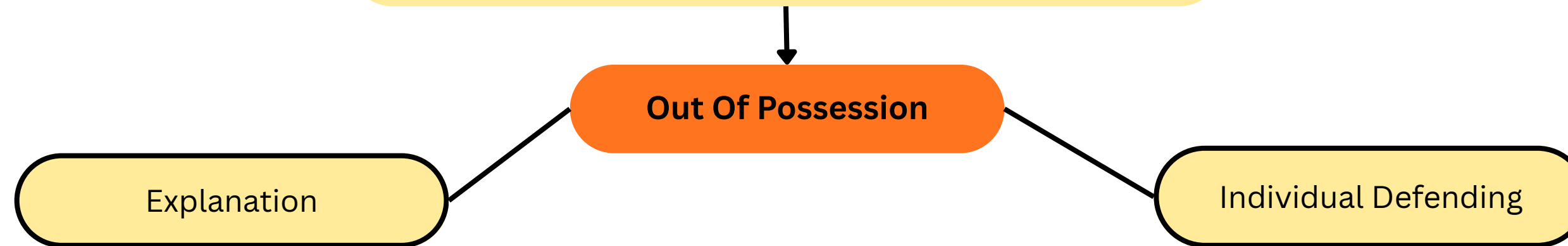
Set Pieces

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Out of Possession

Player Centered Game Model



Our team does not “DEFEND” solely to protect our goal. At all times we want to regain possession of the ball. We look to control spaces and force the opponent into situations where the odds of winning the ball are higher - the center of the pitch when we have numbers, aerial balls, or forcing crosses/long shots in our half.

At all times we work together. We condense the vertical and horizontal distances, communicate clearly about marks and pressure/cover, and are extremely aggressive within our zones.

We always have an idea of the objective in mind. Up high, we want to force the opponent into quick decisions and risky ball movement. In midfield, we want to force them backwards and away from our goal.

Down low, we want to force them into low-percentage crosses and shots, or backwards away from our goal.

1 - EYES

- Our main focus when applying pressure is to force the opponent's eyes to drop to the ball. As quickly as possible, we need to get close enough to force them to look away from the field.

2 - POSITION

- Once their eyes are down, our focus is not on winning possession. We want to dictate where they go and what they do. This depends on where they are on the field.
 - Up high, we want to force them into pressure. Usually central or back, never down the line.
 - In Midfield, we want to force them backward
 - Down low, we want to force them wide and away from our goal

3 - BALL

- Once we have them looking down and moving how we want, we pounce when we are able. A loose touch, an indecisive moment, we get in between them and the ball and use our physicality to hold possession.



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In Possession

Player Centered Game Model

In Possession

Low Build Principles

1 Pressure

2 Pressure

Full Pressure

High Build Principles

Shift to Back 3

Invert/Shift

Combinations/Rotations

Direct Principles

Width and Support

2nd Ball Positioning

Spacing

Finishing Principles

Numbers in Area

Support/Aggression

Shape Behind Play



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In Possession

Player Centered Game Model



In Possession

Objective:

We want to possess the ball into the final third with control. We are pragmatic - we can play direct behind the line into space if needed, we can find and create space with ball and player movement, or we can combine into dangerous areas. We are always looking to possess the ball in the final third.

Every time we possess the ball, anywhere on the field, we should have an idea of how we are going to possess the ball into the final third. We are not in a hurry. If the space exists behind the line and we are in a position to exploit it, do so. If the space does not exist, or we are not in a good position to take advantage of it, we can be patient and possess the ball. Switch the field, reset, combine, draw opponent out, whatever we need to do to possess the ball up high.

Get the ball. Keep the ball. Be dangerous.



Player Centered Game Model

In Possession

Deciding to Build or Play Direct:

Long Pass Triggers (GK or Defensive Line)

- Man marking (is opponent 1v1 everywhere?)
- Over-aggressive shifts (are they cutting off the switch and forcing us into dangerous areas?)
- High line w/ no pressure on keeper (are they allowing/baiting passes to 4/5 or 6/8 with no pressure until after pass?)

Short Pass Triggers (GK or Defensive Line)

- No pressure on the ball (mid block)
 - Pressure leaving +1 advantage (do we outnumber them in our third, even with pressure?)
- Poor discipline (can we see they are not aligned in press or drop?)

Post - Pass Actions

After a Long Pass/Direct Ball

- 7/11 pinch in
- Surround the receiver on 4 sides w/ 2 back (striker long, winger sides, pivots behind)
- Defensive line moves forward to midfield to condense space (as a unit!)

After a short pass

- 4/5 Split wide
- 2/3/7/11 Hug Touchlines
- Staggered Midfield Spacing (look for gaps and pockets)

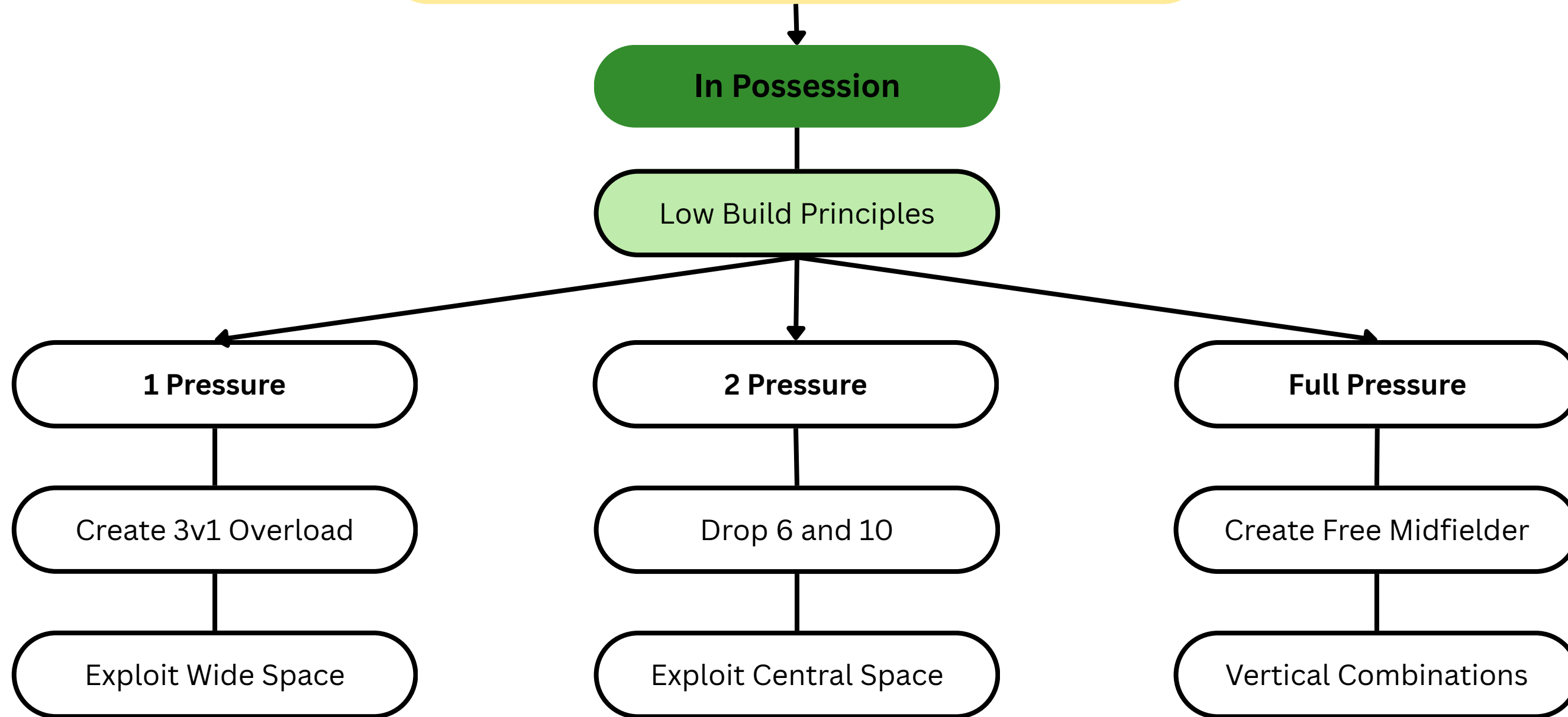
Goal here is for playing on the ground, breaking lines, vertical/diagonal passes. Combination play to get into pockets, always looking to draw opponent in and exploit space behind.



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Player Centered Game Model





Player Centered Game Model

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In Possession

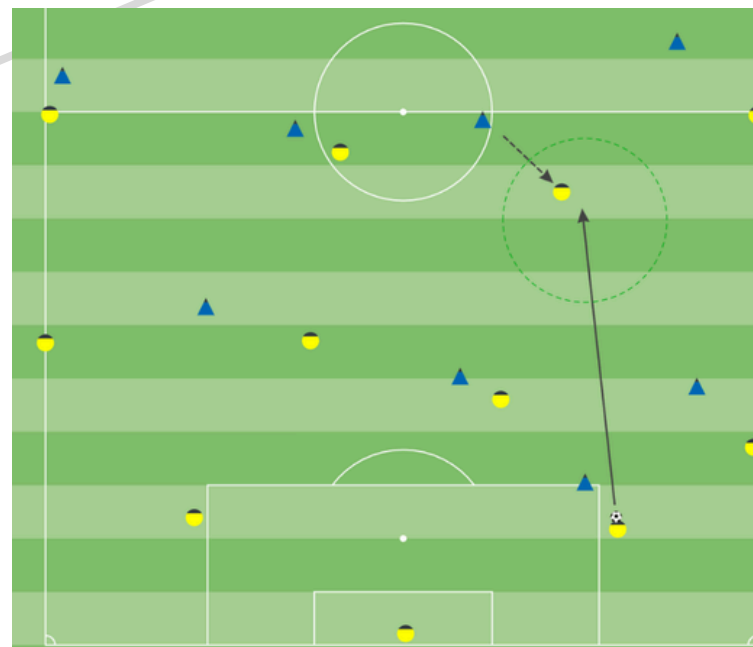
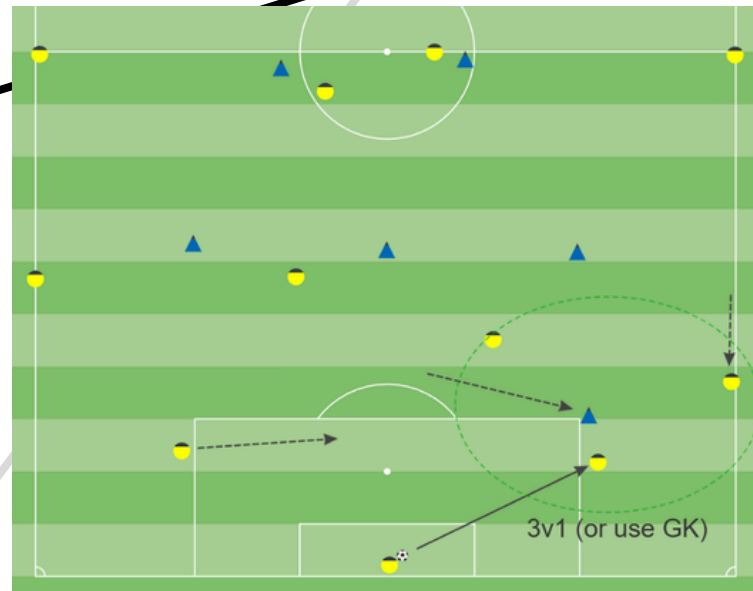
Low Build Principles

1 Pressure

2 Pressure

Full Pressure

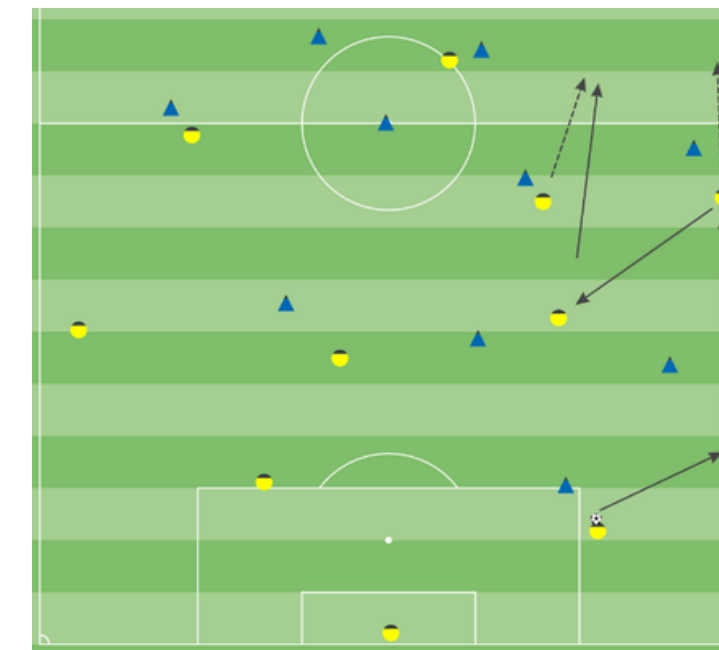
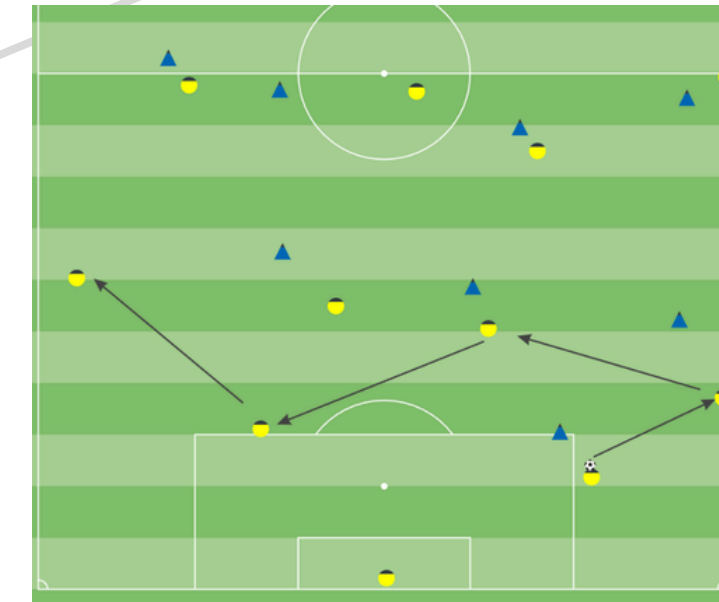
Create 3v1 Overload



- With 1 Press, we spread and create an easy 3v1.
- 4/5, 2/3, 6/8 or 4/5, 2/3, 1
- From base 3v1, we move the ball until space opens in front.
- Midfield rotations are key

One example of a solution is the 9 or 10 dropping from forward line in red zone space. Line-splitting pass played forward. This he can drop to 6/8, play wide to 7/11, or turn with 9/10.

Exploit Wide Space



With our width and 1 pressing high, it may be tough to find space on 1 side. Utilize the width to draw opponent to 1 side, then switch quickly to exploit space on the other

If possible, combination play up one side to quickly try and exploit space behind the opponent back line. At any point in the ladder, a reset/switch is possible. Off-ball movement key.



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In Possession

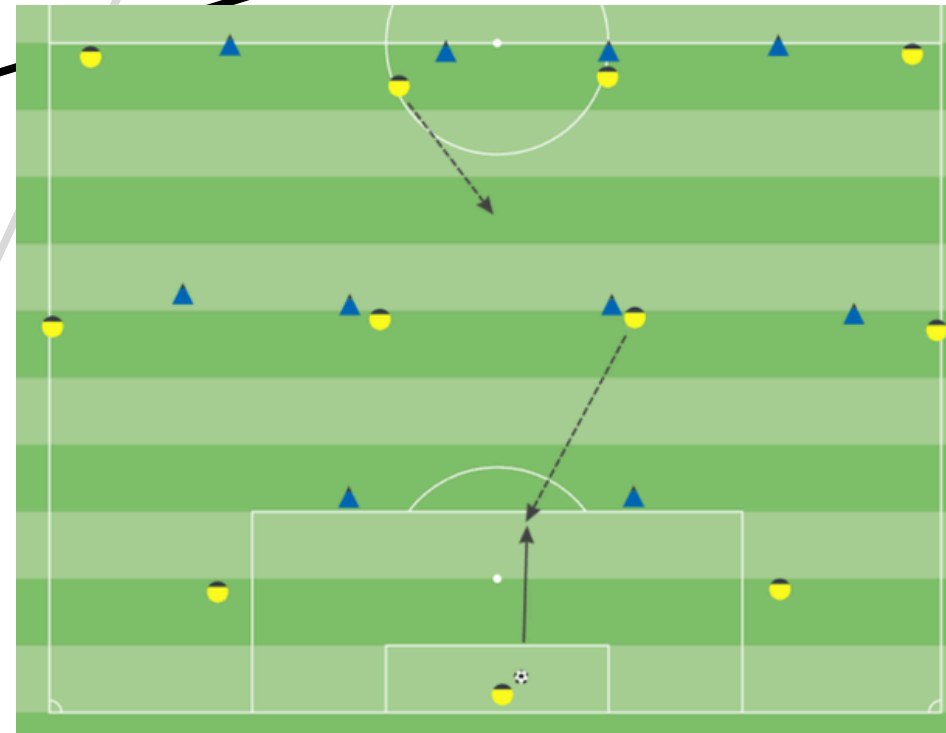
Low Build Principles

1 Pressure

2 Pressure

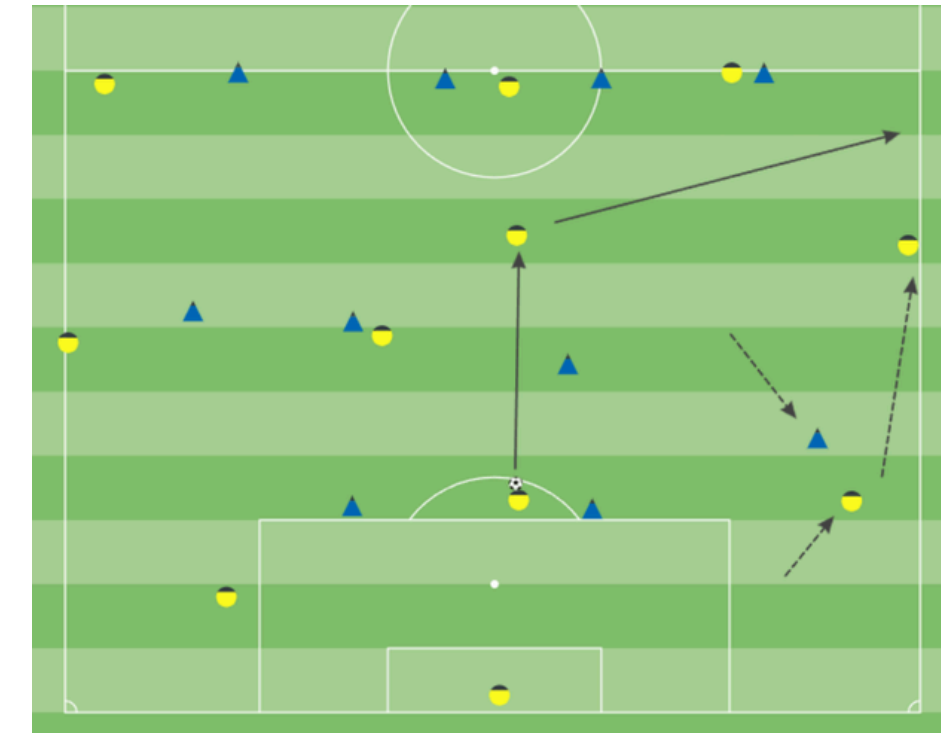
Full Pressure

Drop 6 and 10



If the opponent presses with 2, we drop our 6 between the 4/5 to create 4 vs 2 (incl 1). The opponent will step forward, and with our 4/5 split and 2/3 stepping high, there is space to exploit. Our 10 drops into the pocket, FS7/11 is an option to step central and overload, and we have options.

Exploit Central Space



From the center, with our 9/10 dropping into the zone, we can combine with 6/8 or we can turn and play the overlapping 2/3 from that central area. Playing through the center forces opponent to collapse structure, leaving space to exploit.



Player Centered Game Model

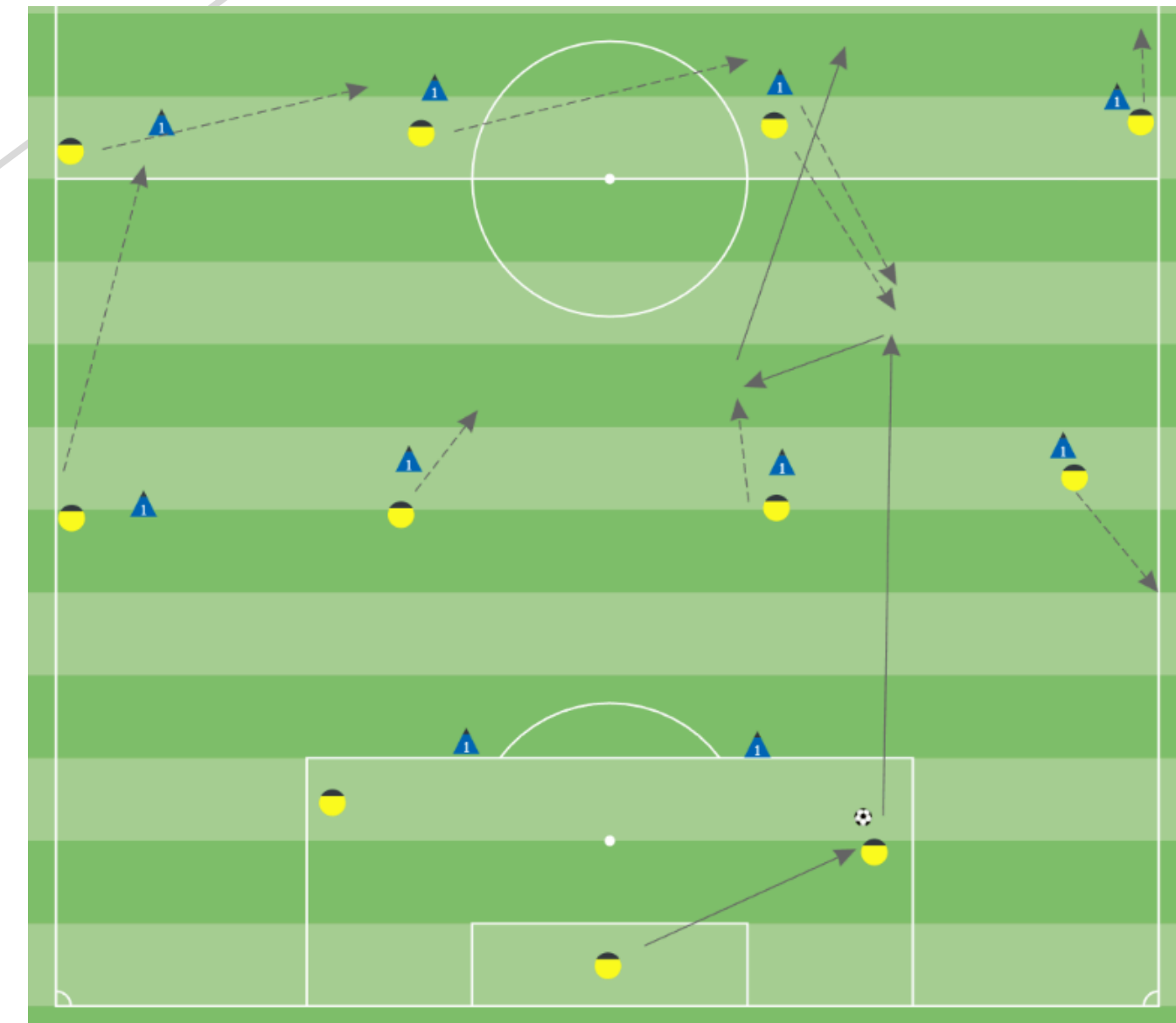
Create Free Midfielder

Vertical Combinations

High Pressure will leave gaps between opponent defensive line and midfield line. We set up with front 4, then we drop near side central attacker into the hole, while other attacker runs into space. Near side wide players create space. Pass through lines, drops to pivot, sends forward into space for overload.

Alternative option - after the drop to the pivot, switch to far side where far side winger has inverted and far side fullback pushes into space for 2v1 overload behind the line.

Far side pivot also an option for switching play. Key is that long pass through lines to dropping attacker.



In Possession

Low Build Principles

1 Pressure

2 Pressure

Full Pressure

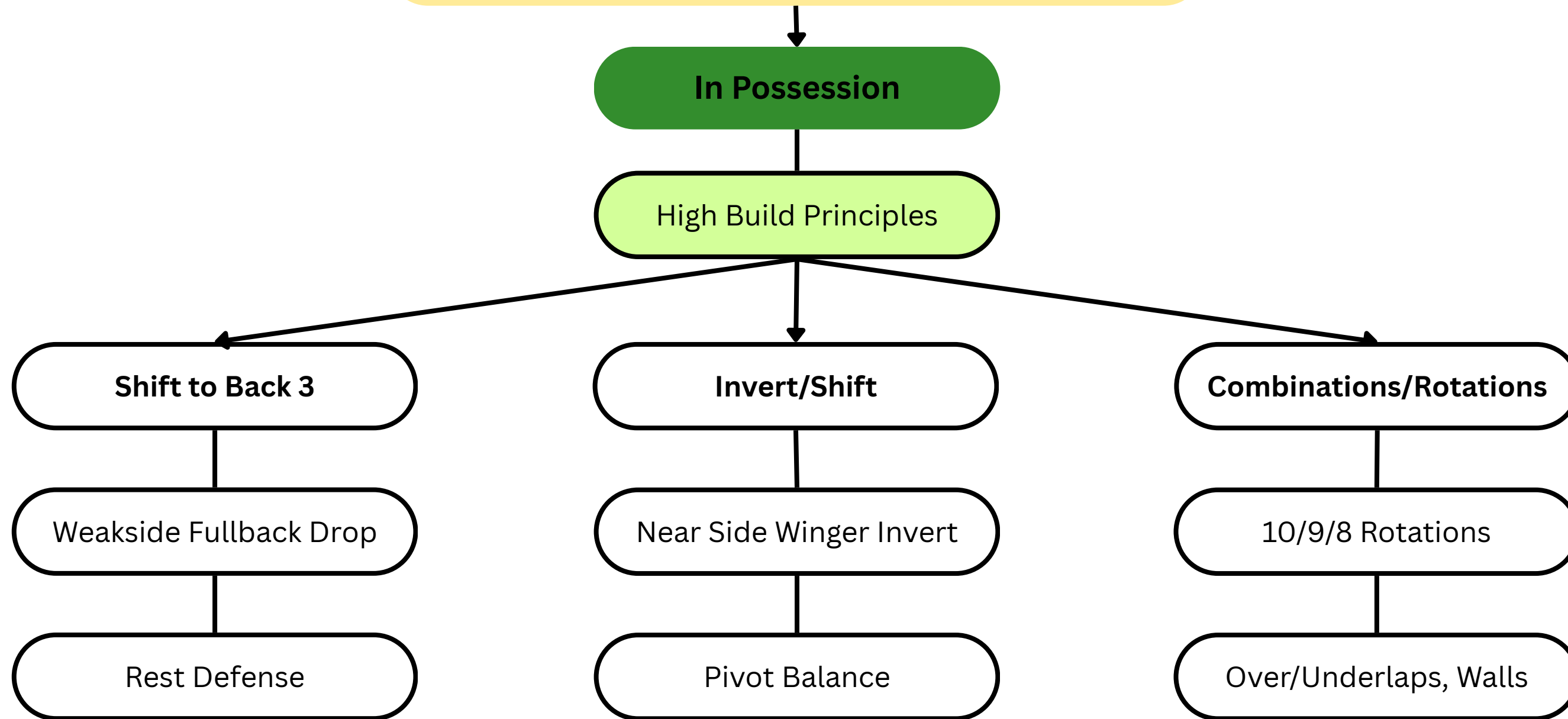
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In Possession

Player Centered Game Model





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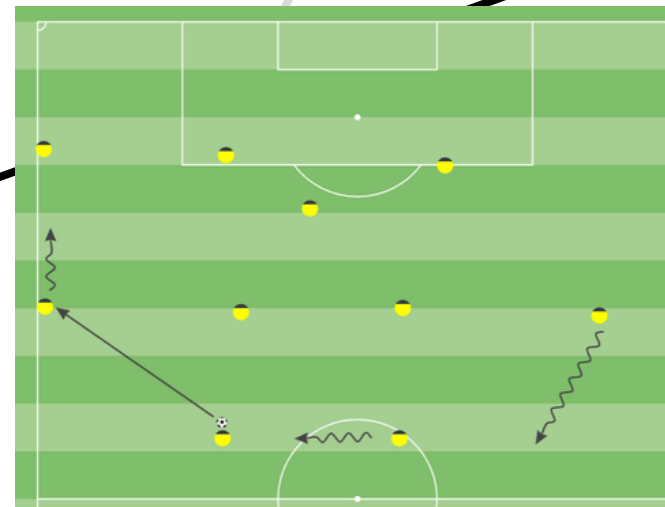
High Build Principles

Shift to Back 3

Invert/Shift

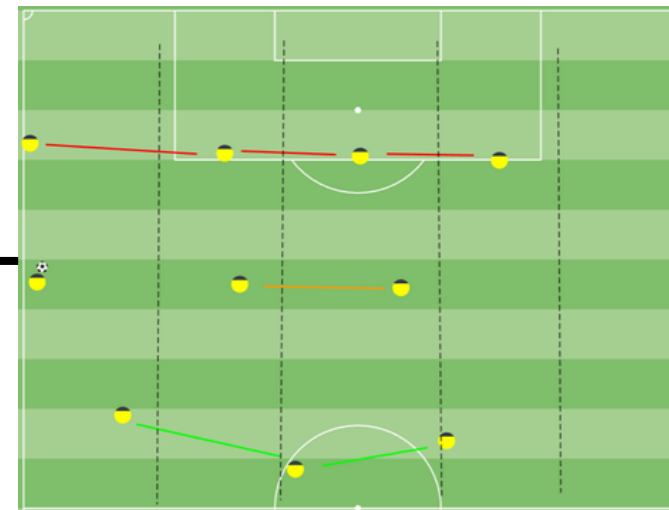
Combinations/Rotations

Weakside Fullback Drop

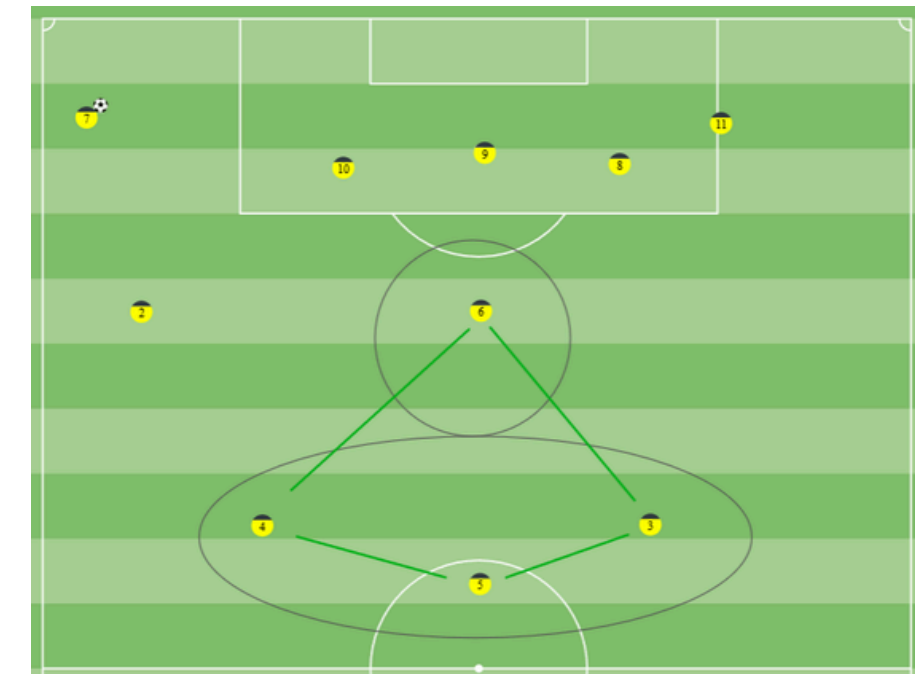


- When one 2/3 moves forward to support, WS2/3 drops in to create back 3
- NS4/5 slides to support, WS4/5 central, WS2/3 aware of space

- Build in attacking half becomes 3-2-4 with free NS2/3 moving higher to create 3-2-5 if possible
- Could also invert central to free 6/8 for attack



Rest Defense



- Important thing is to have 3-2 defensive shape, with one 6/8 central to protect central counters and force wide.
- Other 6/8 or inverted 2/3 support in central area, other joins attacking line



Player Centered Game Model

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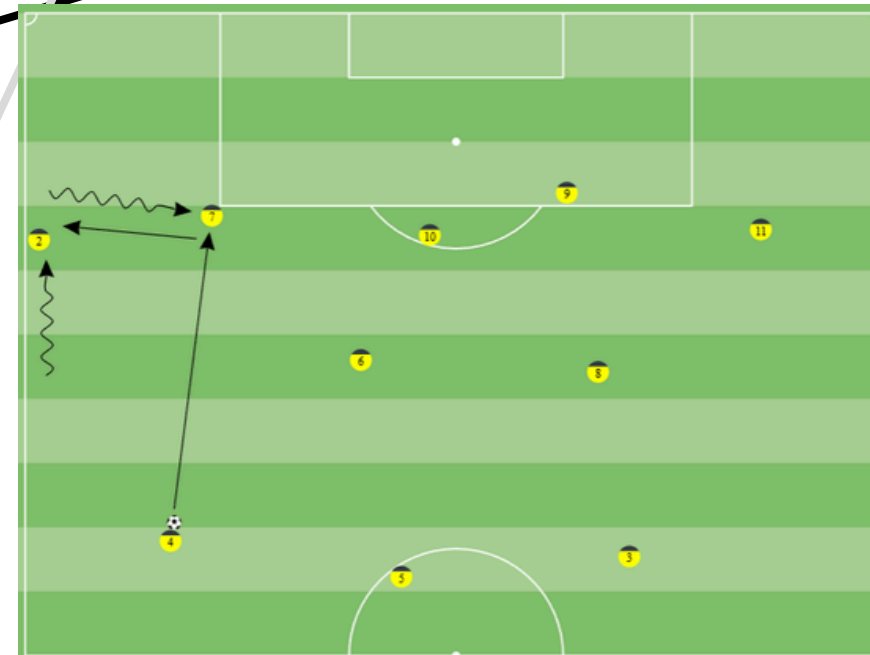
High Build Principles

Shift to Back 3

Invert/Shift

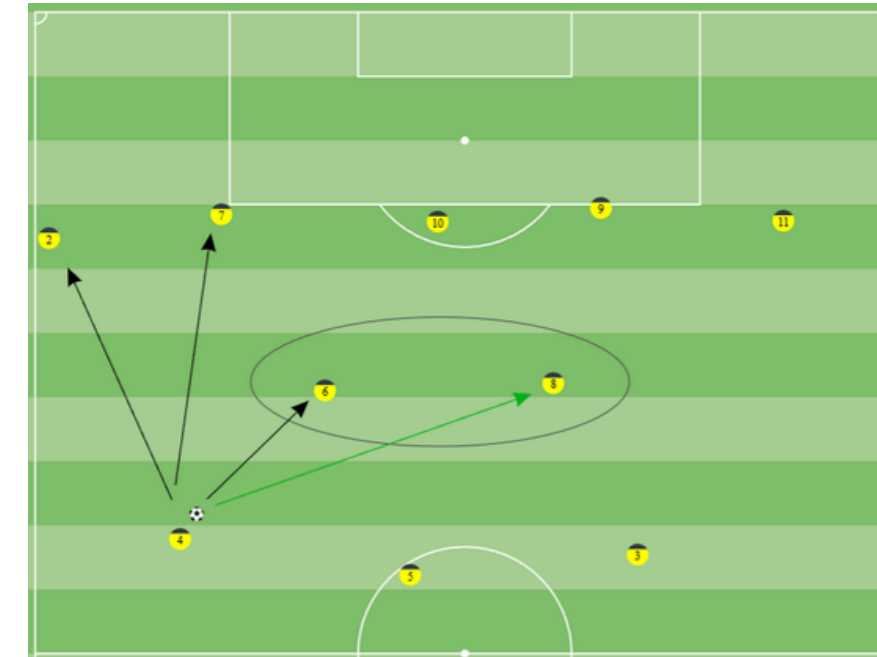
Combinations/Rotations

Near Side 7/11 Invert



- If NS2/3 overlaps, NS7/11 inverts into half-space
- 4/5 or 6/8 has multiple options
- In attacking 3rd, NS2/3 stops running forward and holds to create width.
- In mid 3rd, NS2/3 can exploit space forward

6/8 Balance



- NS6/8 needs to be an option to support NS attackers, while FS6/8 needs to stay in FS halfspace to create switch opportunity
- NS6/8 closest to move forward and join attack, FS6/8 stays for support/rest defense



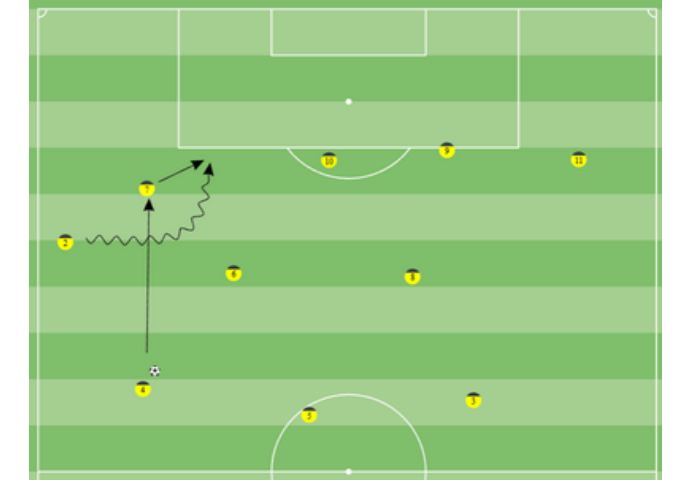
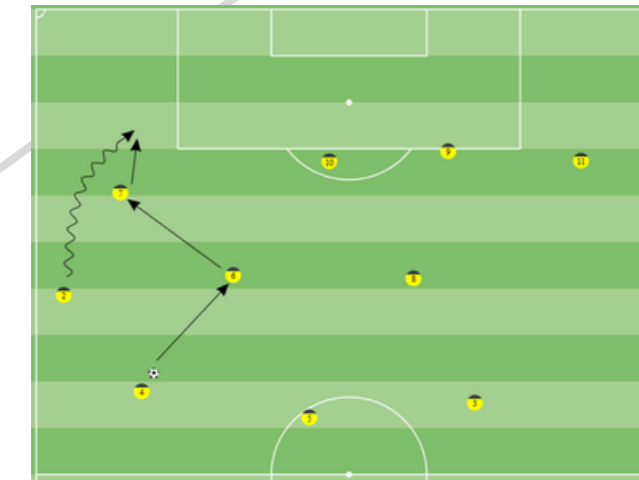
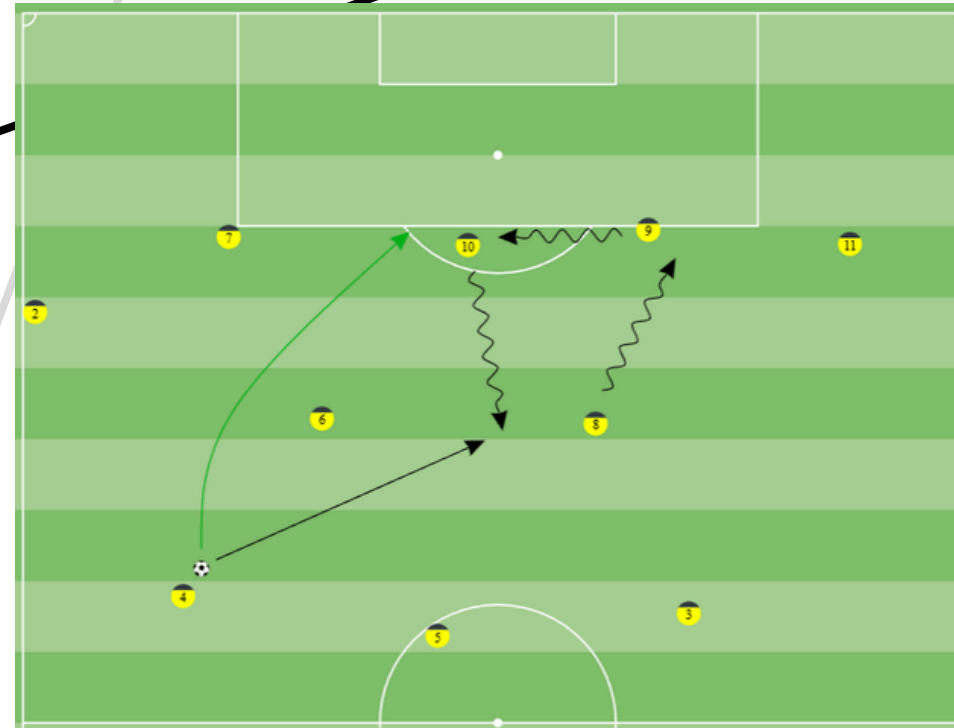
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In Possession

Player Centered Game Model

10/9/8 Rotations

Over/Underlaps, Walls



- Three central attacking options free to rotate in and out of pockets of space
- 10/9 drop easily into red zone, other covers, freeing 8 (or 6) to move forward into front line of attacking 5
- Can't be static, we need to shift and communicate to create space

- When space is limited, we use wide combinations to create space, with a central player shifting to the wide area or half space to create overloads.
- We always look to support and make unselfish runs to create space for teammates

When space behind does not exist, we create space through overloads, rotations, switches, and isolation before attacking aggressively.

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High Build Principles

Shift to Back 3

Invert/Shift

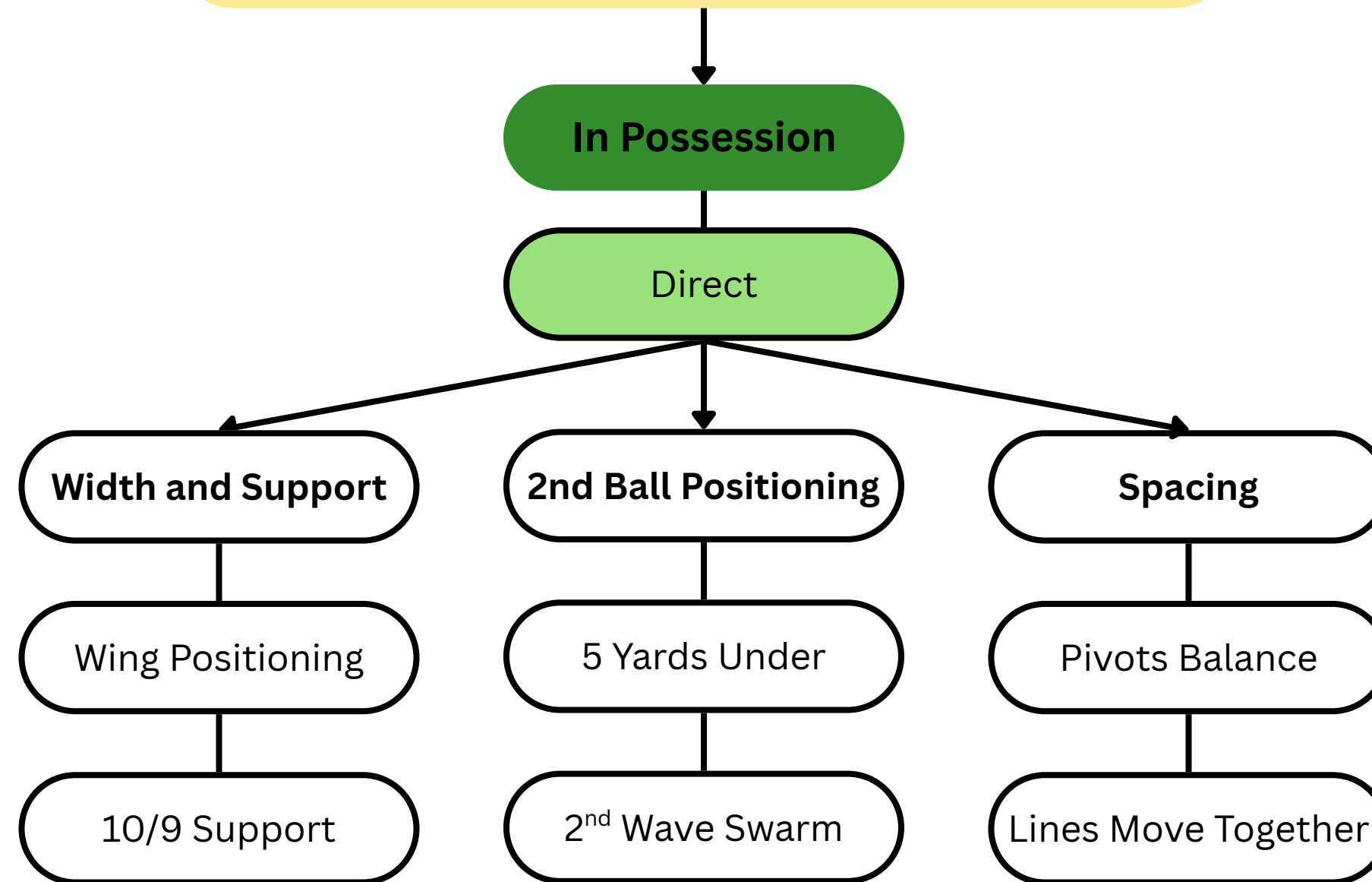
Combinations/Rotations



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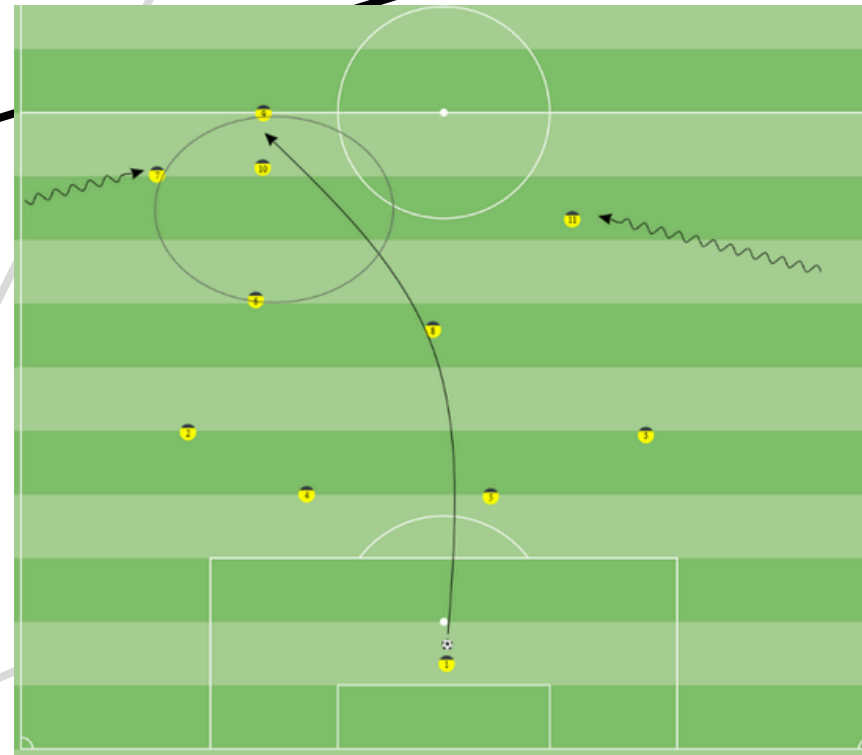
Player Centered Game Model



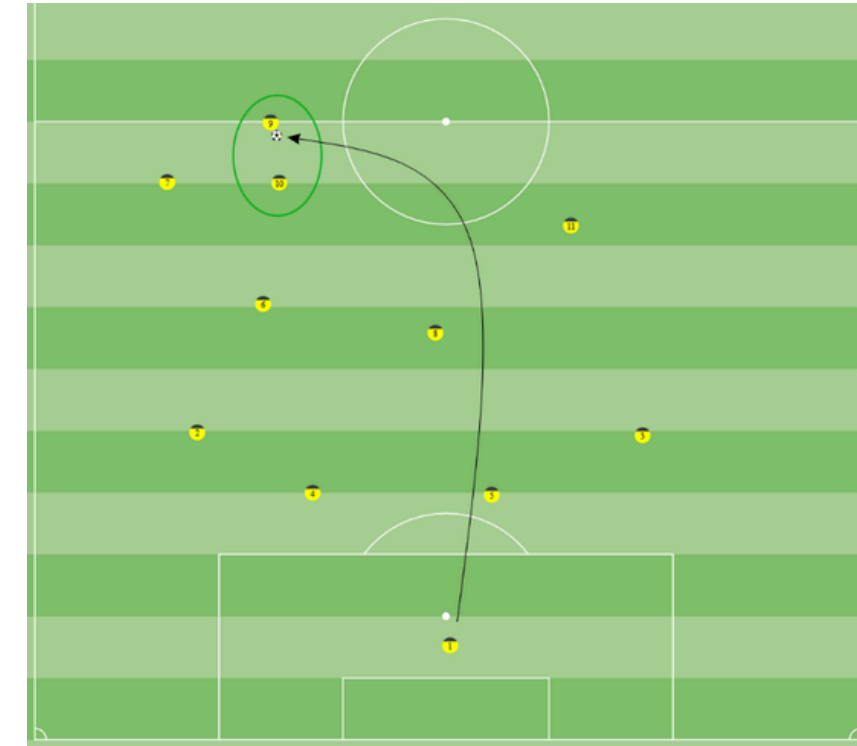


Player Centered Game Model

7/11 Positioning



10/9 Support



In Possession

Direct

Width and Support

2nd Ball Positioning

Spacing

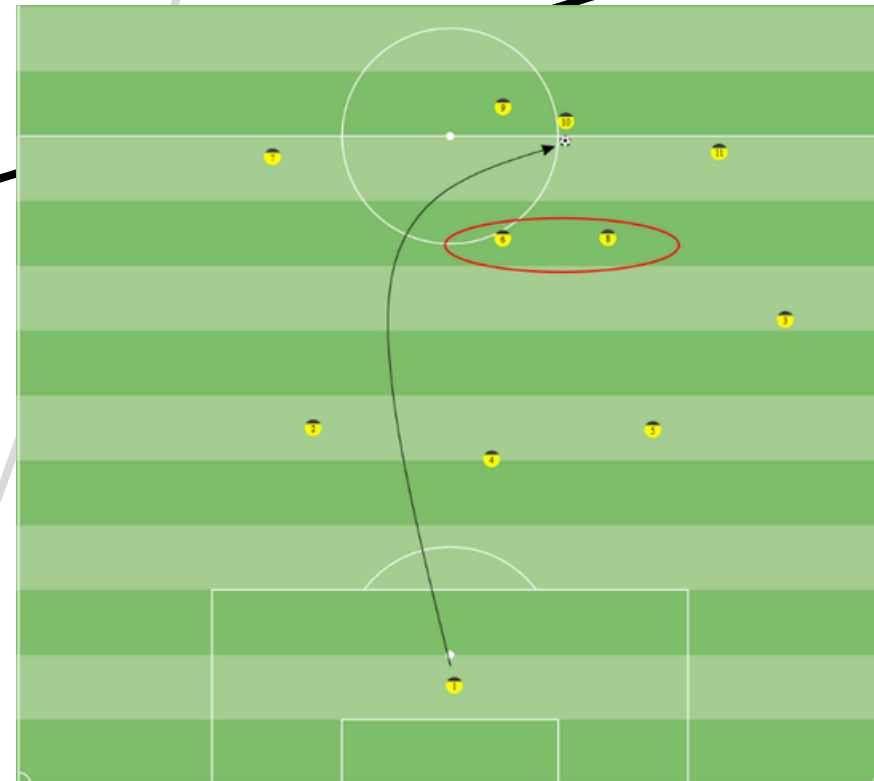
- When playing direct, the 7/11 pinch into half-space to assist with 2nd balls
- If we regain possession, immediately move wide to create space and attack through balls from wide position

- Direct balls centrally are won with both 10 and 9 combining. One attacks the ball for first touch, other slides underneath for knockdowns.
- We always touch the ball first
- We utilize 2 players to win these aerial balls - one to touch first, directly to our teammate
- We avoid flick-ons if possible



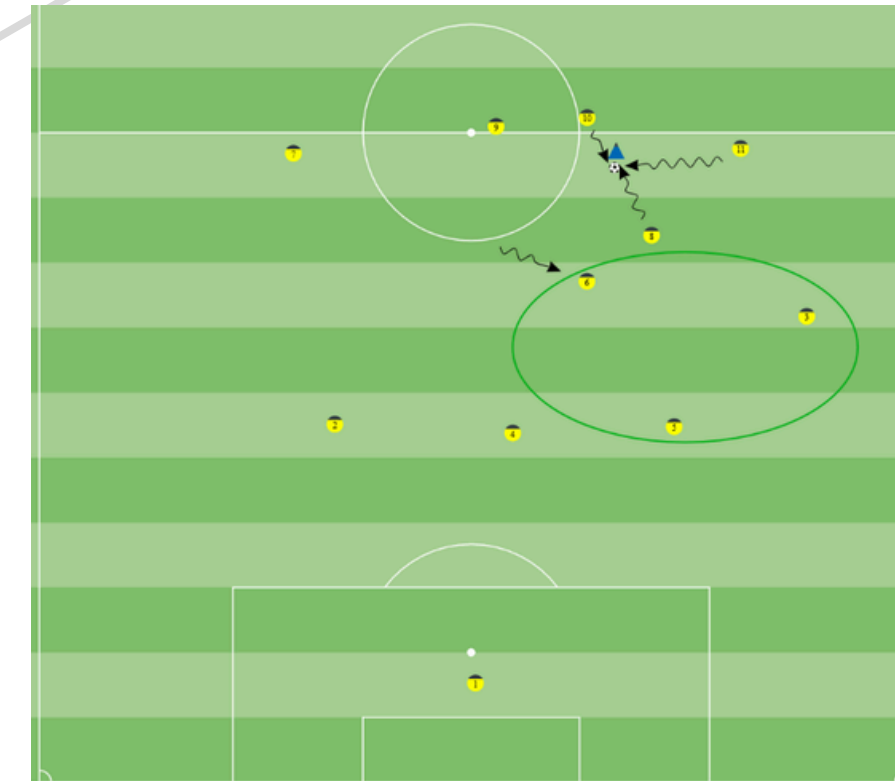
Player Centered Game Model

5 Yards Under



- It is very important to win loose aerial balls, from both teams
- We avoid flick-ons and always try to knock a ball down to our teammate
- We don't need to control the ball individually, we look to win it back as a unit

2nd Wave Swarm



- Once the loose aerial ball has been touched but is still loose, the closest 2 players swarm from underneath.
- We fight to win possession
- If not, we immediately press to force the opponent backwards so we can get into our base defense positions

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Direct

Width and Support

2nd Ball Positioning

Spacing



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Direct

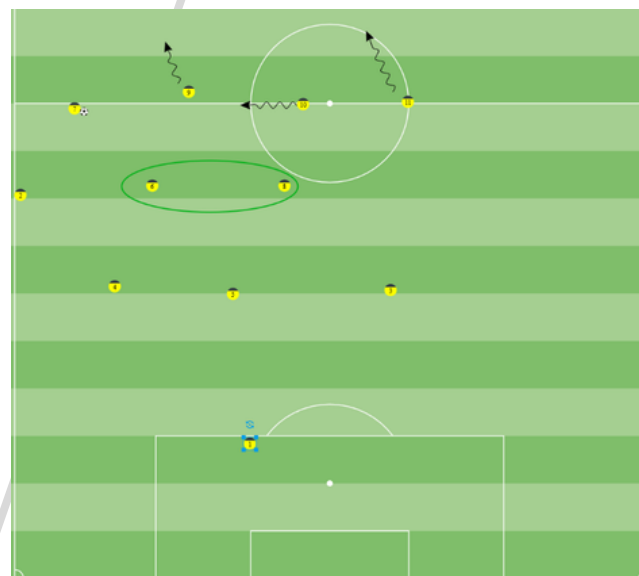
Width and Support

2nd Ball Positioning

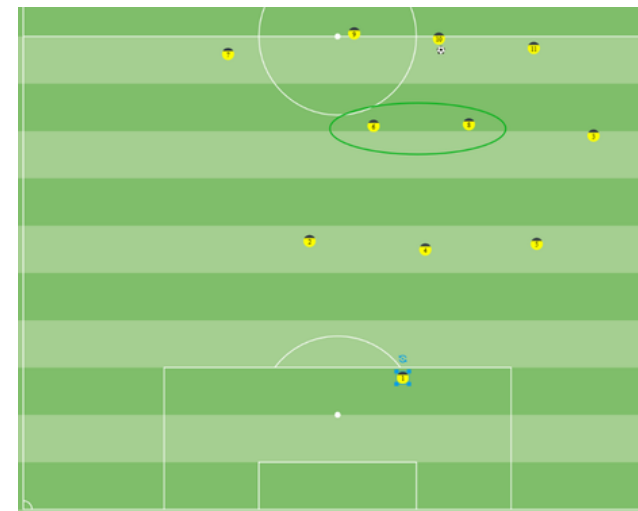
Spacing

6/8 Balance

- Direct balls require 6/8 positional discipline
- During the battle for possession after knockdown, one pivot attacks ball, other supports behind play

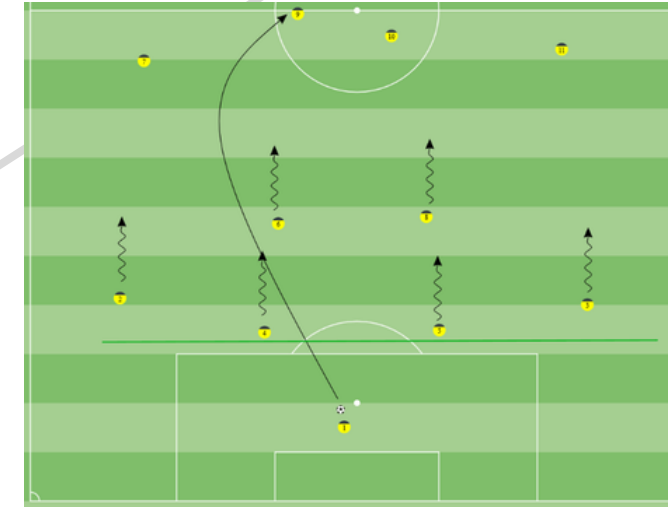


- When possession is regained, one 6/8 is in support, other is available for switching play.
- Both are ensuring play is kept in front of them

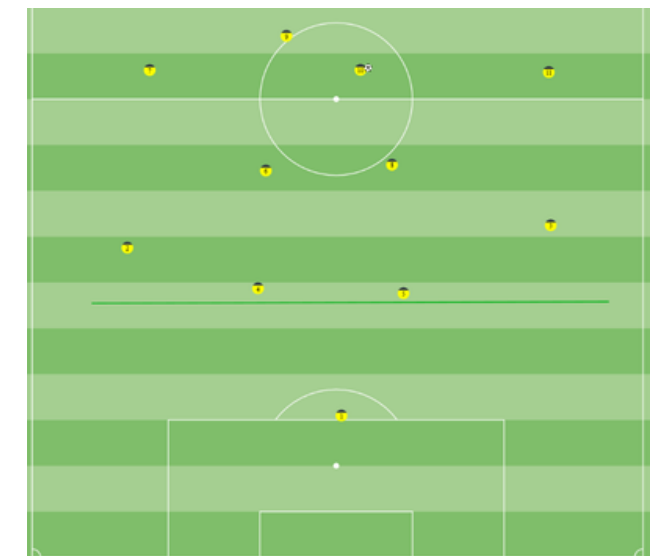


Lines Move Together

- All direct balls require defensive line to step forward and compress midfield space
- 4/5 together, 2/3 slightly in front and half-space



- Defensive line positioning frees 6/8 to attack ball and provides attacking platform
- Rest defensive positioning important
- Not too much space between lines

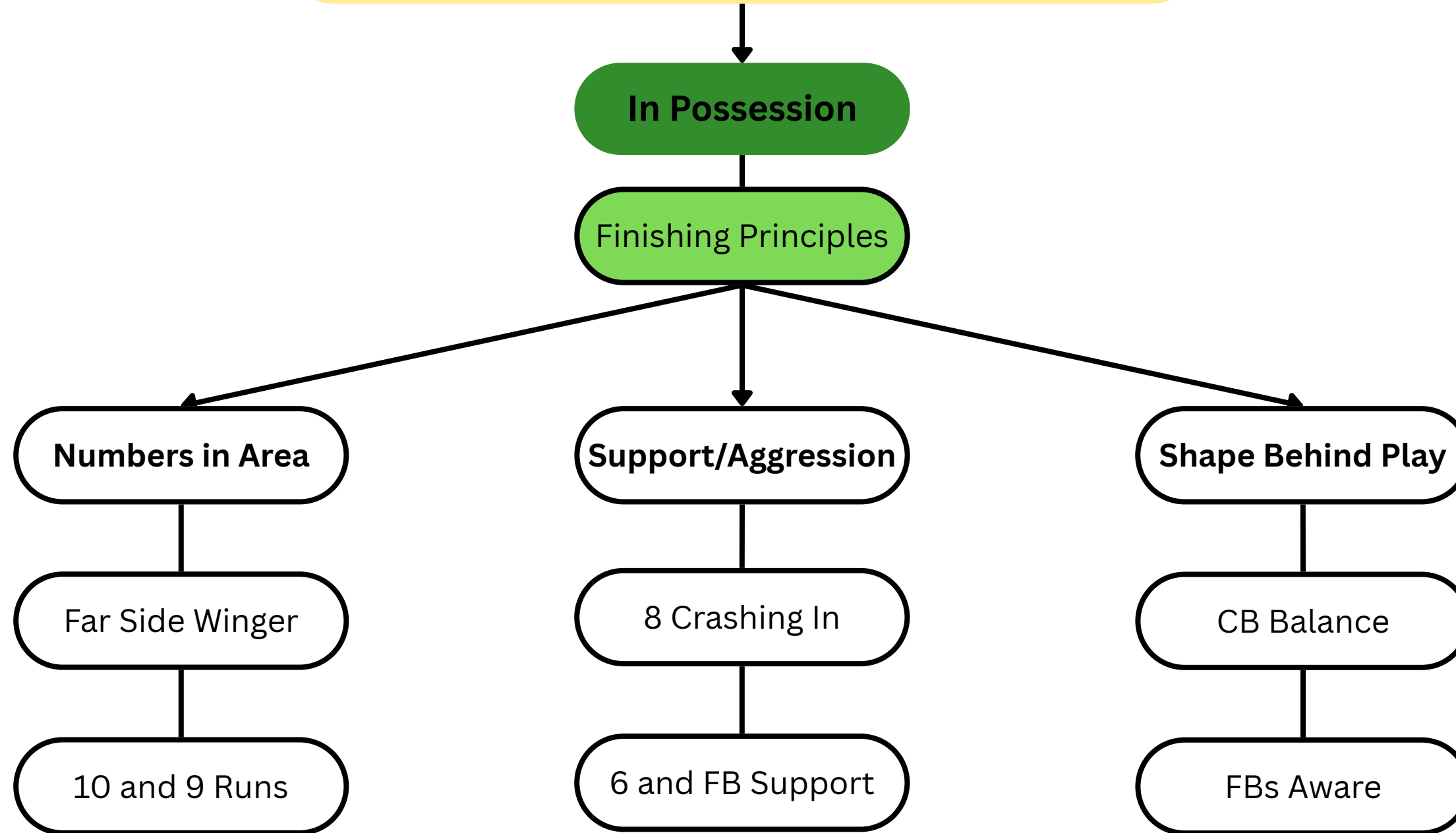




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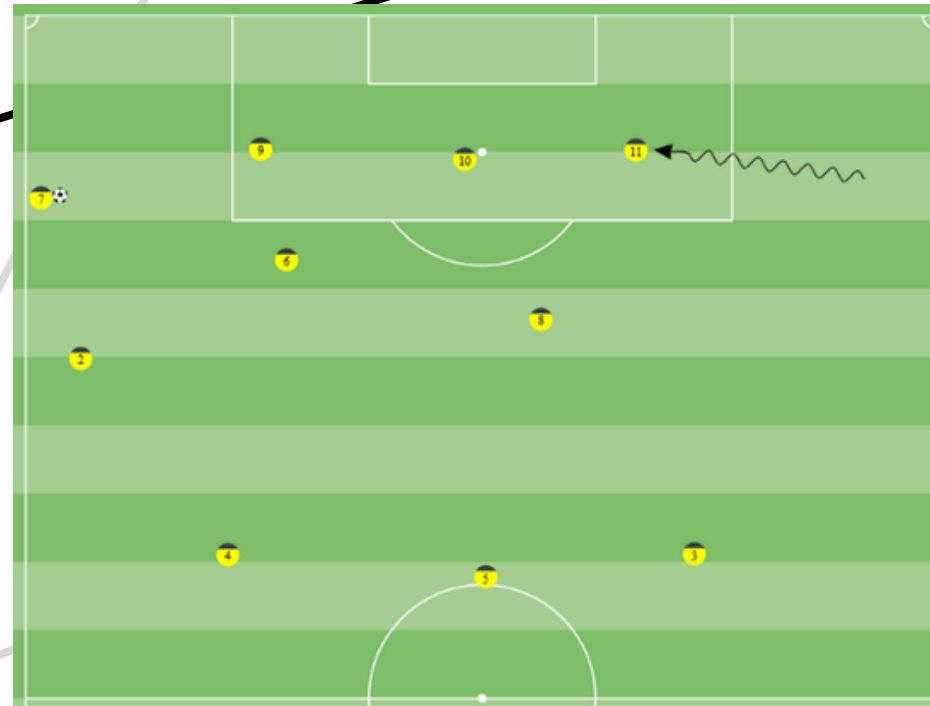




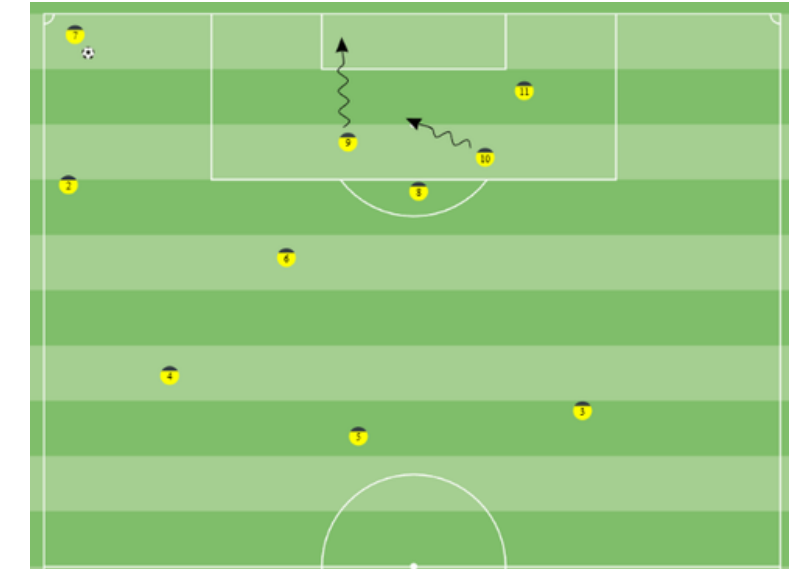
Player Centered Game Model

Far Side 7/11

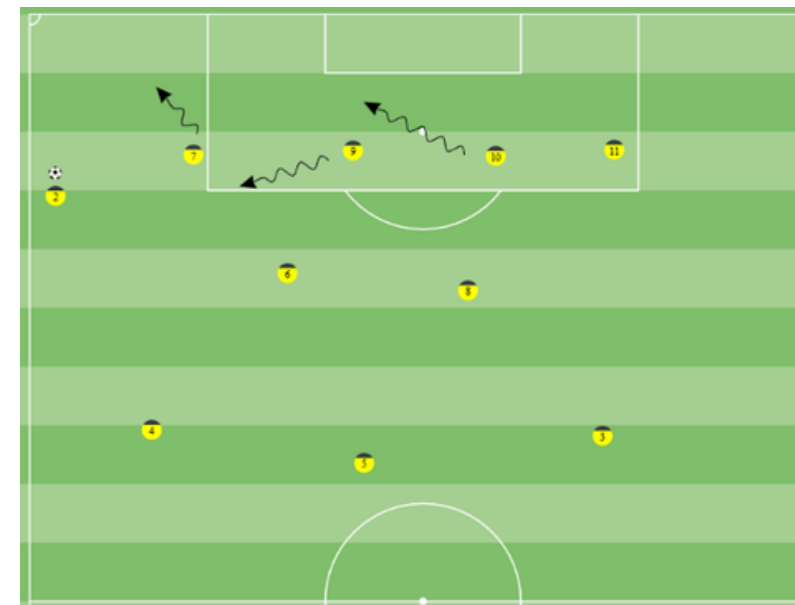
10 and 9 Runs



- 10/9 go near post and penalty spot, depending on previous movements and who is closer
- Communication is key
- Movement to drag defenders and create space for teammates



- If ball is not crossed, NS10/9 slides to near corner of area for support, FS10/9 finds space between penalty area and near post
- Constant movement/rotations to create space/confusion



- FS7/11 pinches centrally when ball is in attacking 3rd
- Responsible for far-post runs
- If ball gets past them into FS corner, the closest 6/8 shifts to support, closest 2/3 step forward, and now FS 2/3 drop to back 3 while FS6/8 moves central behind play

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Finishing Principles

Numbers in Area

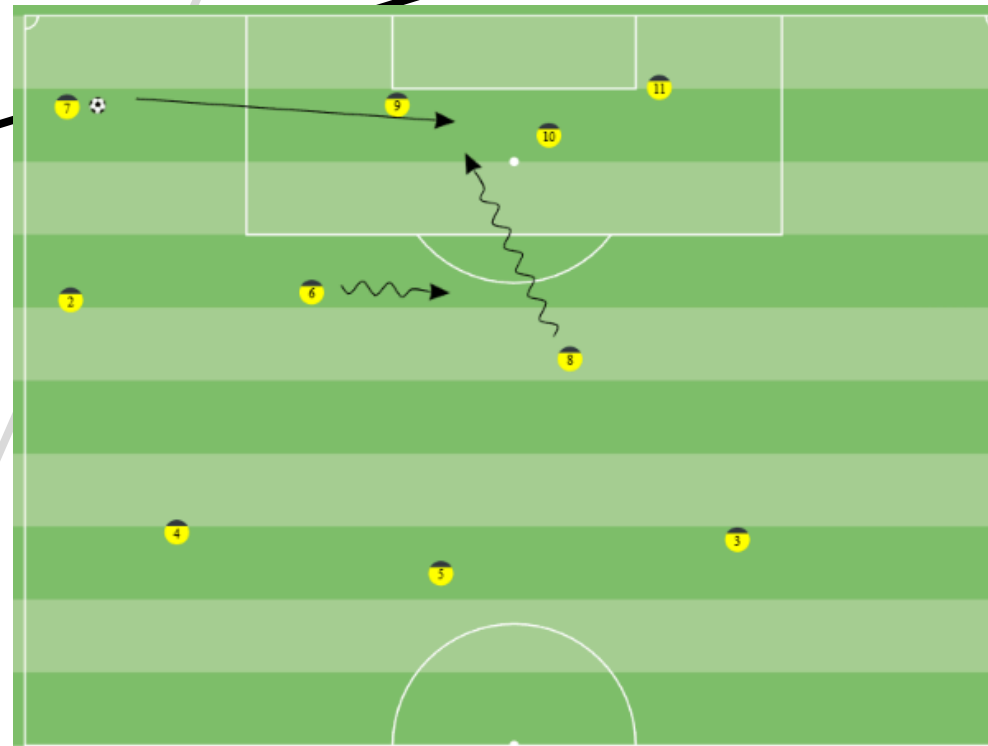
Support/Aggression

Shape Behind Play



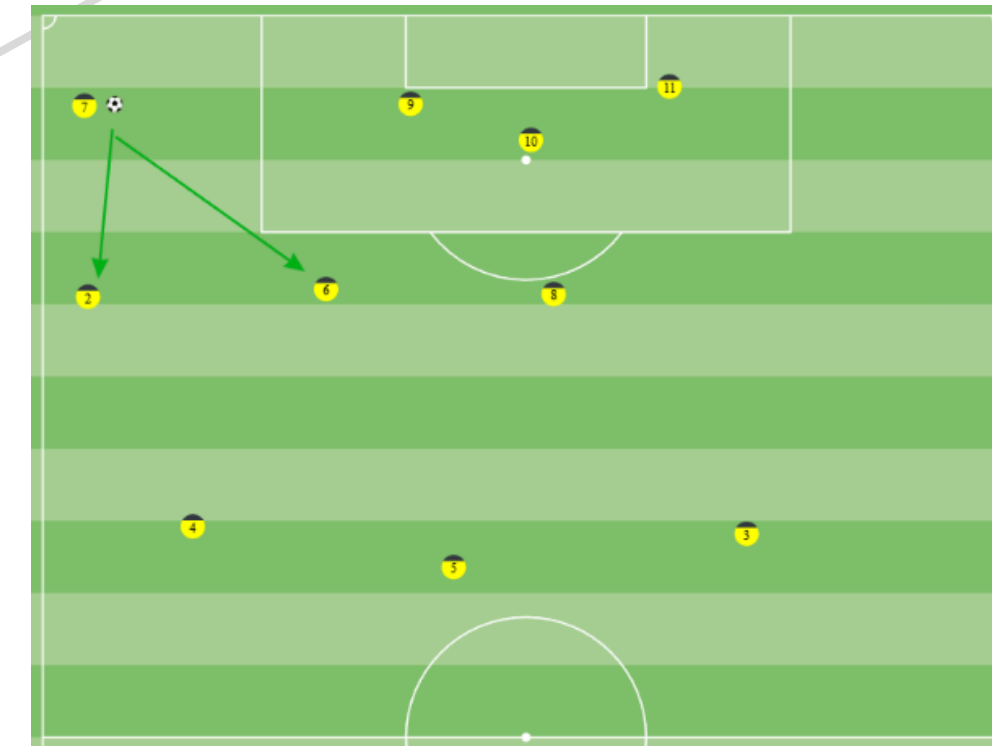
Player Centered Game Model

8 Crashing In



- 6/8 free to crash the box on crosses and cutbacks, looking for loose balls and creating confusion
- 9/10/FS7/11 in box with 8, creating 4 staggered, moving players

6 and FB Support



- NS2/3 behind in support, NS6/8 in halfspace outside area
- When rotations of 10/9 provide support at that corner, NS6/8 slides back and central to look for loose balls and clearances from crosses

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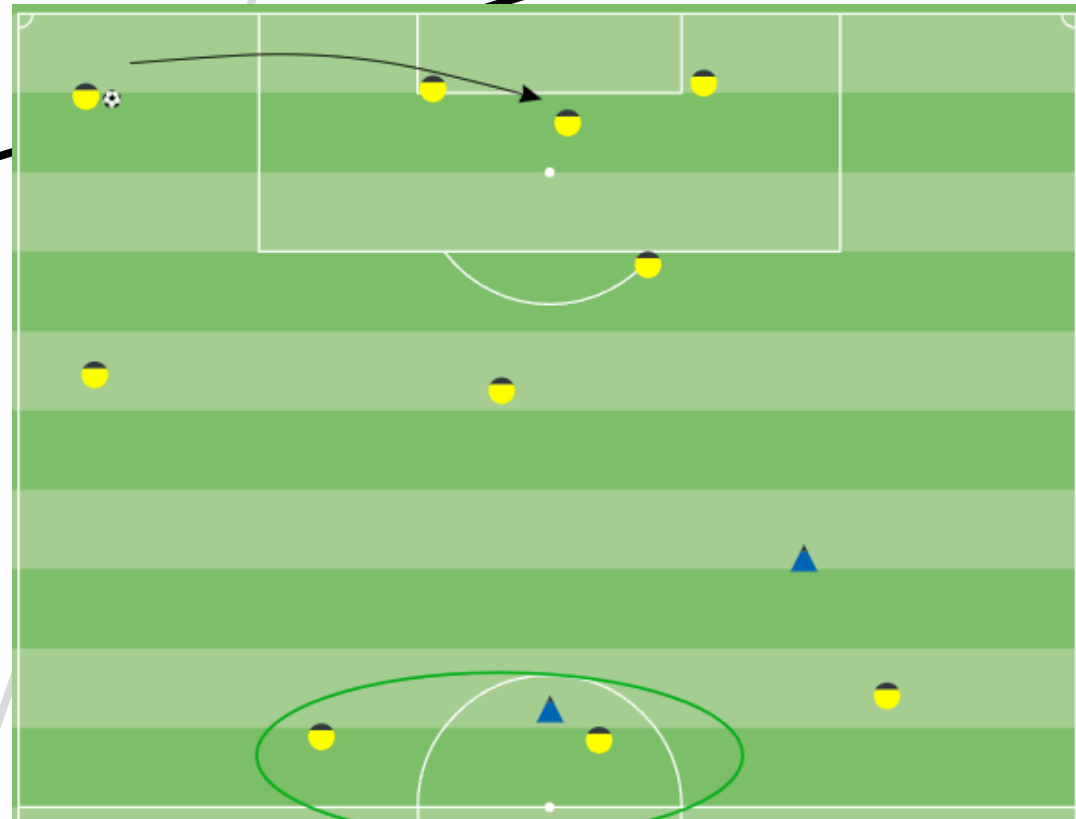
Support/Aggression

Shape Behind Play



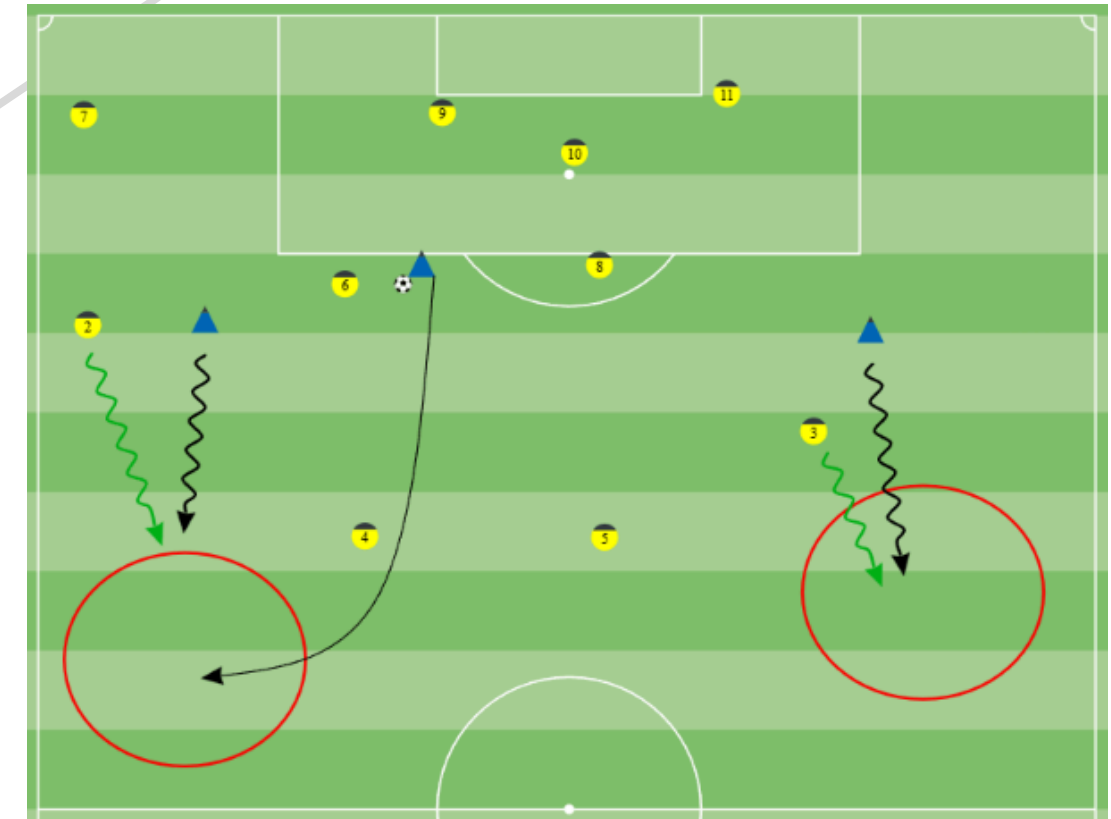
Player Centered Game Model

4/5 Balance



- During this pressure in the attacking 3rd, 4/5 stay balances and aware.
- Defensive line height important - compress space but aware of counters and attacking threats.

2/3 Aware



- There is space behind the 2/3s that they need to be aware of and position themselves accordingly
- 4/5 can't get too high, need to be in a position to delay the counter and force wide

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Support/Aggression

Shape Behind Play

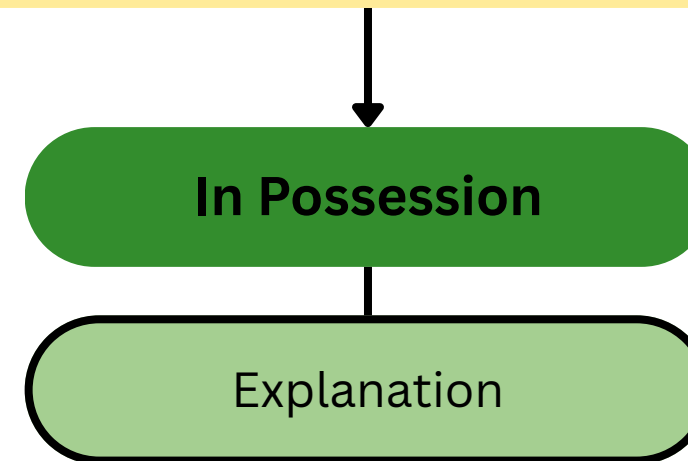


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In Possession

Player Centered Game Model



When we first gain possession, we need to understand where on the field we can have success. Since our goal is to get the ball into the final third with possession, we can first look direct. If a direct ball is not possible or advantageous, we build.

The structure of our build is extremely important. Depending on the situation, the wide players will either stay wide or pinch in. The lines will compress or expand. The midfielders will rotate. The defensive line will shift forward and laterally to support. Everything is balanced and done together. Communication is key.

When we get the ball into the final third, we need to be brave. Take risks. Take shots. Trust our solid rest defense to slow and disrupt counters. Occupy dangerous zones and areas. Be disciplined in our positioning so we have width and depth.

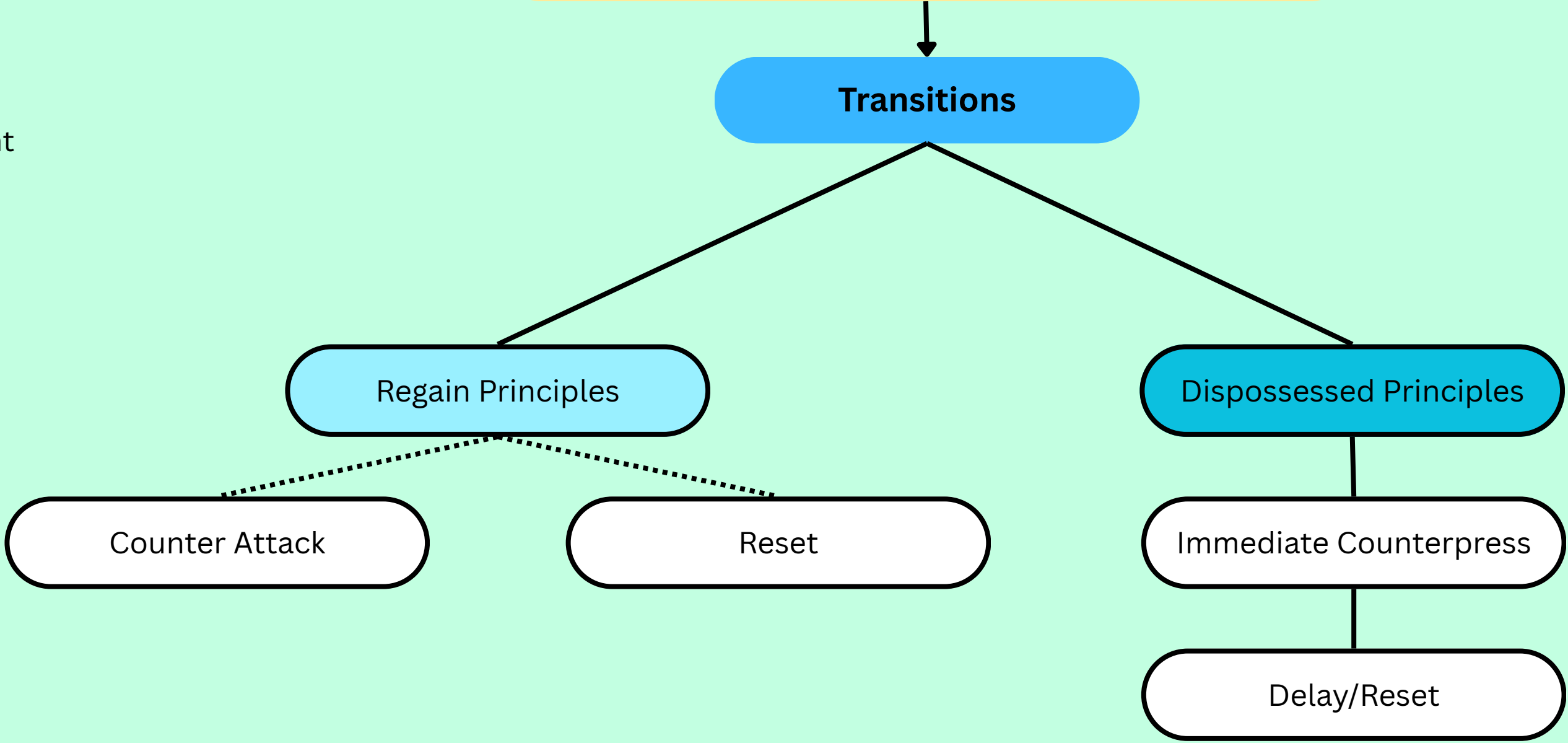
There are always solutions. We need to recognize the opportunities and solve problems with intent.



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Transitions

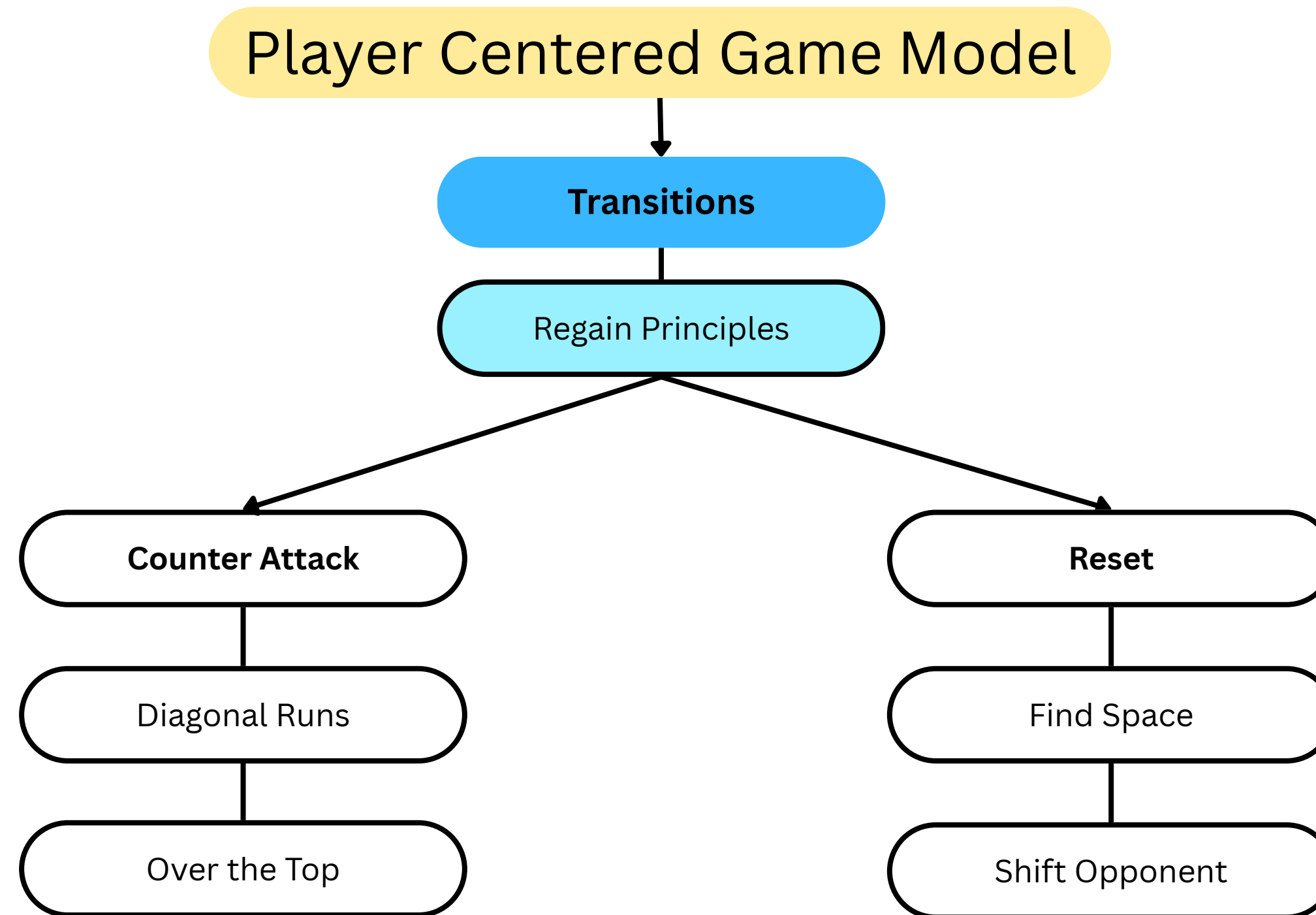
Player Centered Game Model





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Player Centered Game Model

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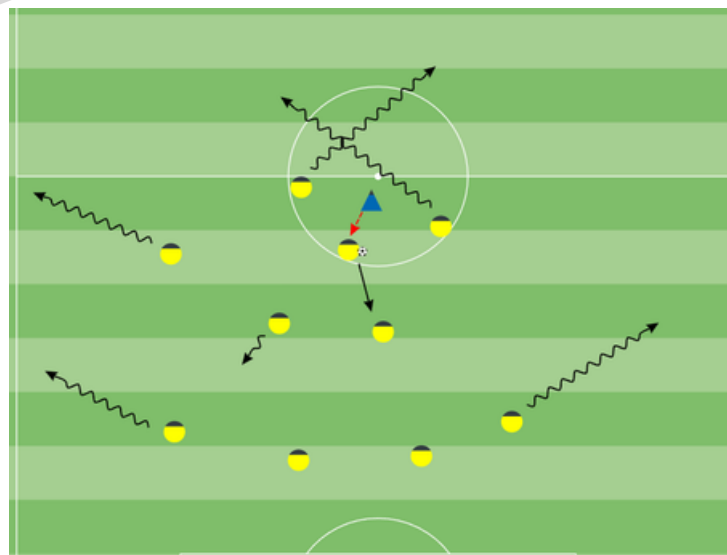
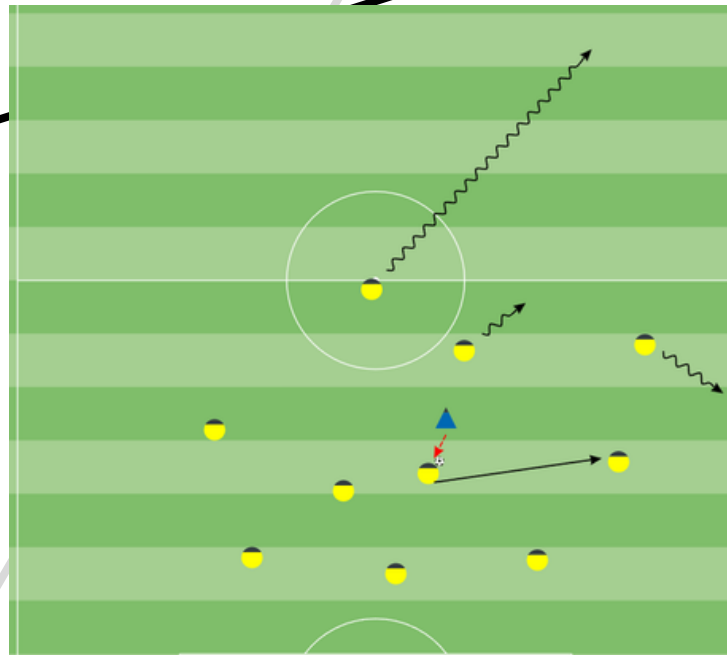
Transitions

Regain Principles

Counter Attack

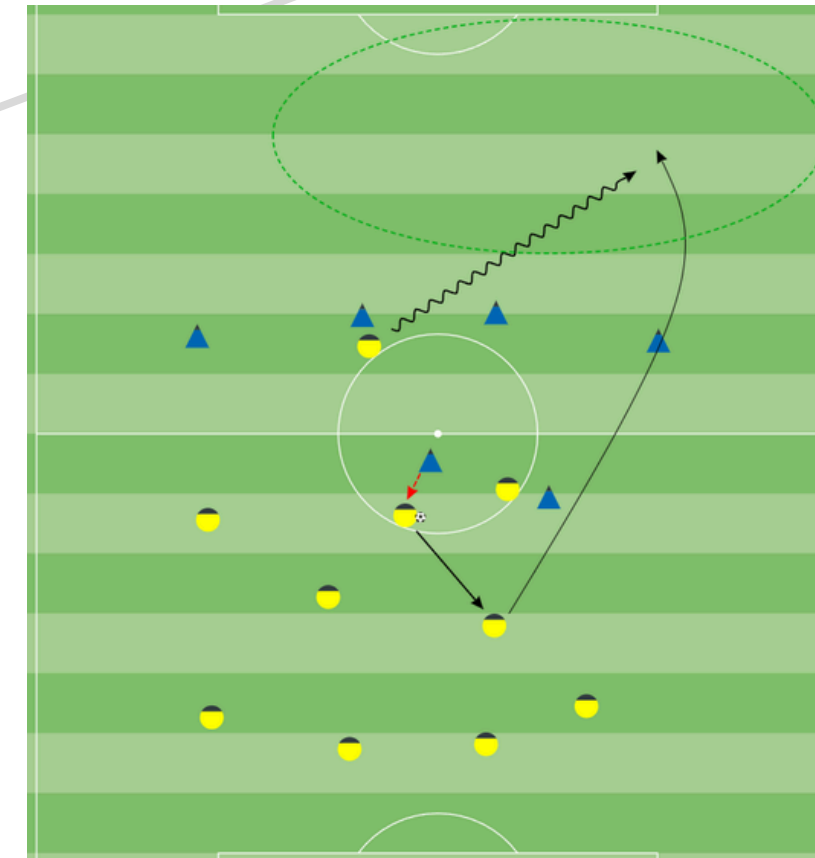
Reset

Diagonal Runs



- Immediately after we regain possession, we evaluate space to attack.
- We do not run forward in a straight line - this makes it too easy to defend and the possessor has no options
- We need to change lanes - make diagonal crossing runs to ask tough questions of the defense and open attacking space

Over the Top



- If there is space in behind - a zone to run into between the keeper and defensive line, we play into that space immediately
- Attackers make runs in behind from an onside position (as we were just defending, this should be easy)
- The midfield and defensive lines immediately move forward to support, getting into attacking shape



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Transitions

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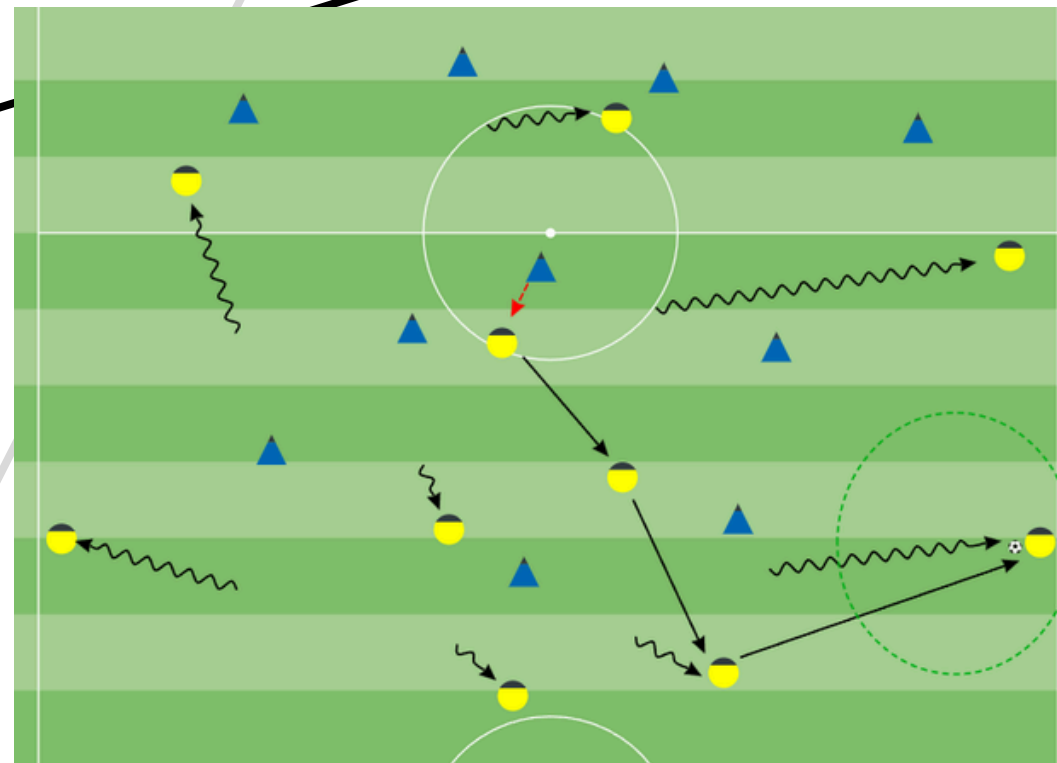
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Regain Principles

Counter Attack

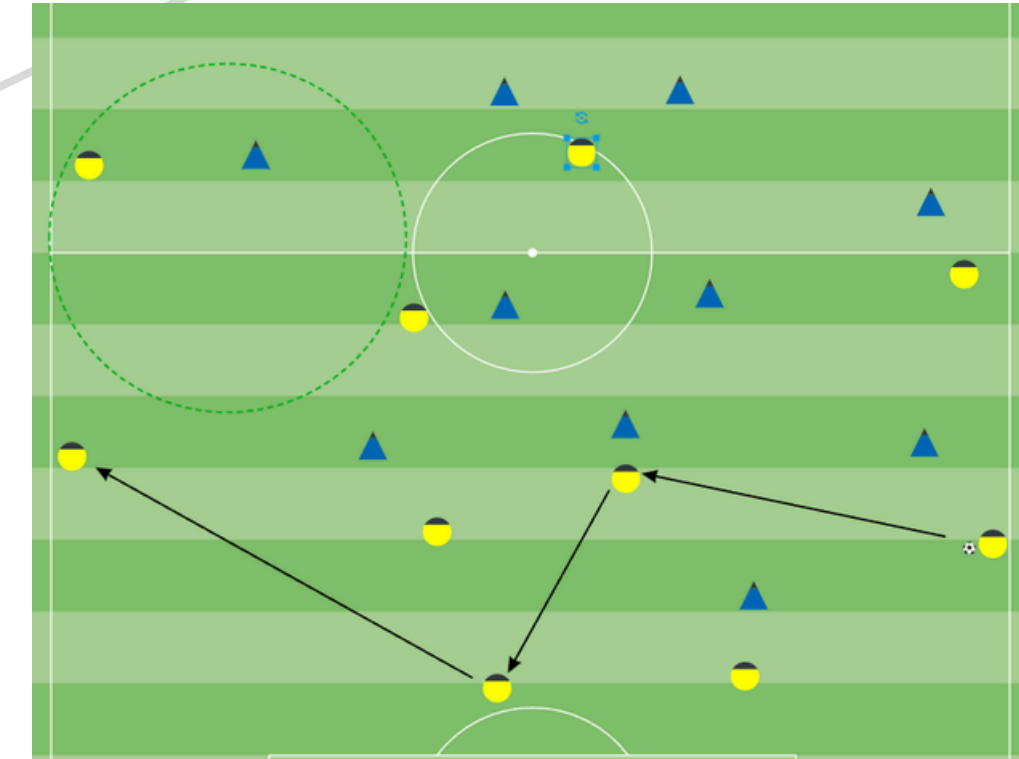
Reset

Find Space



- If the space to counter attack is not open, we need to immediately reset with possession
- This involves finding space - usually behind and/or wide, and calmly but quickly playing the ball into space
- Any back pass is accompanied by wide movements off the ball
- Possess into our base attacking shape

Shift Opponent

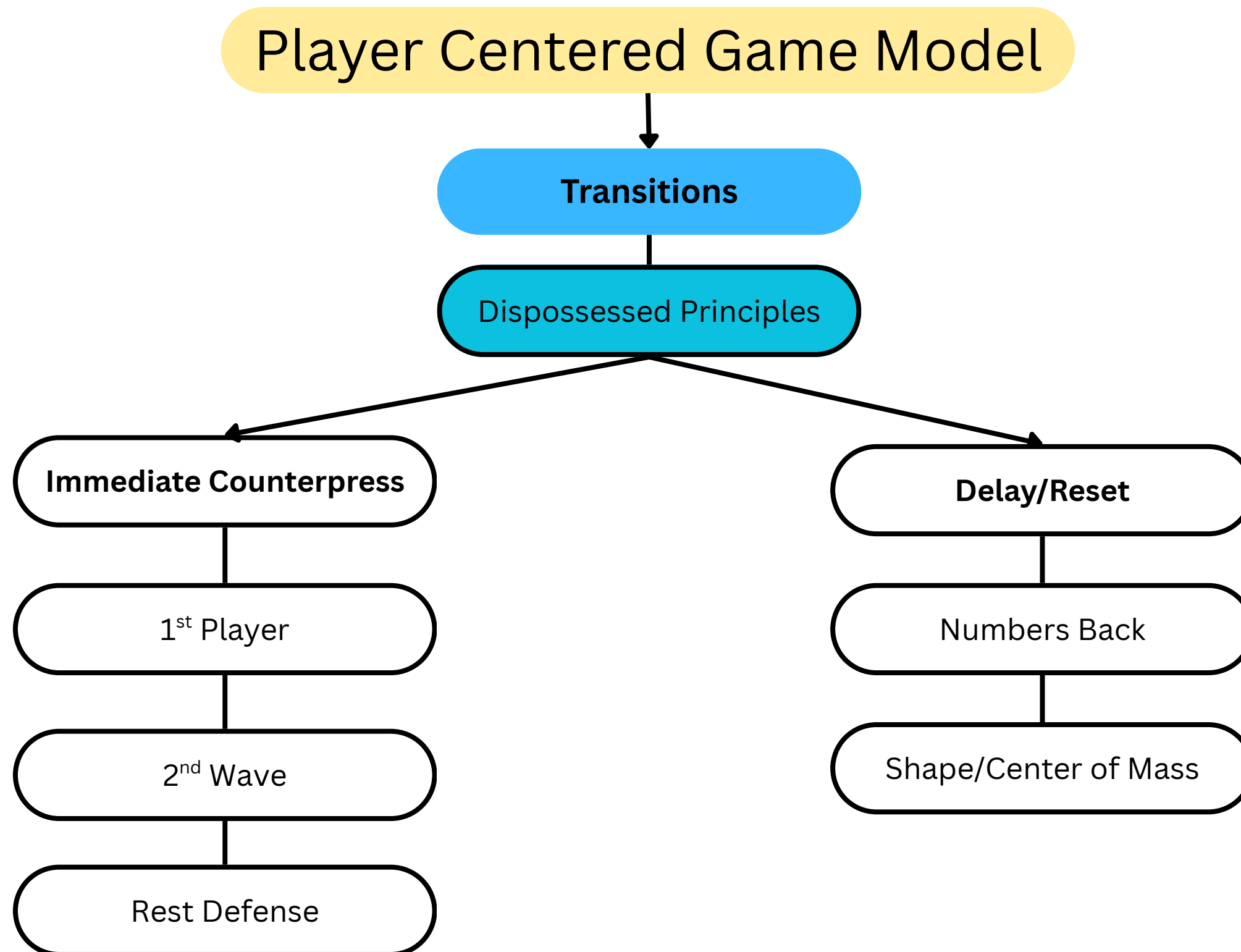


- Once we have possessed into our base attacking shape, we need to work on creating space to attack
- One way to do this is by shifting the opponent laterally
- Whilst moving the ball from one side to the other, our attackers will need to find pockets of space and we always look to move forward quickly when those pockets are open
- We use the ball to move the opponent to exploit gaps



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Player Centered Game Model

1st Player

2nd Wave

Rest Defense

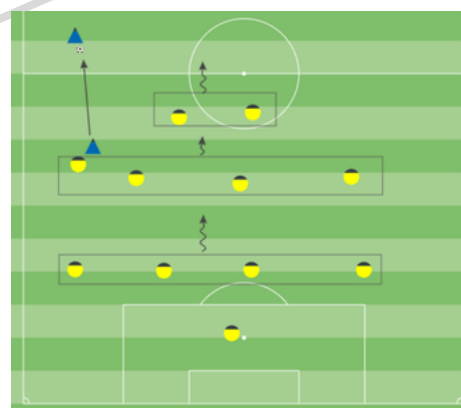
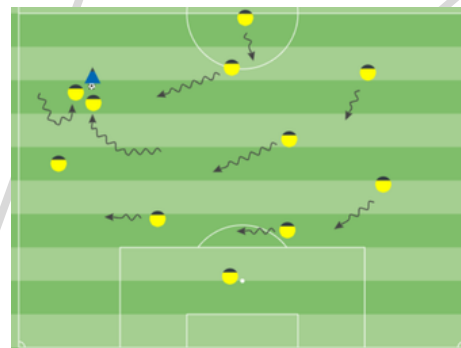
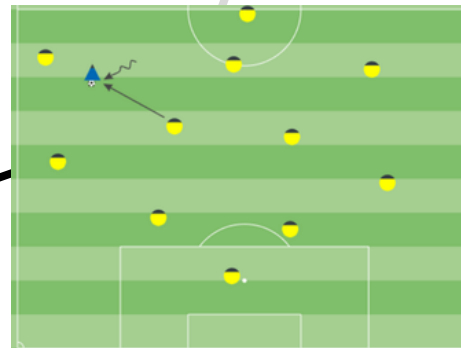
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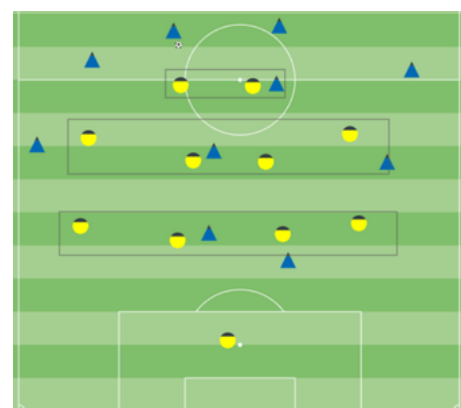
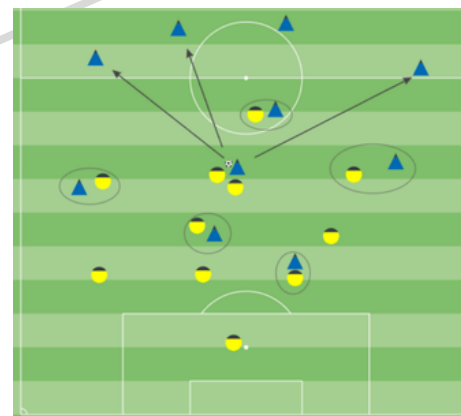
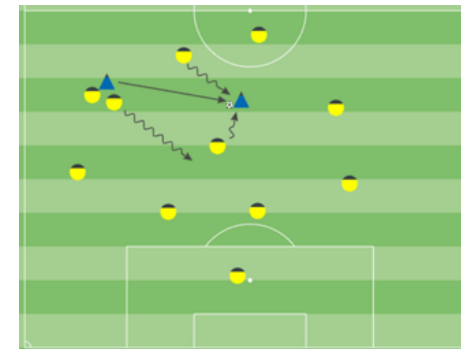
Dispossessed
Principles

Immediate
Counterpress

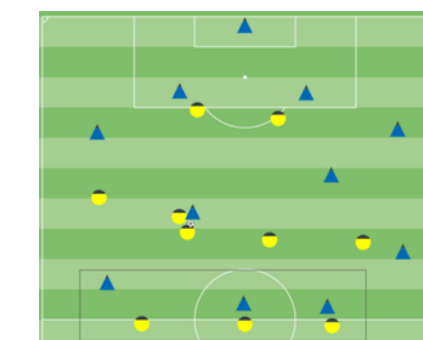
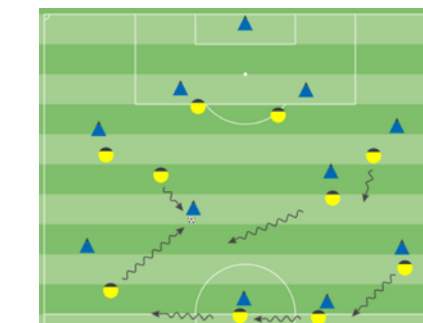
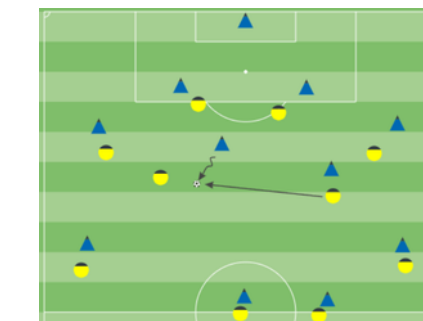
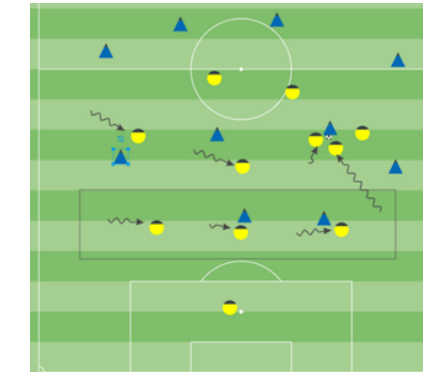
Delay/Reset



- 1st Player immediately presses - forcing backward
- Follow individual defending principles
- Rest of team uses delay to recover into defending shape
- Immediate press for 5 seconds



- 2nd and 3rd players initially move to cut off passing angles and provide cover
- Then, once set, the entire team presses forward together
- Follow high/low or mid/low defensive principles



- While attacking and defensive lines are pressing and stepping, our defensive line and potentially pivots need to get into solid rest defense shape
- 3-2 back if one of 2/3/4/5 steps forward to assist
- Get into defensive lines/zones first - communication is key



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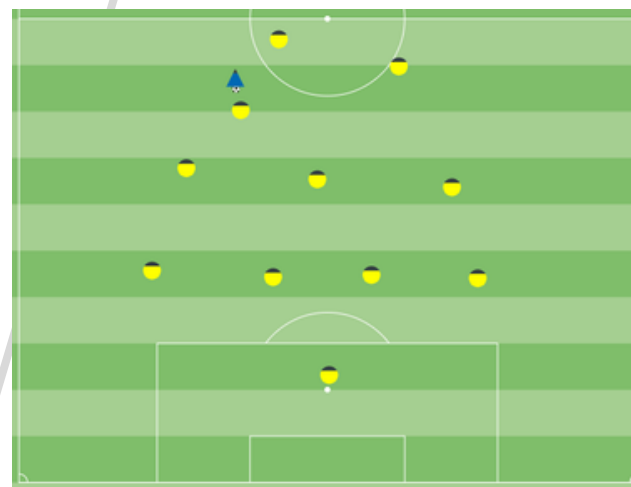
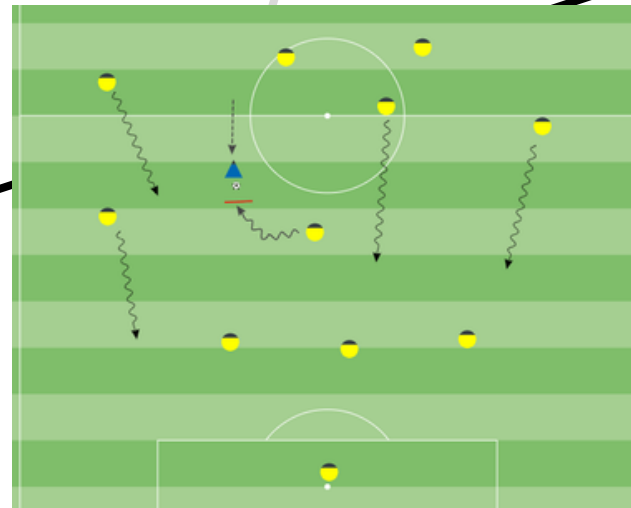
Transitions

Dispossessed
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Counterpress

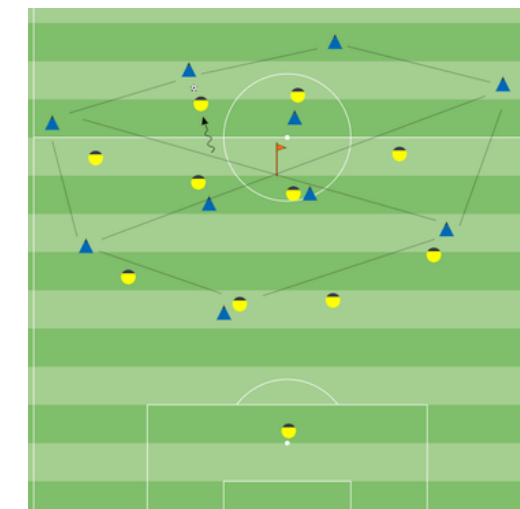
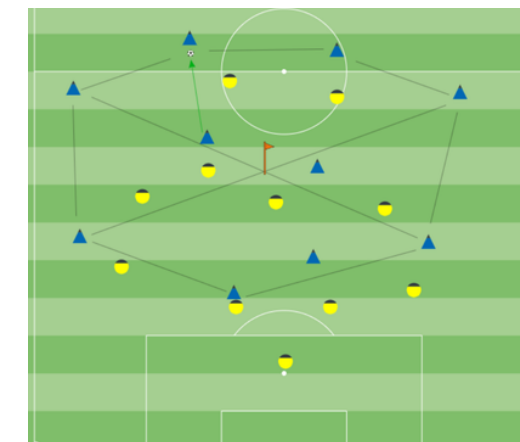
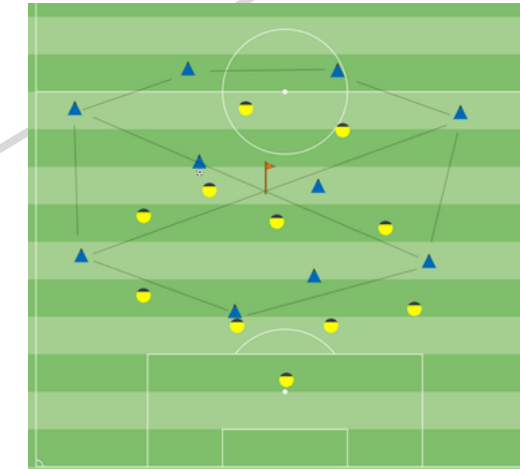
Delay/Reset

Numbers Back

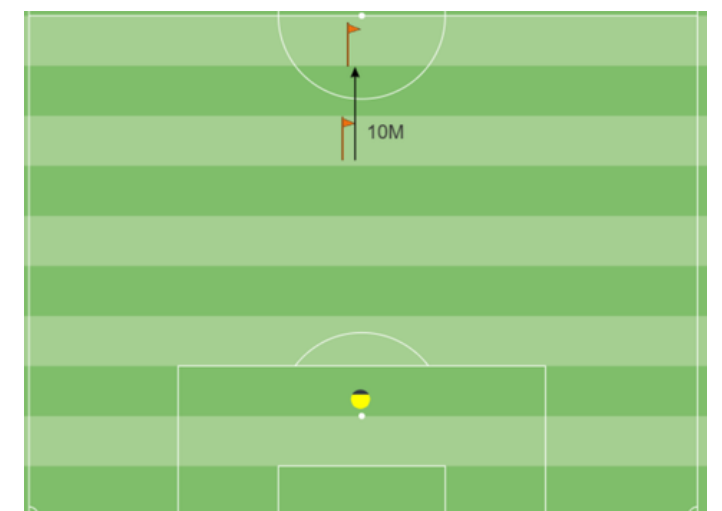
Shape/Center of Mass



- During counterpress, the players not immediately involved in the 1st and 2nd waves of pressure need to recover into defensive shape
- The press either allows us to regain immediately and attack space during chaos, or it forces the opponent back and allows our defensive shape to reset
- **These recovery runs are the most important runs in this system - we are built on controlling space! If you do not recover, you are giving the opponent space.**



- One way to look at defensive pressure during transitions is by how close the opponent center of mass is to our goal
- When we lose possession, typically there will be space to exploit behind and between our lines (when attacking, we create space).
- Drawing a line around the opponent shape, we want to push the center of that shape back toward the opponent goal





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Transitions

Explanation

Immediate counterpress

- Always press from the front, force them back
- Goal is to win the ball back in 5 seconds as a team
- 1st player press, second wave crash (backpress too), rest defense immediately set up

If/When counterpress fails to regain possession:

- Delay and force backwards
- Reset lines, compress space
- Step forward every chance we can as a unit
 - Be aware of space in behind
 - Control space in front and behind
- Shift center of mass away from goal
- Push so far back that 6/8 are in attacking half
 - Once we push back and are in shape - look for high press triggers



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Set Pieces

Player Centered Game Model

Set Pieces

Corners

Goal Kicks

Free Kicks

Throw Ins

Penalties

Kickoffs

Offense

Offense

Offense

Offense

Offense

Offense

Defense

Defense

Defense

Defense

Defense

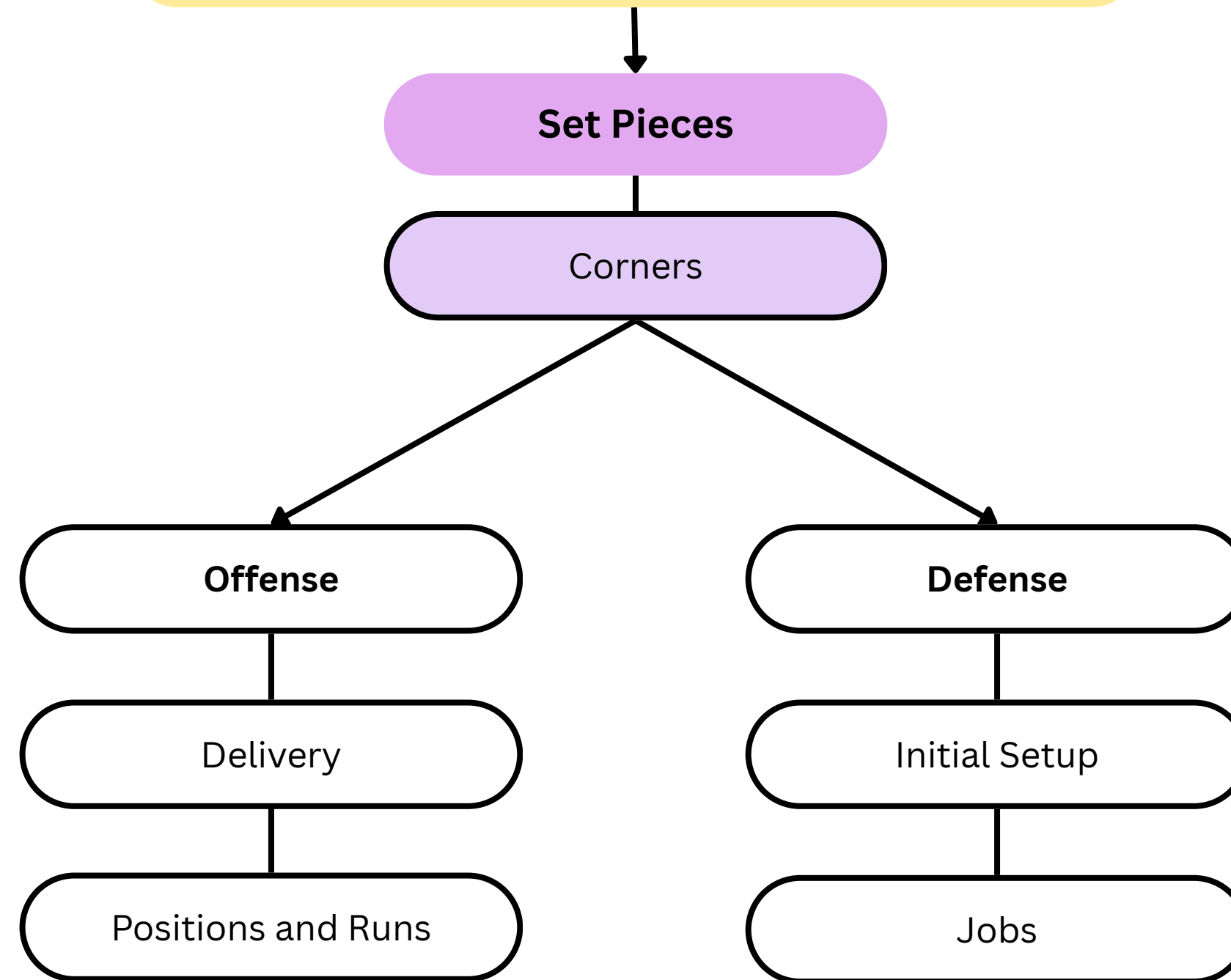
Defense



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Player Centered Game Model





Player Centered Game Model

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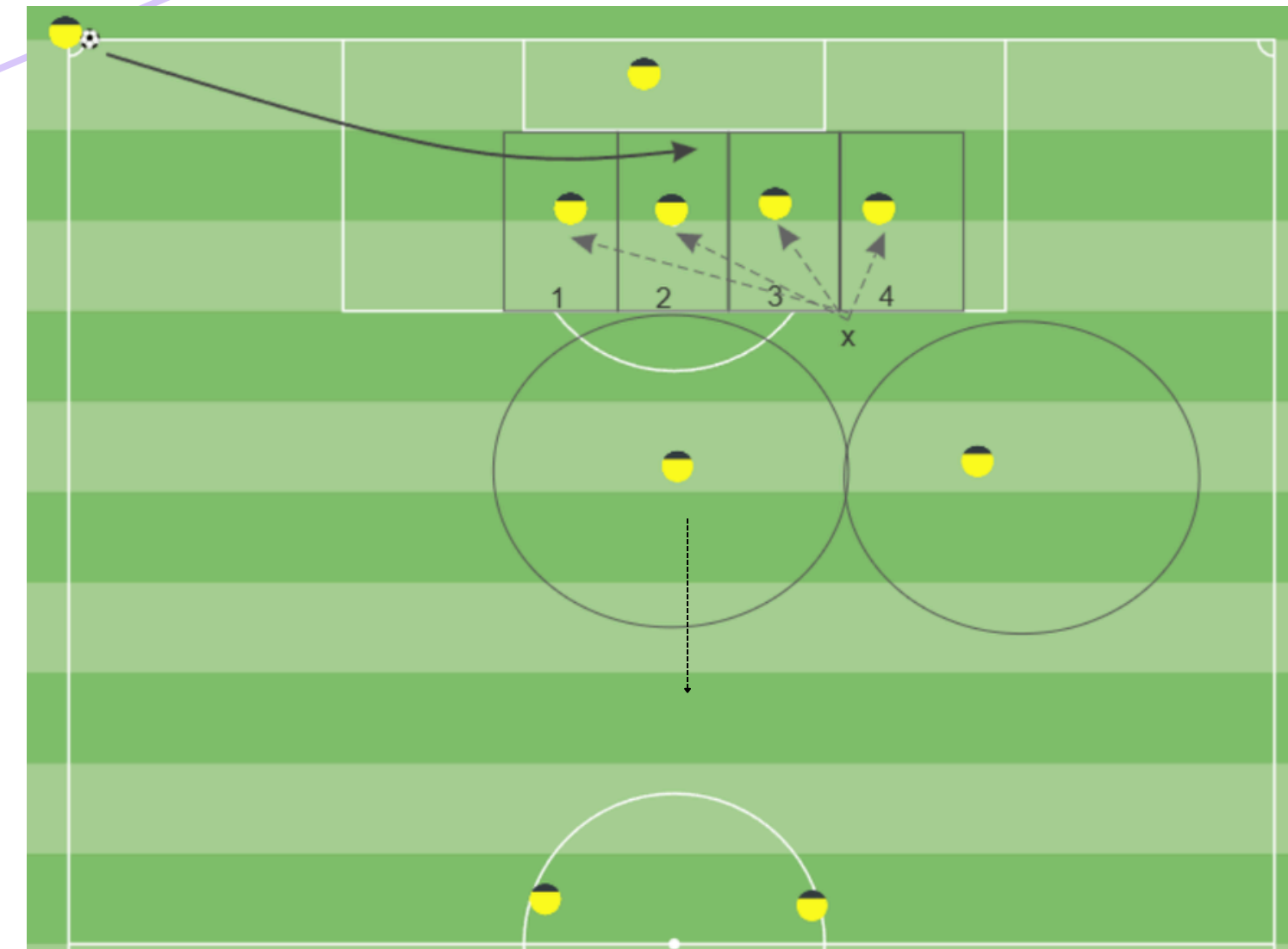
Delivery

Positions and Runs

1v1 On Keeper, 4 Mids in 4 Zones

- Striker on Keeper
- ACM, 2 Wingers, 1 Pivot finish in 4 zones
 - Varied Starting Points, at least 2 together, potentially all 4
- Pivot for central drop
- Far FB for Garbage
- 2 CBs stay home
- FB Takes Corner

As long as each job is taken care of, it is possible to have 1 CB take the place of the Zone-Running Pivot





Player Centered Game Model

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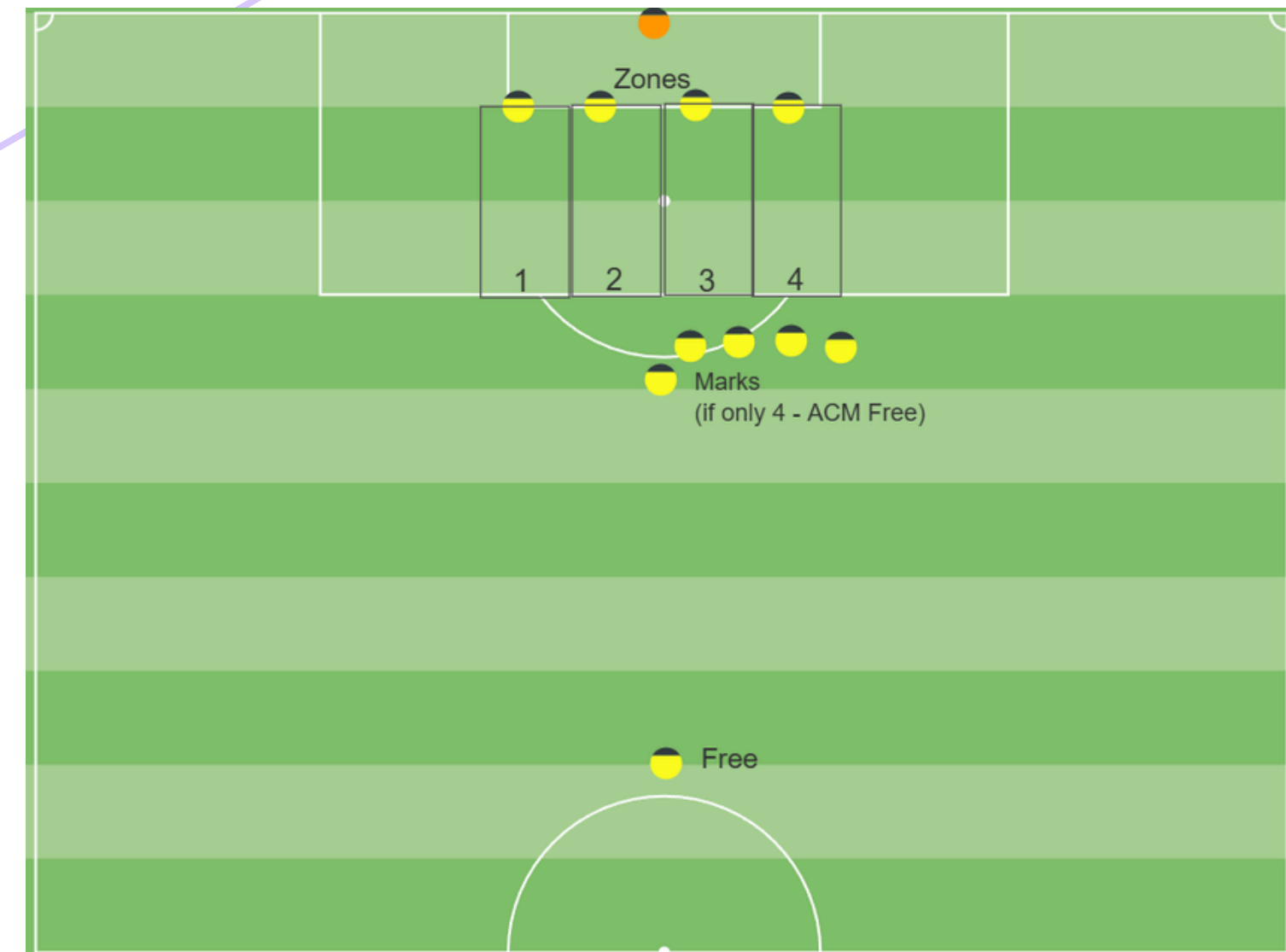
Defense

Initial Setup

Back 4 Defending Zones, Rest w/ Marks

- In position, ready to assume defensive roles
 - If short, near FB pressure, back 3 slide into 3 Zones
- Pivots, Wingers, ACM With Marks
 - If only 4 needed, ACM free for counter
- ST free
- If ball goes far post, near FB drops to near post
- If ball goes near post, far FB drops to far post
- CB Win Everything
- Marks to delay and destroy free runs

Jobs





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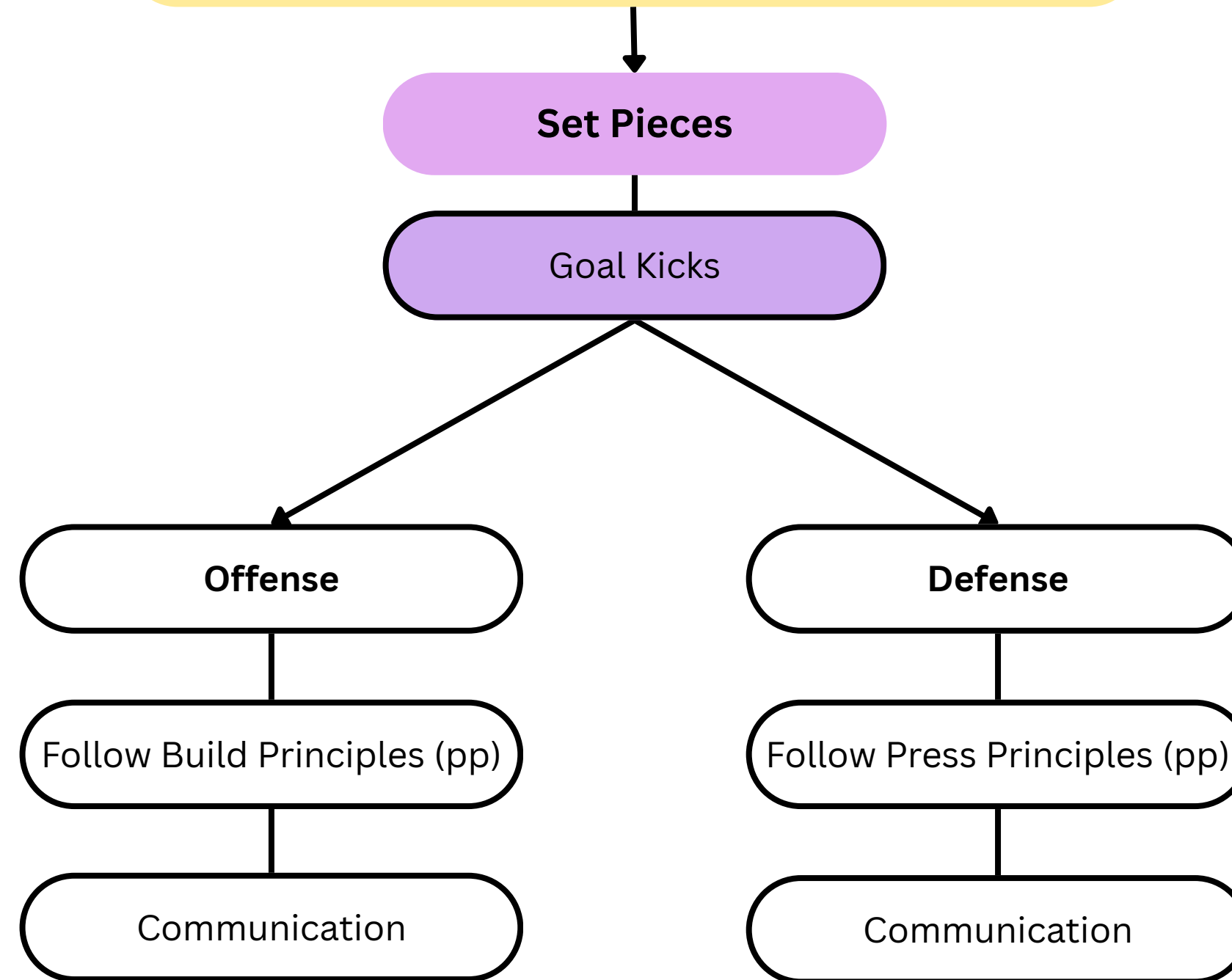
Set Pieces

Game Management

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Set Pieces

Player Centered Game Model





Player Centered Game Model

Follow Low Build Principles - Pages 25 and 26

Steps

1. Get into team shape (2/3s wide and high, 2-4-4 shape)
 2. GK assesses pressure (1 press, 2 press, full press)
 3. GK evaluates space - if 1 or 2 press and we are in good shape, play short to draw in attackers and create space in midfield)
 4. If full press or we are overmatched - play long and midfielders assume their 5-under and 2-man control positions
- any ball in the air: we touch first and swarm to control

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Player Centered Game Model

Follow High/Low or Mid/Low Principles - Pages 11 and 16

Steps

1. Evaluate if we press high (game state, midfield position, opponent setup)
 2. 9 triggers press (if played short)
 3. If high press - players follow their jobs, compress space, force opponent into risky central pass or aerial ball
 4. If opponent plays long - drop into 2-man control positions
- any ball in the air: we touch first and swarm to control

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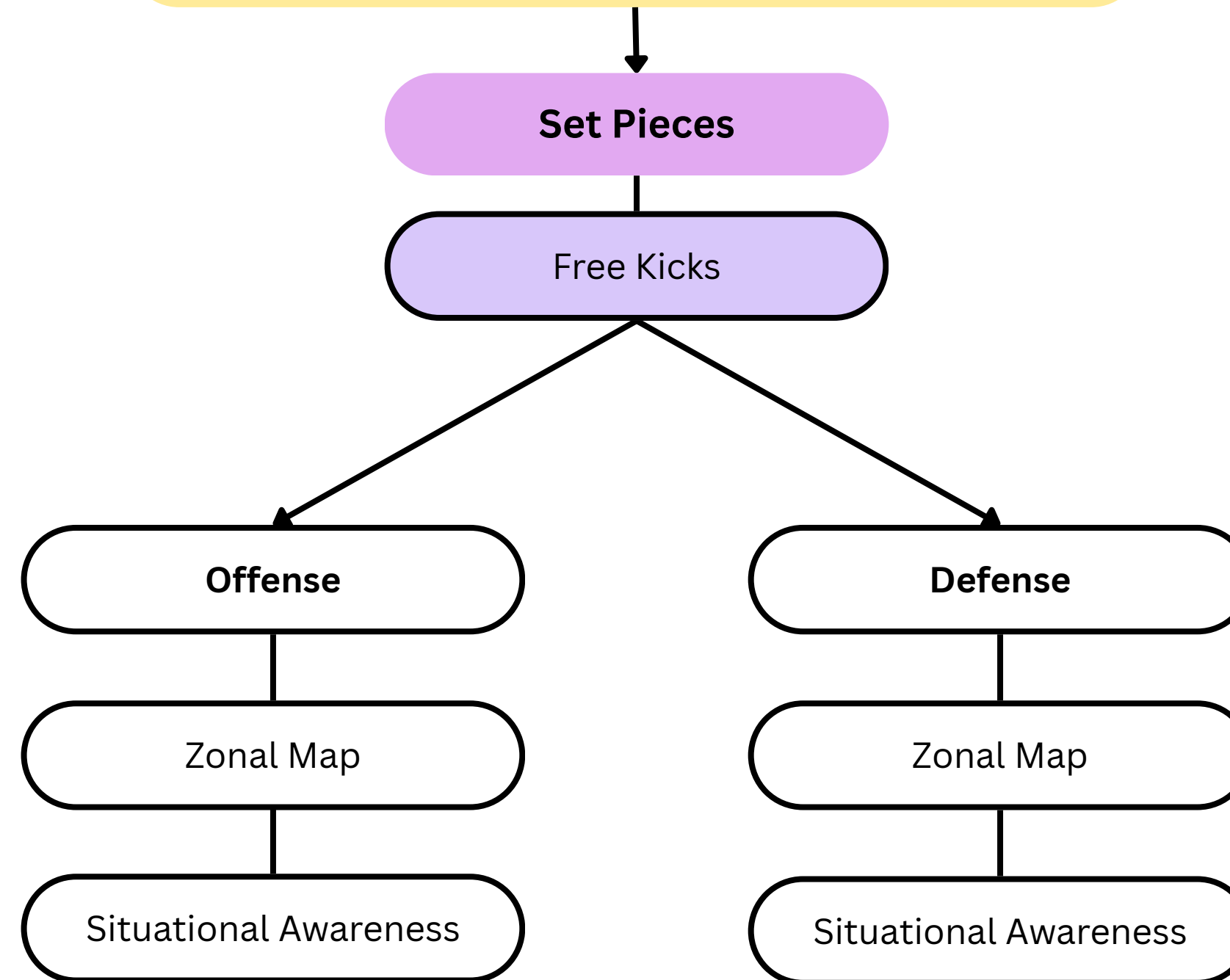
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Player Centered Game Model





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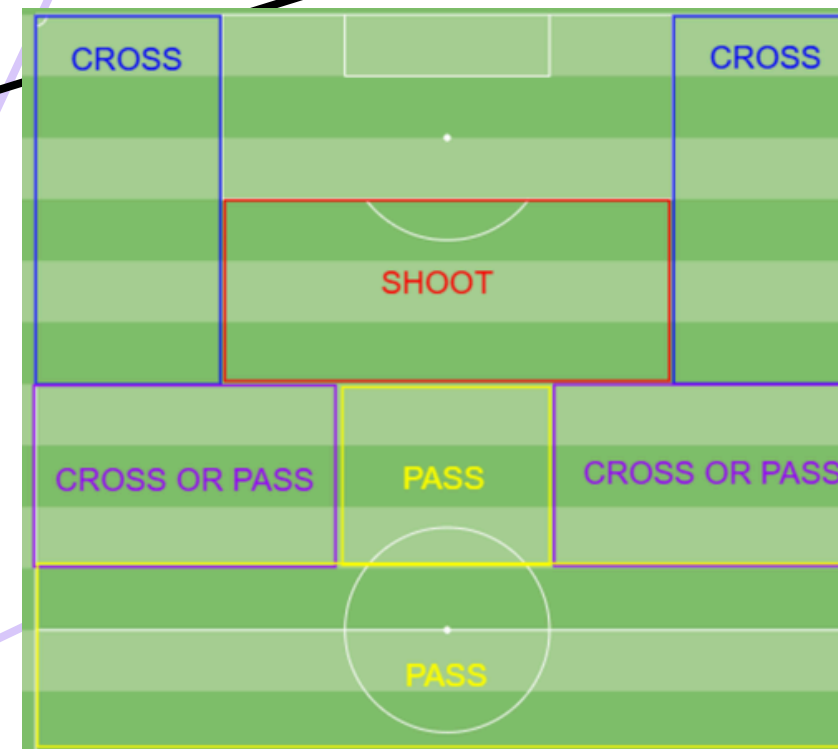
Set Pieces

Free Kicks

Offense

Defense

Zonal Map



Situational Awareness

- Blue - cross like corner
- Red - inswinger
- Purple - back corner of 6 if long, or control pass
- Yellow - high build principles - page 32

- Our team is always looking to control space to get into dangerous areas.
- If there is space to exploit quickly from a free kick, we exploit it quickly and communicate.
- If the opponent is set up well, we allow the center of mass of the opponent to retreat and we set ourselves up, looking for matchups and space.
- Every free kick in the attacking or midfield third is an opportunity to create a dangerous opportunity - a long aerial ball into pressure might not be the best option, especially if opponents have good aerial defenders.
- During these moments, it is important to have a good rest defense - 3 players back with 2 shield, unless the cross is higher and the opponent only has 1 attacking, in which case we can afford to send another player forward



Player Centered Game Model

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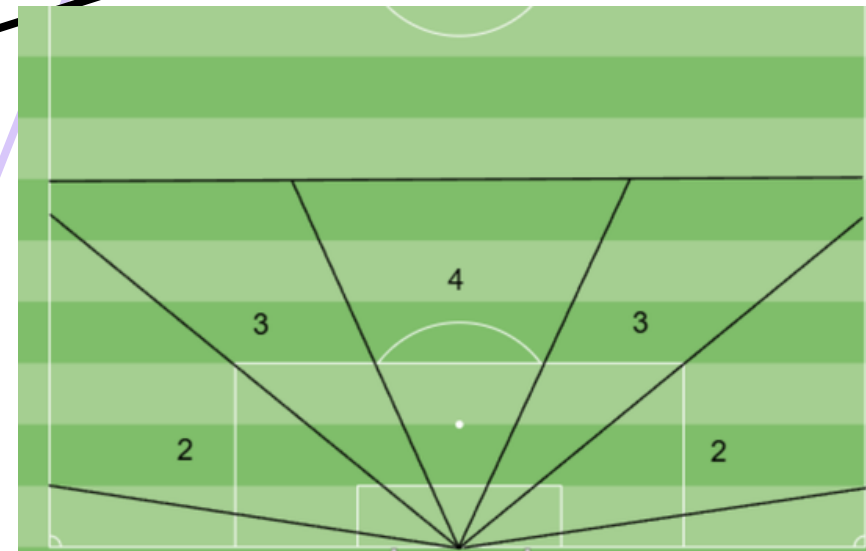
Set Pieces

Free Kicks

Offense

Defense

Zonal Map



Situational Awareness

- Initial player 5-8 yards away to delay quick restarts
- Immediate organization - no use arguing the call or complaining.
- Be aware of quick plays to near side or behind lines
- GK very aggressive within 6 and potentially out to penalty spot
- Within zones, allow nearest zonal player to win duel, everyone else set into shape and mark runners through the box

- Keeper sets up the wall according to his preference - but general guidelines for how many players in the wall above
- Much like a corner, defenders mark zones while midfielders mark and create wall.
- GK communicate clearly
- Initial player stands 5-8 yards from ball - close enough to delay but not too close to receive a card.
- 1 player high for counter attack



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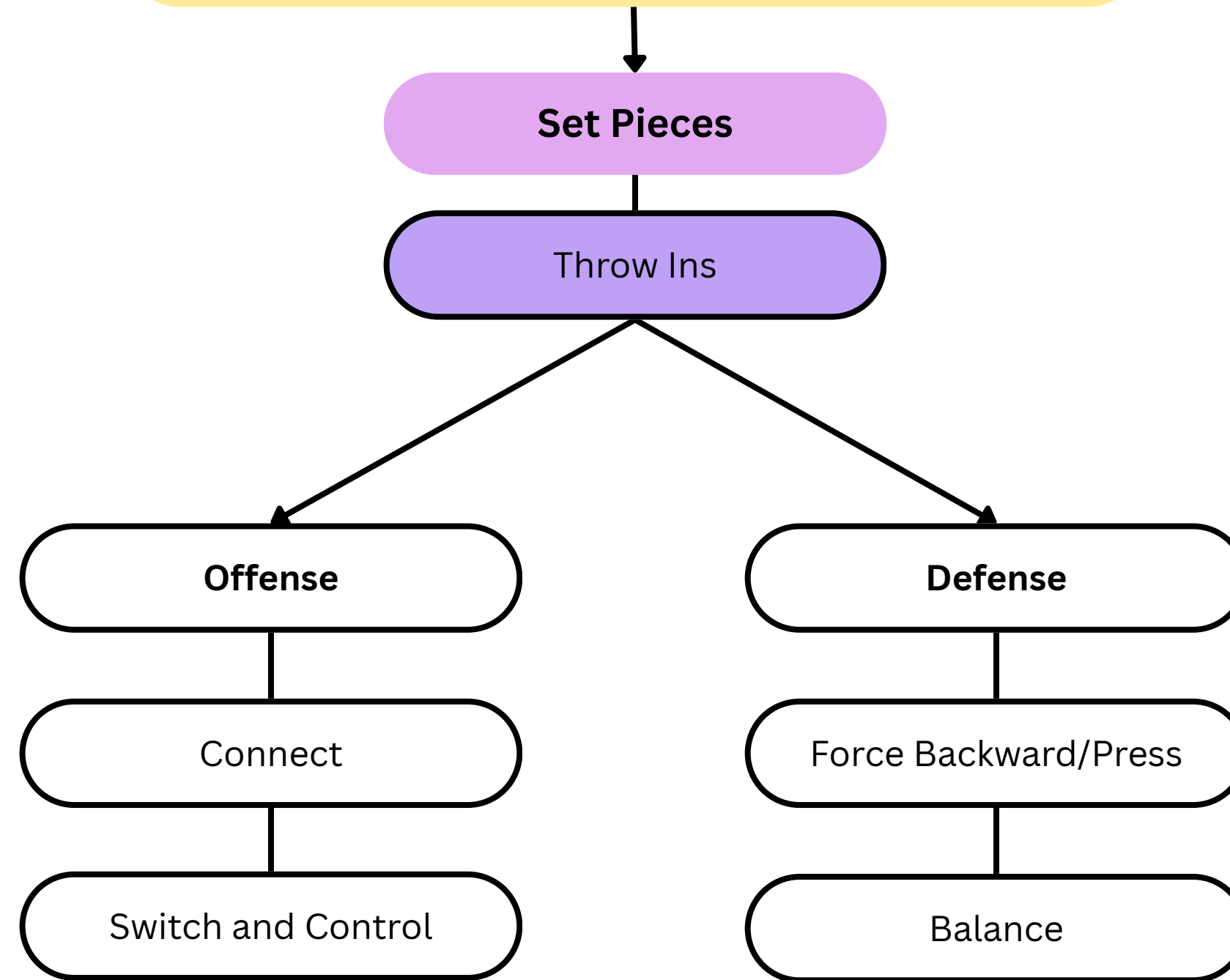
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Player Centered Game Model





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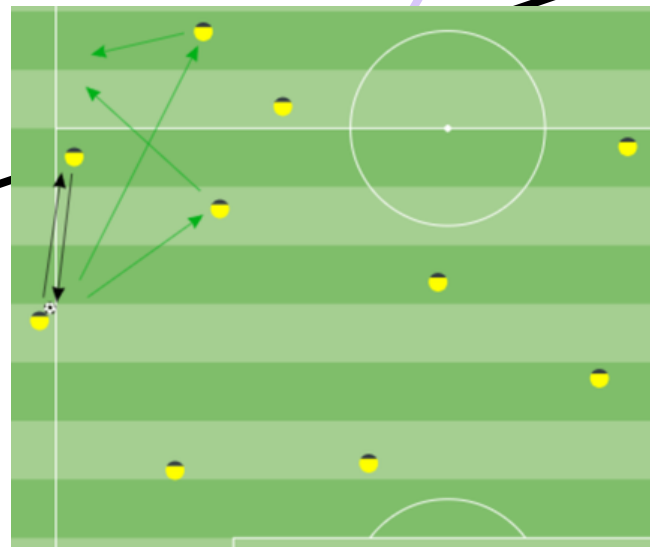
Throw Ins

Offense

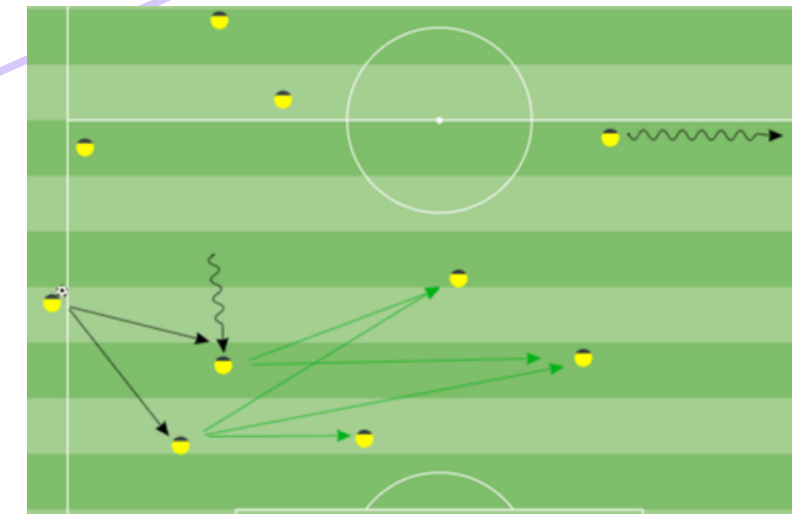
Defense

Connect

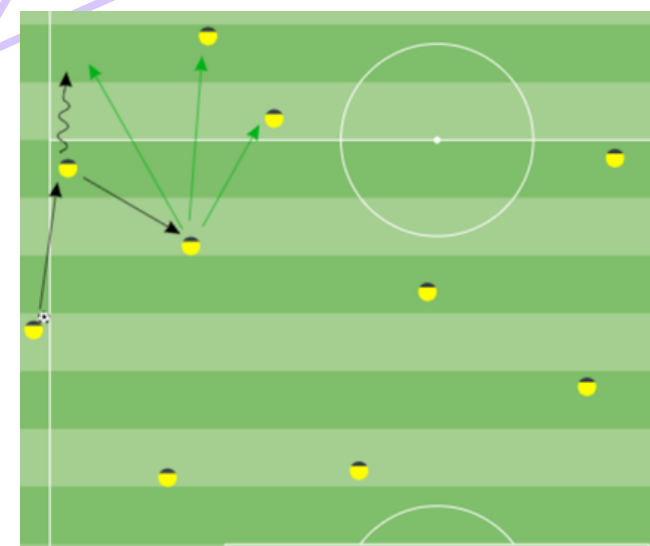
Switch and Control



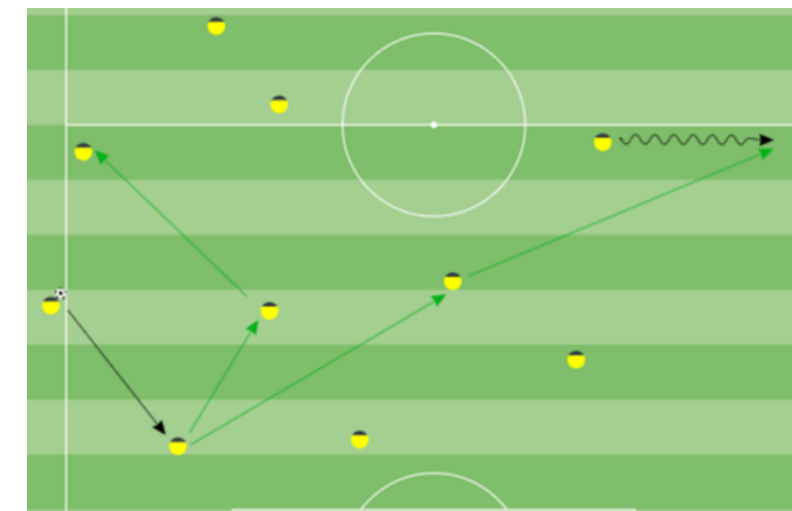
- Look to play back to feet rather than flick on
- Take a breath - unless space is there to exploit (rarely), we need to keep possession
- Never let the ball bounce



- Without numerical superiority, we know the far side has space
- Look to play slightly or fully back, followed by immediate switch



- Always look to pass with 1 touch to teammate
- Either thrower or inside to runner
- **Keep possession**



- During switch, this lateral movement of defenders could result in central space
- Always look to break lines with passing during these transitions



Player Centered Game Model

Force Backward/Press

Balance

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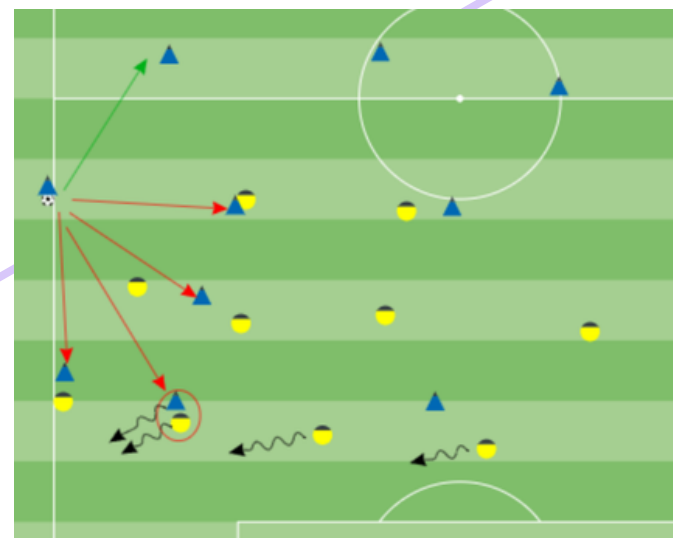
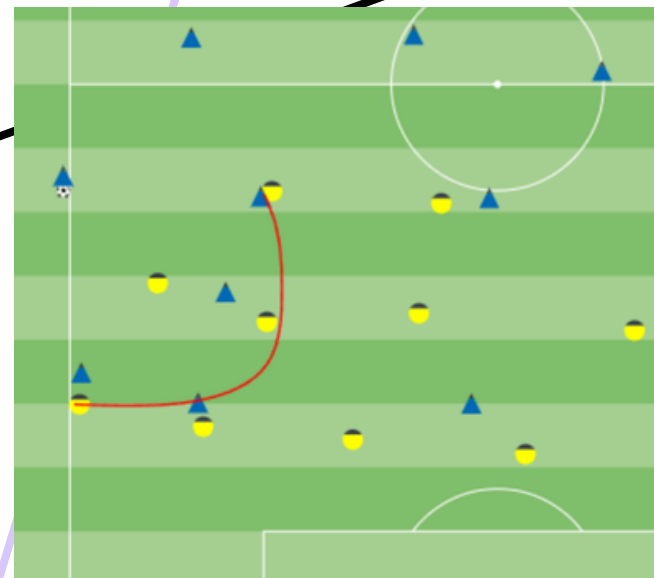
Game Management

Set Pieces

Throw Ins

Offense

Defense



- Most teams throw down the line.
- Keep play in front of us
- 1v1 defense here is fine, we don't need to overcommit players and allow space behind or internally
- Create a pocket of pressure where the safe option for the opponent is to play backward
- When the opponent sends a runner behind, our defensive line needs to shift, and the FS2/3 needs to drop
- GK communicate these movements if within 40 yards of goal



- Big danger in overcommitting players
- Necessary to keep balance - we need players in multiple lanes
- Keep space between central players, offset lines

- Our objective is like any defensive press - regain possession through coordinated pressure and controlling space.
- Communication of shape and positional discipline is key
- Pass off defensive marks when leaving your zone, keep shape and force opponent into risky forward passes or safe backward passes



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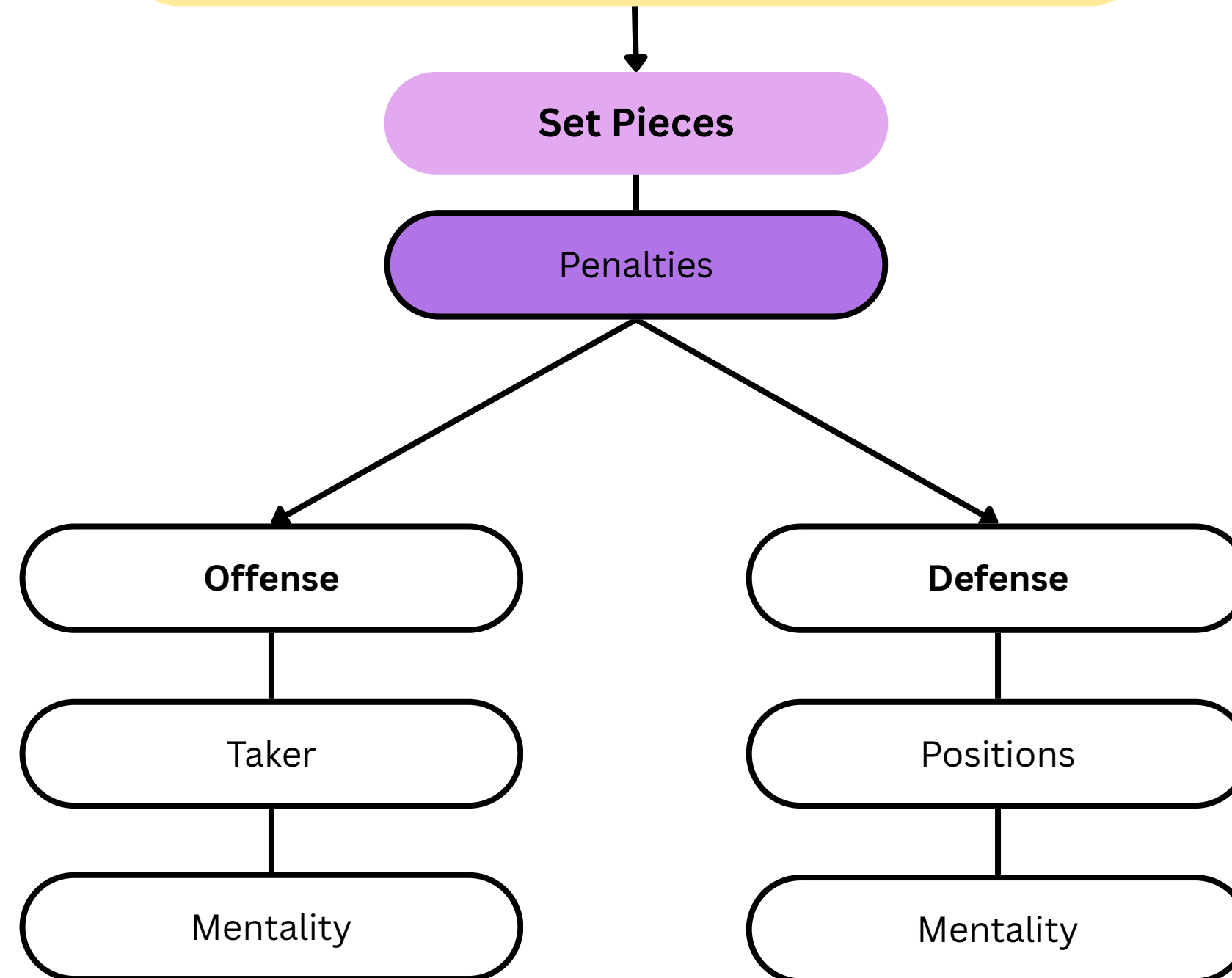
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Player Centered Game Model





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Penalties

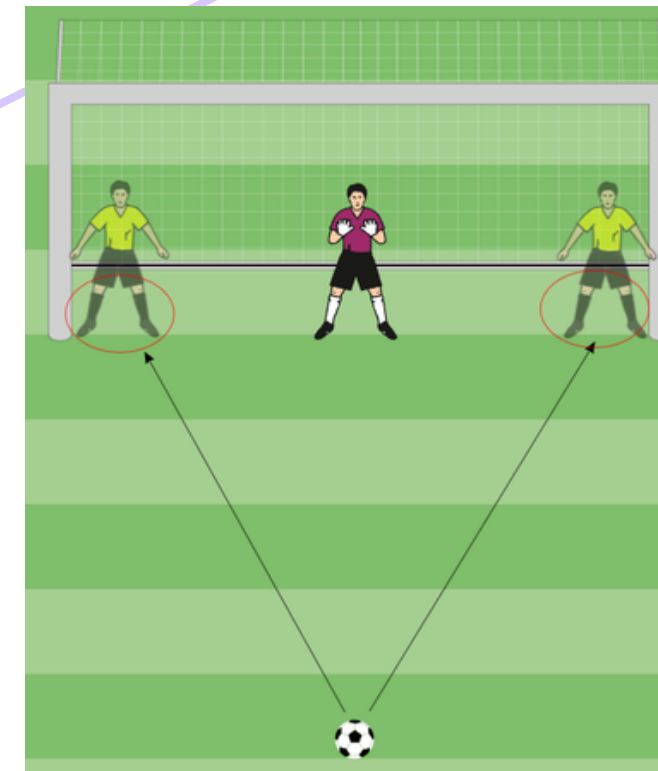
Offense

Defense

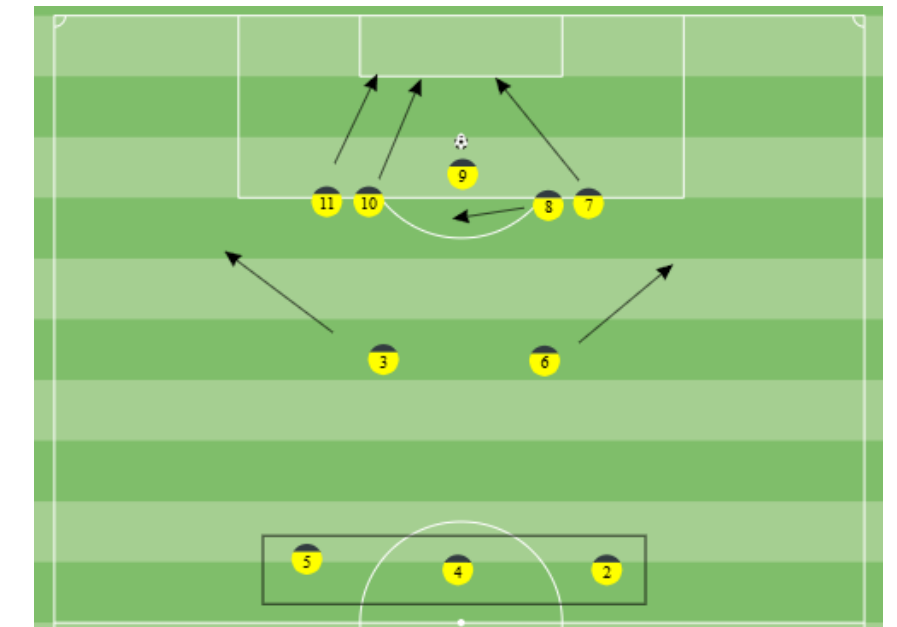
Taker

Mentality

- Taker is the person who drew the foul
- If they don't want to take it, we have an order. Top of order on the field takes it.



- Pass the ball to the teammate inside the post.
- Pass with force, but pass.
- Miss internal - force a save
- 3 Players Crash the kick. Rest in Rest defense.





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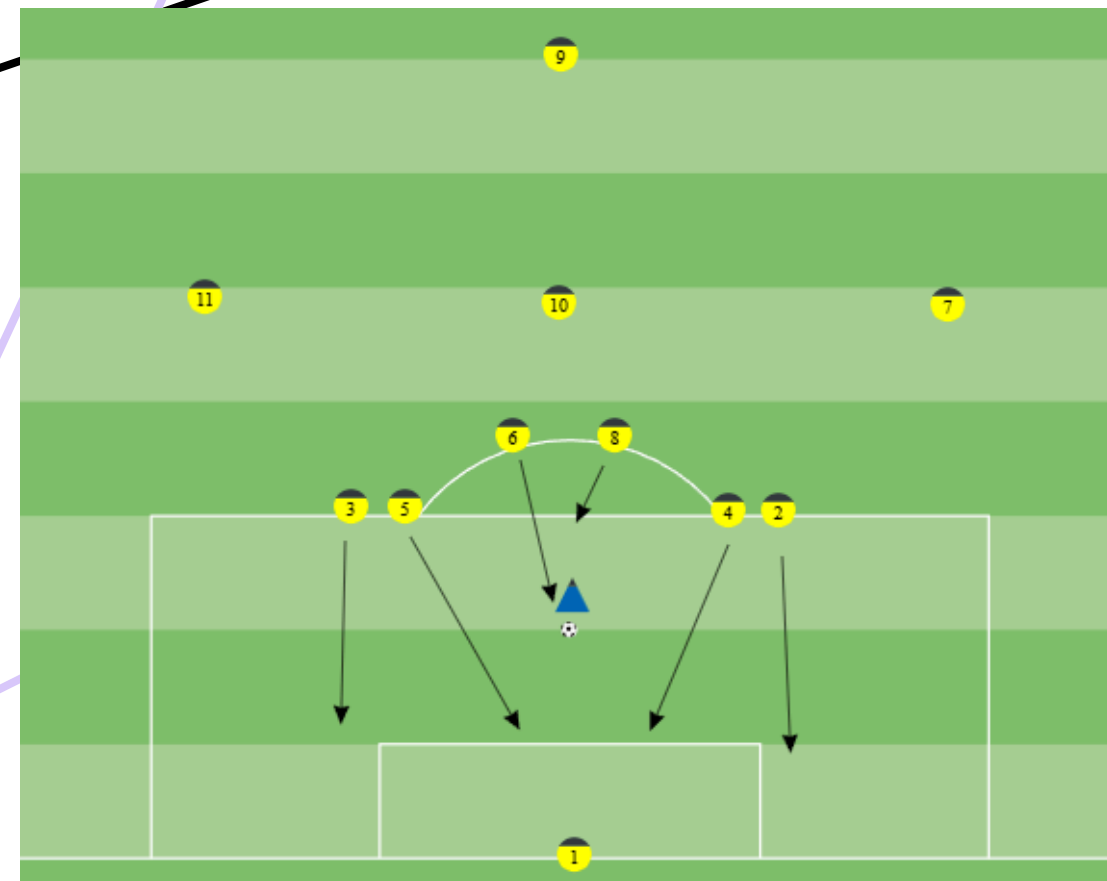
Set Pieces

Penalties

Offense

Defense

Positions



- 3 - 1 counterattacking shape up high
- 4/5 Crash back on keeper
- 2/3 drop to corner of six yard area
- 6/8 penalty spot and D.
- Everyone focus on regaining possession and counterattacking from any deflection

Mentality

- Crash the box to defend, immediately counter if possible.
- If they score - react to the new situation immediately. Settle, kickoff, attack.
- Teams are most vulnerable after they score - if the opponent scores this PK, we look at this as an opportunity to create a dangerous chance more easily
- How do we immediately switch our mentality to possess the ball and attack without dropping our intensity levels?



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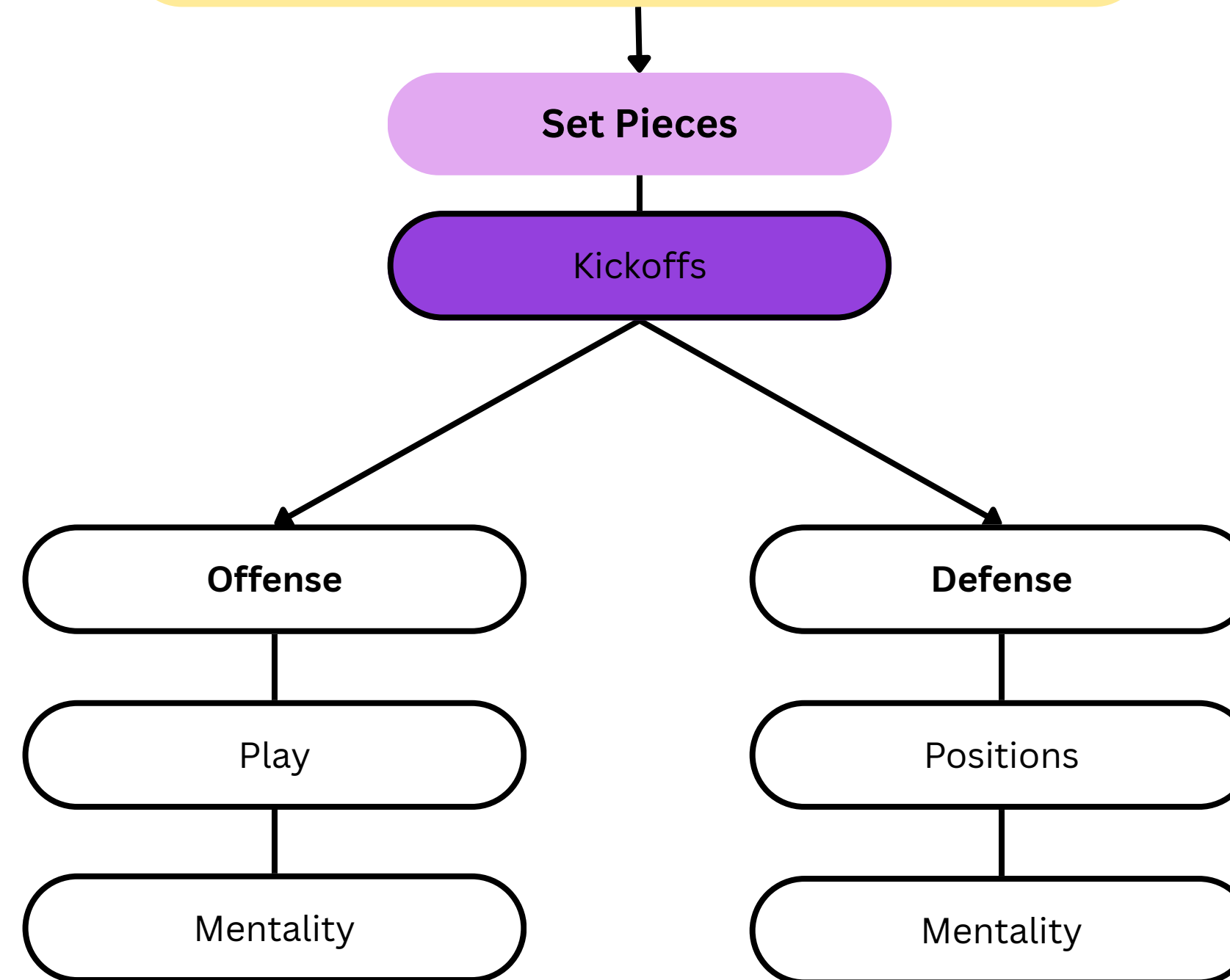
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Set Pieces

Player Centered Game Model





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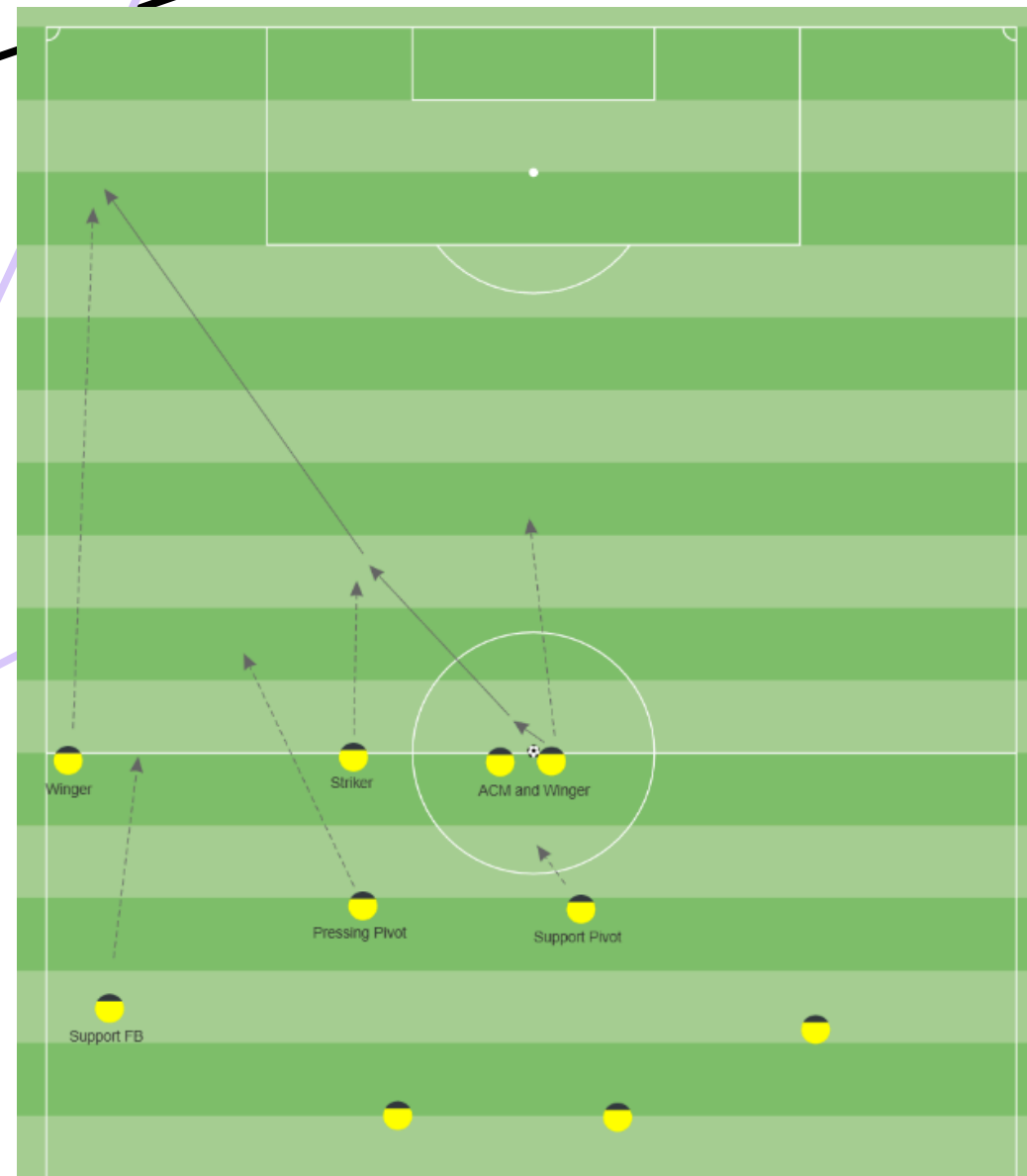
Kickoffs

Offense

Defense

Play 1 of 2

Mentality



- The objective is to establish the tone of the opening few minutes - that we will be on the front foot, attacking with intent and possession.
- 10 and 7 in the circle, 9 outside on the left, 11 on the touchline.
- 7 to 10, then 11 runs forward to give space and/or provide option. 10 to 9 in half-space left. 9 to 11 on the line.
- Options for dribbling forward, combining with 7 or 10, but once through Attacking and Midfield Lines we have 4 attackers.
- 6/8 to crash space behind striker in support. 3 also in support. Back three and other pivot move and respond to midfield line.



Player Centered Game Model

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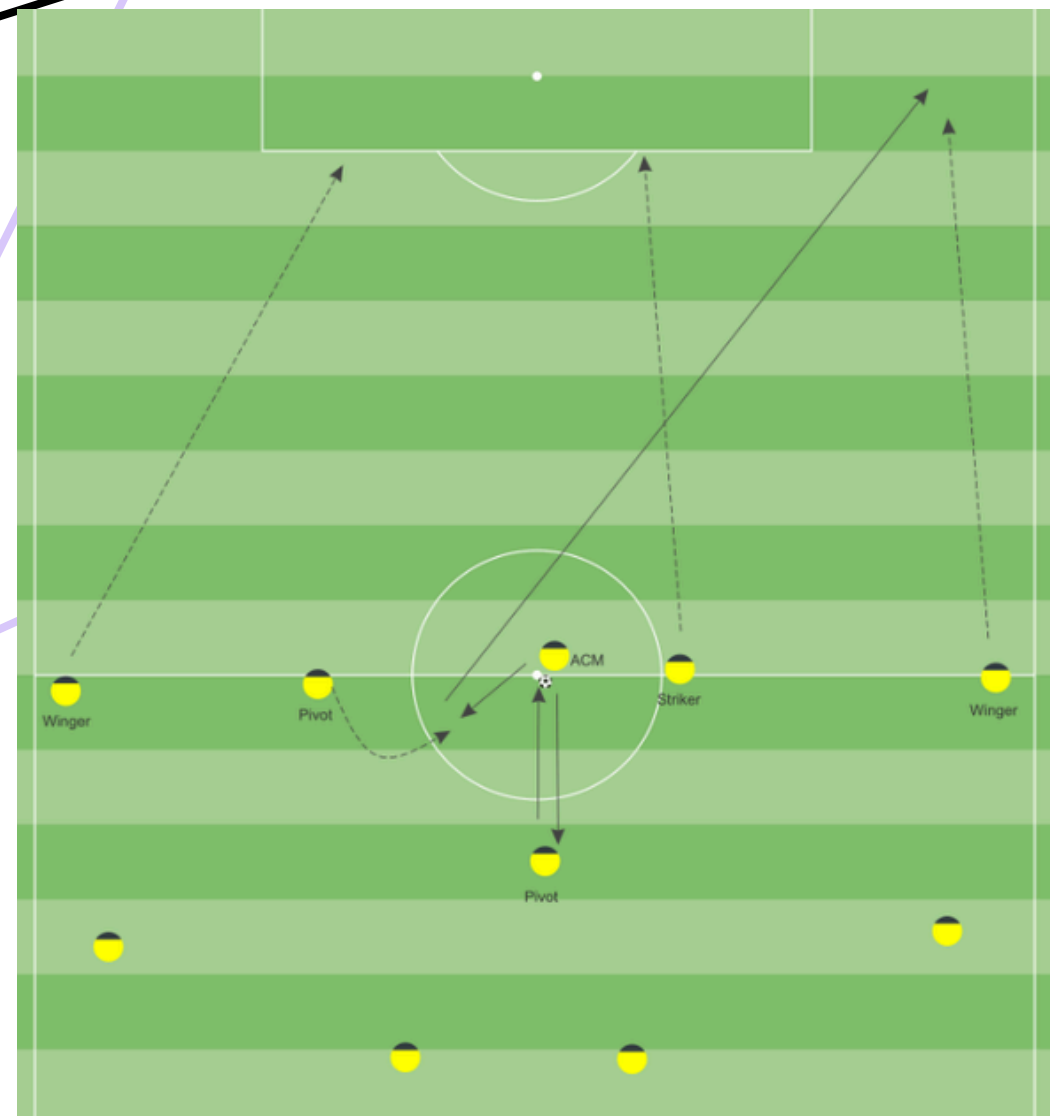
Kickoffs

Offense

Defense

Play 2 of 2

Mentality



- The objective is to establish the tone of the opening few minutes - that we will be on the front foot, attacking with intent and possession.
- 10 drops to 6/8, then 10 finds space. 6/8 back to 10, who lays off to other 6/8, who plays down far side line.
- Other options for combinations or near side line exist based on opponent.
- Strong side fullback moves forward in support.
- Pivots provide balance and immediate counterpressing.
- Establish a high defensive line at midfield to lock opponent into their half.



Player Centered Game Model

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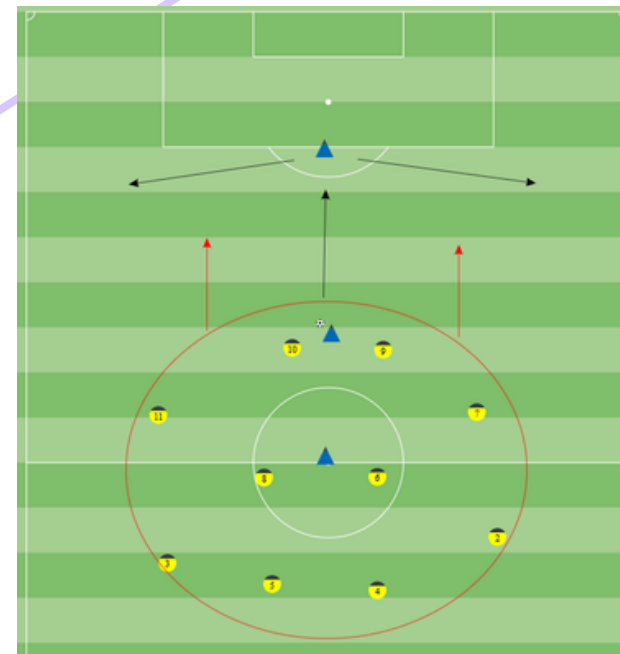
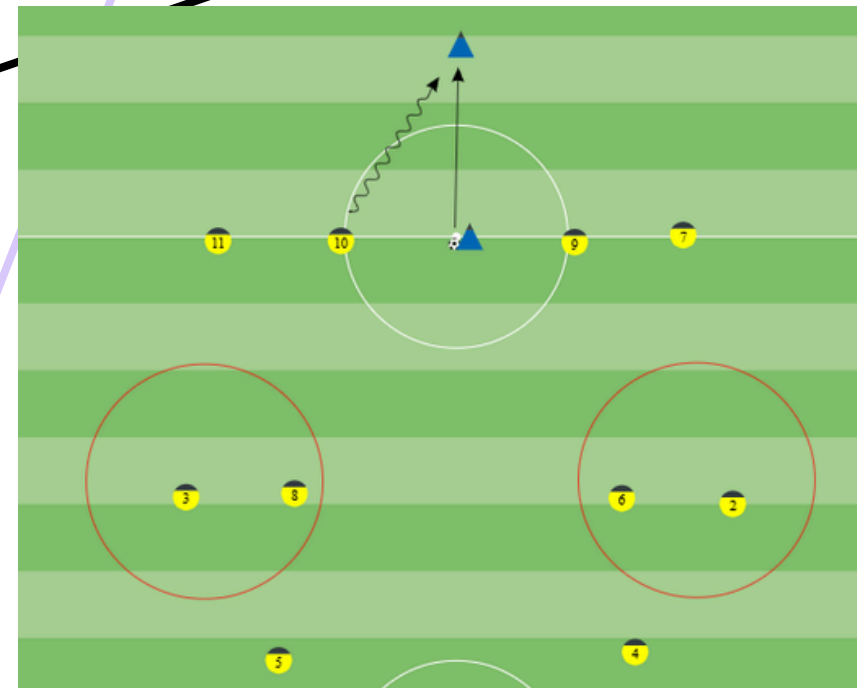
Set Pieces

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Positions



Mentality

Steps

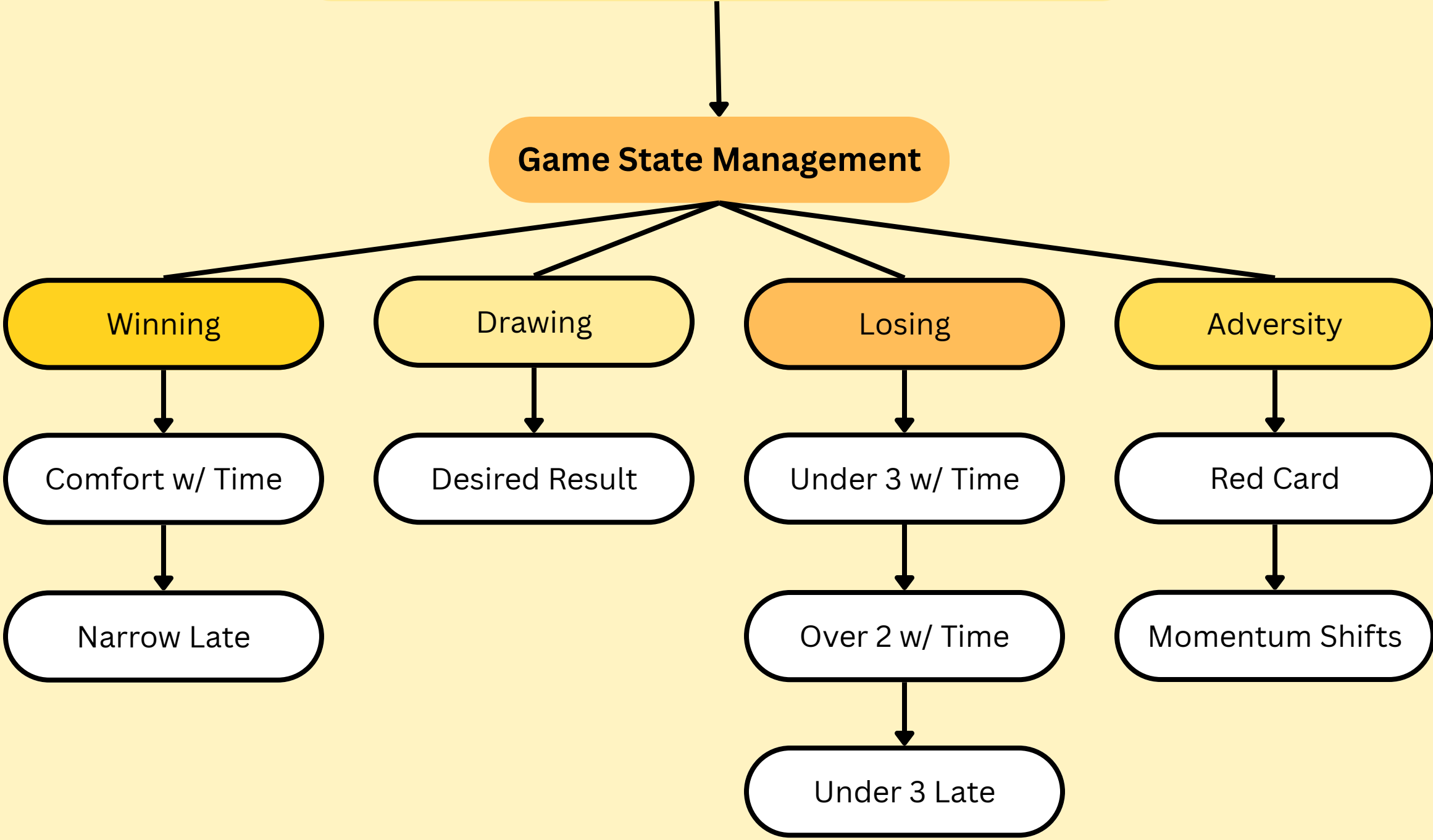
- Immediately mark the 2 dangerous zones with 2/3/6/8 in respective positions, supported by 4/5
- If ball is not played long immediately, we shift into our mid/low defensive principles (page 17)
- If ball is played back to their keeper, and our midfield line is in the attacking half, and we are in good position, 9 can trigger the high press. Then we follow high/low defensive principles (page 12)
- **Mentality here is to immediately establish that we are controlling the spaces into which the opponent can easily play. From the beginning, even without the ball, we are in control of the game.**



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Game Management

Player Centered Game Model





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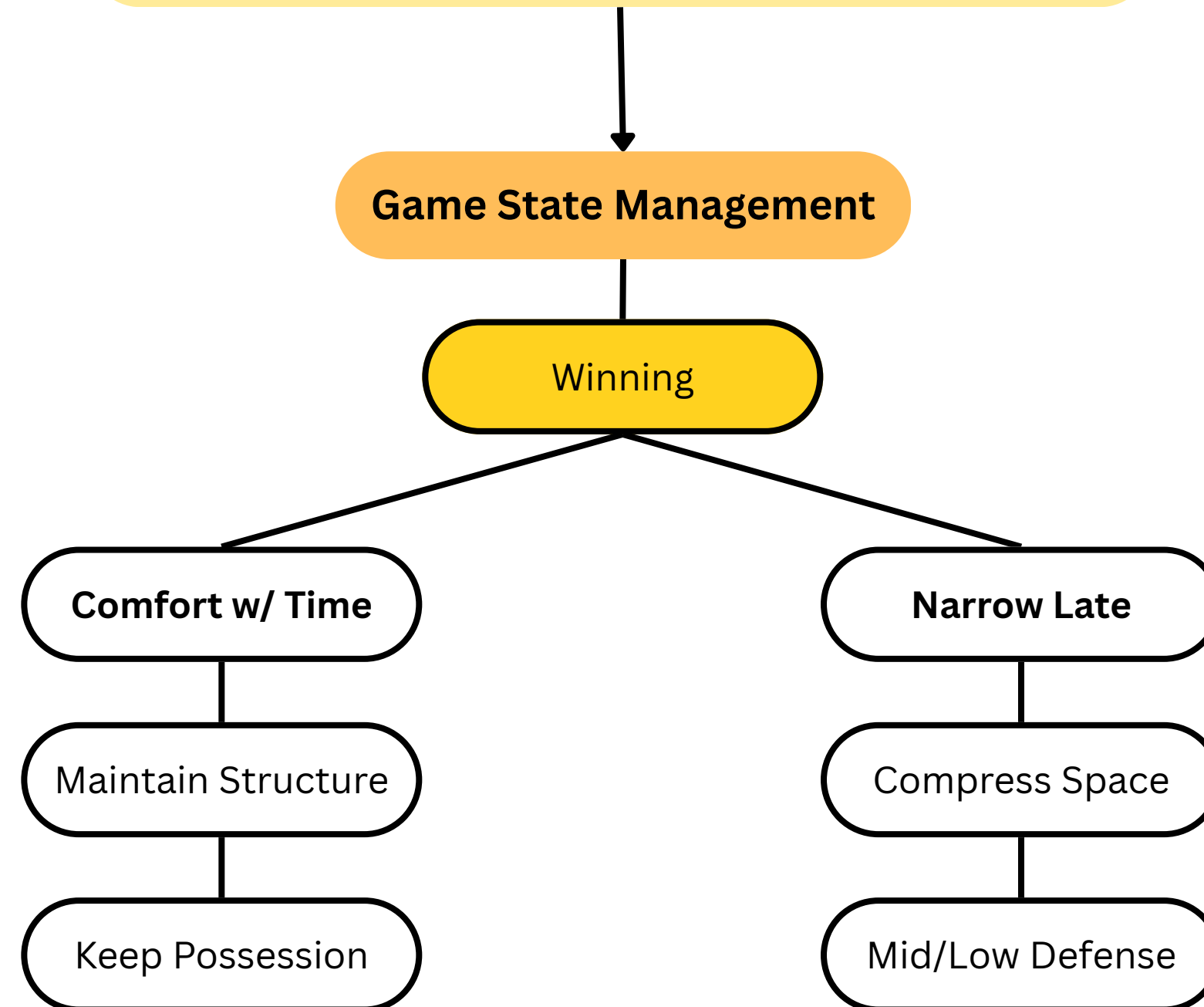
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Player Centered Game Model





Player Centered Game Model

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Game Management

Maintain Structure

Keep Possession

**Game State
Management**

Winning

Comfort w/ Time

Narrow Late

- Very important that we don't get loose. There is time left on the clock and the opponent will be playing with more intent to score to get back into the game.
- Captains need to maintain calm and discipline on the pitch, we get into our positions and make sure each position's primary objective is clear and top of mind.

- Let's keep the ball to stem any changes of momentum. We want to feel like an inevitable machine - there's no way for the opponent to find consistent pressure.
- Make the opponent run. The longer we have the ball and the lead, the more difficult it is for the game to slip away. Continually switch the point of attack and ask questions, probe for weaknesses.
- Play stifling defense, don't let them feel like they have a chance to get back into it.



Player Centered Game Model

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Game Management

Compress Space

Mid/Low Defense

**Game State
Management**

Winning

Comfort w/ Time

Narrow Late

- The opponent will be getting desperate, let's adjust the risk percentages and compress space in the midfield.
- Protect the center of the pitch and continually force the opponent backwards. Don't play risky defense, don't foul, just pressure and support to deny space to play and sacrifice the attacking half of the field.

- Ignore high pressing triggers and stay back in the mid-block to deny space and don't take risks.
- Adding another defender allows us to step FORWARD more and play more aggressively on defense, DO NOT DROP FURTHER with the extra defender on the field.
- There is a mentality to adding a defender that needs to be understood by the team. Extra defender allows for extra aggression in defensive third - do not give the opponent any time or space in that area.



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Player Centered Game Model

Game State Management

Drawing

Desired Result?

Win/Lose Gamble

Maintain



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Win/Lose Gamble

Maintain

**Game State
Management**

Drawing

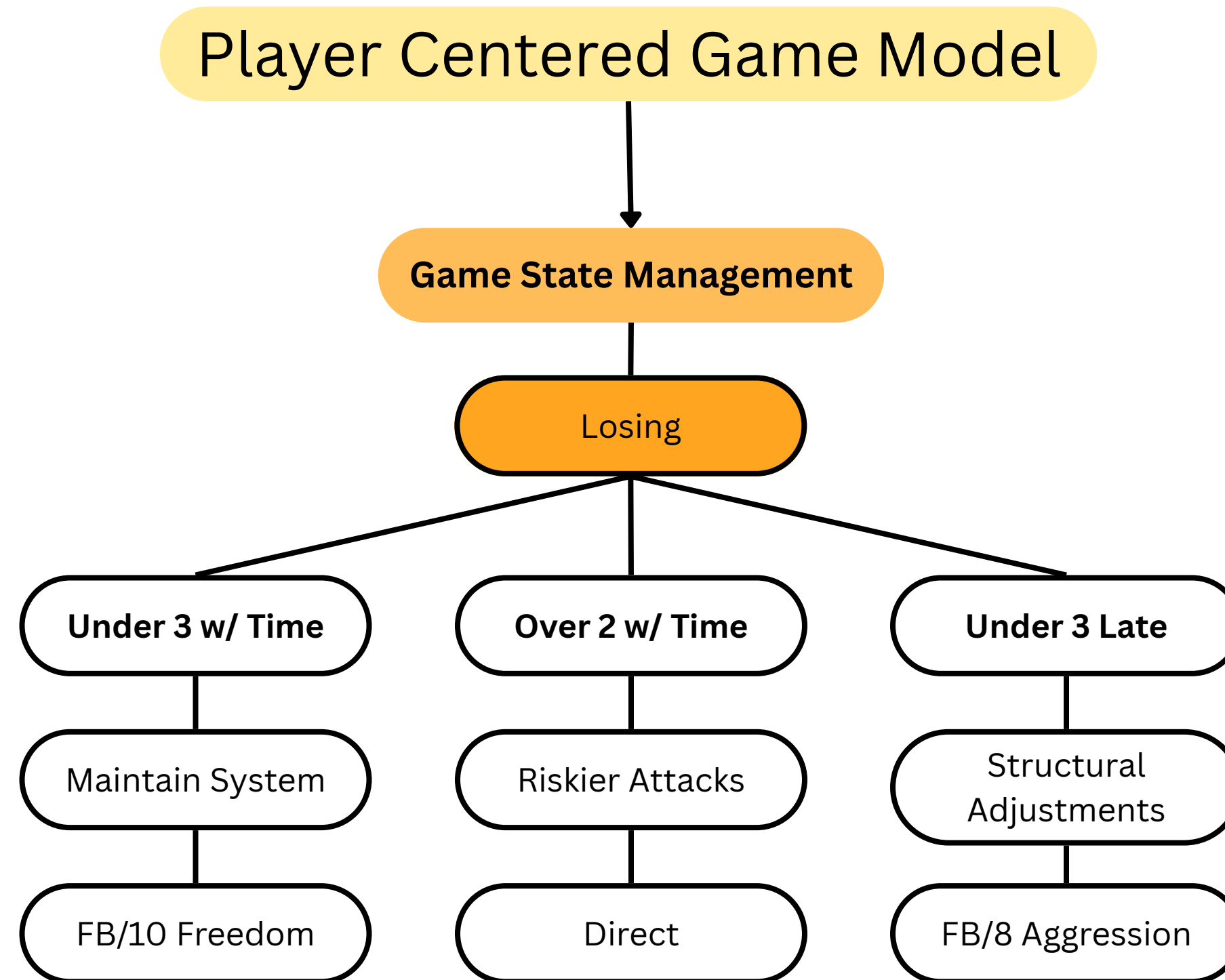
Desired Result?

- At home with either nothing on the line or needing a win for league reasons, we shift.
- Free the fullbacks to attack more and push a 6 higher to a dual 10, look to overload the opponent back line.
- Defensive line/rest defense needs to be solid and connected.
- Take risks from midfield.

- On the road or at home needing a point, shift to the same game plan as holding on to a late lead. (page 73)



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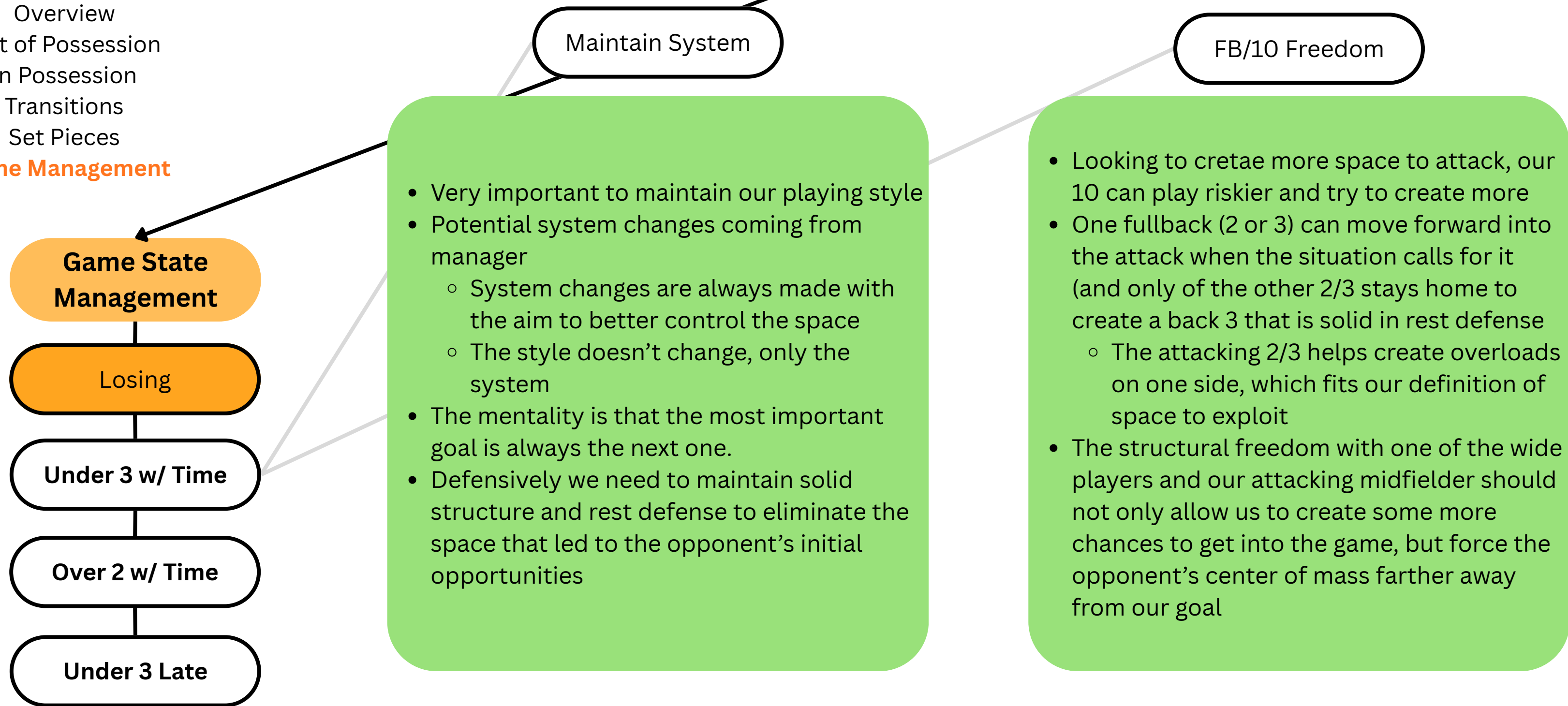




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Player Centered Game Model

Riskier Attacks

Direct

- If the game is getting away from us, the mentality should be to step the tide with a goal
- Shifting a 2/3 higher up, sending the 8 up to be a duel 10, defending more riskily with a 3-1 are options for creating opportunities
- The mentality should not be to bunker more and hope for the best - we need to wrest control from the opponent with a creative, risky attack from an overloaded side.
- During these moments, the defense will need to play safe during counterattacks against us

- Playing direct over the top, or early crosses behind the line, only works if the space exists there.
- A change of system to shift the available space so we can exploit the gaps before the opponent can adjust.
 - See Page 85
- Continuous pressure on their defensive line, even with a lower likelihood of success, can teach us where the weaknesses are that we can try to exploit.
- Rest defense important to stop the opponent from continuing to score

Game State Management

Losing

Under 3 w/ Time

Over 2 w/ Time

Under 3 Late

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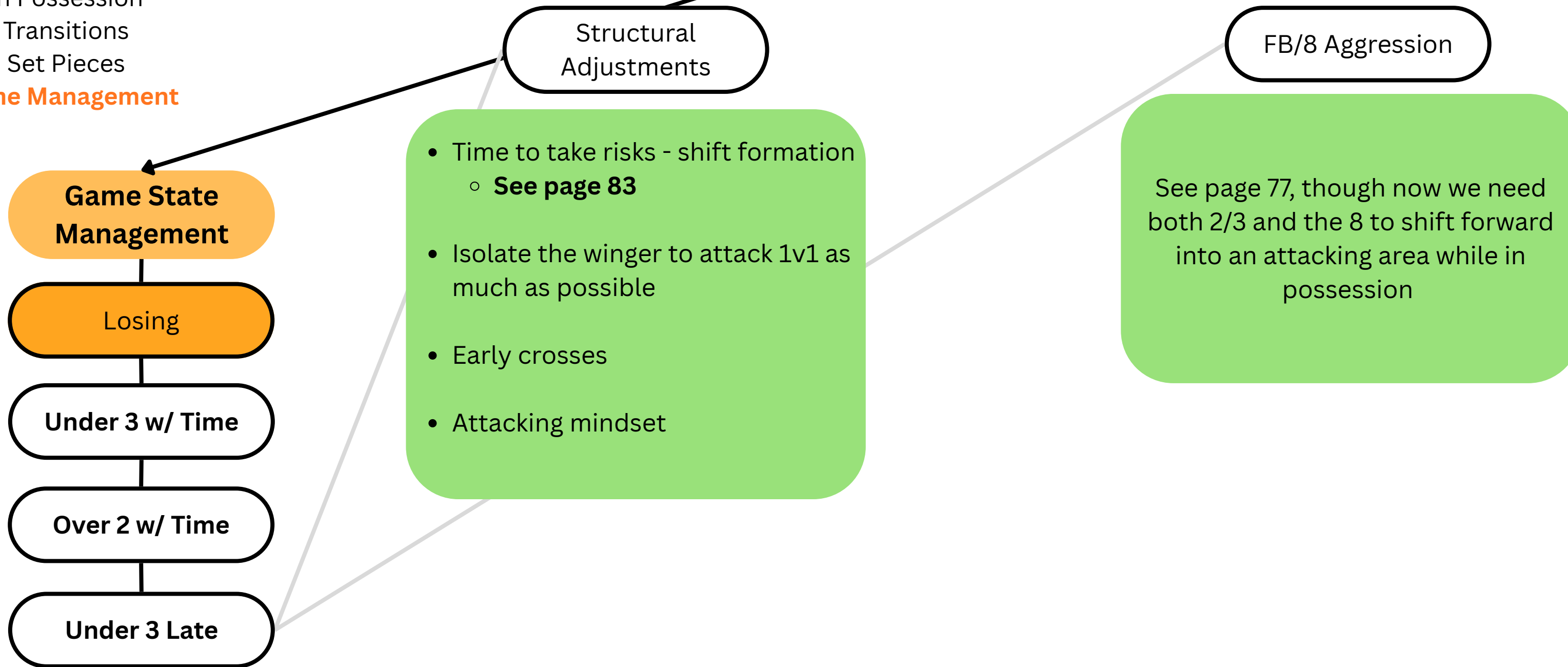
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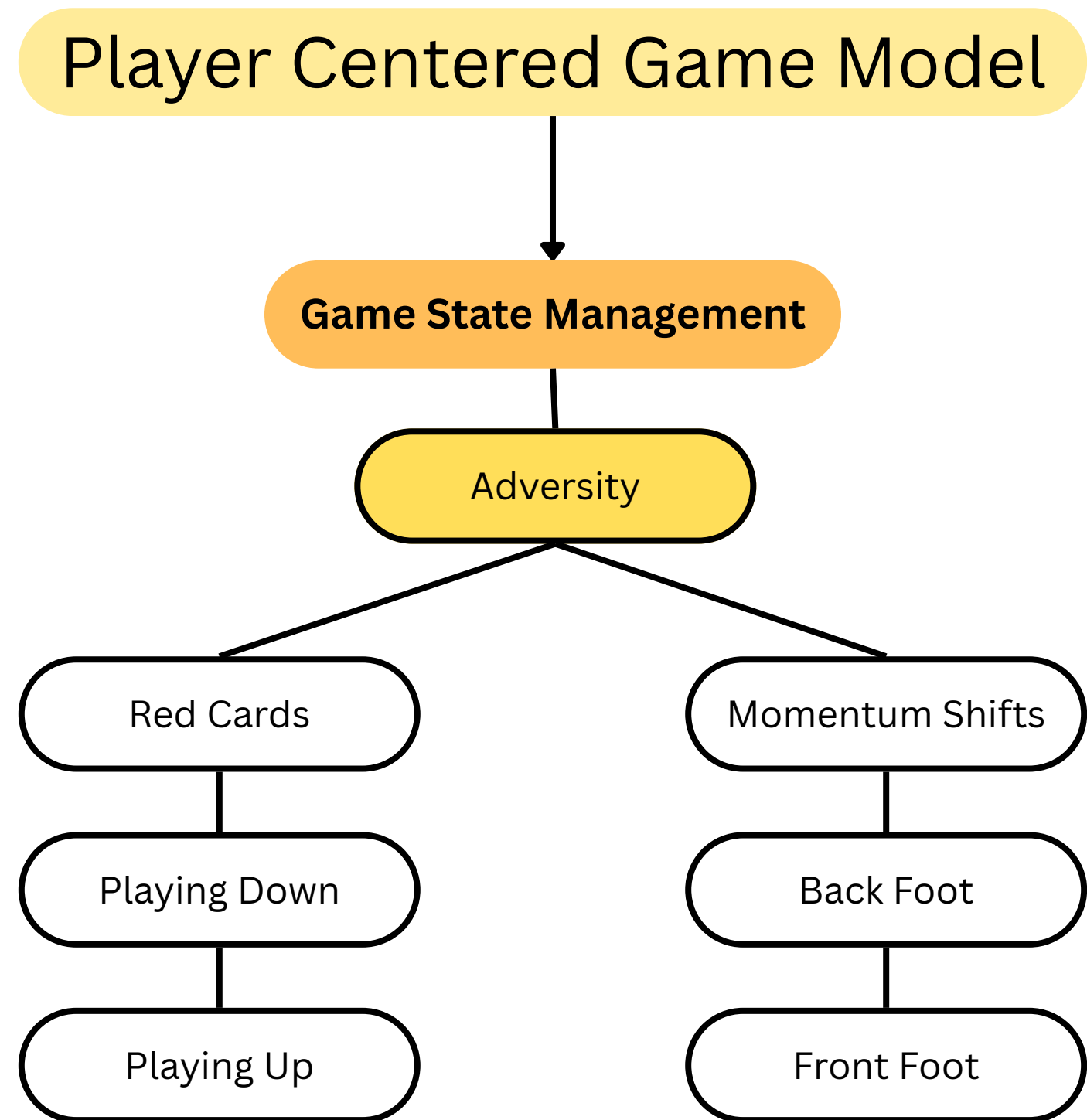
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Game State Management

Adversity

Red Cards

Momentum Shifts

Up or Down

Situation	Tactical Fix	Execution
Opponent reduced to 10 men	Use the spare player to create overloads	Stretch the pitch, switch play, maintain rest defence.
Team reduced to 10 men	Simplify structure and stay compact	Default to a 4-4-1 unless game state demands more risk.
Need to score with 10 men	Keep two players between the lines	Use a 4-3-2 or similar attacking variation.
Need to defend with 10 men	Protect central areas first	Force opponents wide and defend crosses.



Player Centered Game Model

Match State

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Game State
Management

Adversity

Red Cards

Momentum Shifts

Match State	Tactical Fix	Execution
On the back foot	Add control	More possession, shorter distances, extra midfielder.
On the front foot	Sustain pressure	Keep territory, counter-press, maintain rest defence.
Match is chaotic	Restore structure	Compact shape, simpler roles, slower tempo.
Opponent gaining momentum	Break rhythm	Possession spells, tactical changes, game management.
Need a momentum shift	Create an event	Higher press, attacking substitution, extra forward.



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Tactical Adjustments

Problem Area in 3-5-2	Tactical Fix	Execution
Wing-backs can become isolated	Use a 4-3-3 with wide wingers	Create 2v1s on the flanks through overlaps and quick switches.
Central midfield congestion	Stretch them before playing through or around them	Use switches of play and channel balls behind wing-backs.
Two-striker partnership	Use a disciplined 6 to protect the CBs	Screen passes into strikers and create a temporary 3v2 when needed.
Three-CB build-up	Press the outside CBs aggressively	Force long balls and disrupt their build-up structure.

Problem Area (4-2-3-1)	Tactical Fix	Execution
Better central midfielders	Avoid central possession battles	Use wide progression and quick attacks.
Dangerous #10	Keep a disciplined screen in front of CBs	Force him to receive under pressure or facing away from goal.
Faster transitions	Attack more directly	Connect striker, #10 and wingers quickly after regains.
Dominant double pivot	Press selectively	Trigger pressure only when possession becomes vulnerable.
Midfield being outnumbered	Create a temporary midfield three	Have the #10 drop alongside the pivots when defending.



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Tactical Adjustments

Problem Area (4-3-3)	Tactical Fix	Execution
Midfield three creating central pressure	Use the #10 between lines	Occupy spaces around their lone 6 and link attacks.
Wide forwards isolating full-backs	Defend as a compact 4-4-1-1	Wingers recover and help full-backs.
Single pivot controlling possession	Block access to the 6	Force build-up through centre-backs and wide areas.
High full-backs	Counter into channels	Attack space behind advancing full-backs immediately after regains.

Problem Area (4-4-2)	Tactical Fix	Execution
Two-man central midfield	Use your #10 to create a 3v2 overload	Occupy spaces between their midfield and defence.
Two-striker press	Build through CBs and double pivot	Create numerical superiority in first phase.
Flat midfield four	Stretch the block horizontally	Use switches and overlapping runs.
Wide midfielders responsible for defending	Create flank overloads	Combine with full-back and winger to generate 2v1s.
Strike partnership disrupting build-up	Form a temporary back three	Drop a pivot between CBs when necessary.



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Tactical Adjustments

Problem We're Facing	Formation Adjustment	Why
Need more central control	4-3-3	Adds a third midfielder and improves possession.
Need to exploit wide spaces	4-3-3	Wingers stay higher and wider, stretching the opposition.
Need more players between the lines	4-2-2-2 / Box Midfield	Creates multiple central passing options.
Opponent dominating midfield	4-3-3 or 4-1-4-1	Matches or exceeds midfield numbers.
Opponent defending deep	4-2-4	Adds extra attackers to occupy the back line.
Opponent exposing your full-backs	3-4-3 / 5-2-3	Gives extra defensive cover.
Need more counterattacking threat	4-4-2	Two forwards stay high and stretch defenders.
Opponent playing two strikers	3-4-2-1	Creates a spare centre-back.



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Glossary

Term	Meaning
NS	Near Side (same side as the ball)
FS	Far Side (opposite side from the ball)
NS7/11	Near-side winger
FS7/11	Far-side winger
NS2/3	Near-side fullback
FS2/3	Far-side fullback
NS6/8	Near-side pivot/midfielder
FS6/8	Far-side pivot/midfielder
4 or 5	Center backs
2 or 3	Fullbacks
6	Anchor pivot
8	Progressor midfielder
10	Attacking midfielder
9	Striker

Term	Meaning
Red Zone	Dangerous central space between defensive line and midfield line
Rest Defense	Defensive structure maintained while attacking to prevent counters
Counterpress	Immediate pressure after losing possession to regain the ball
High/Low	High press that recovers into a low block if broken
Mid/Low	Mid-block or low-block defensive organization
Vertical Compression	Reducing space between lines vertically
Half Space	Channel between central and wide areas
Switch Play	Move the ball from one side of the field to the other
Second Ball	Loose ball after an aerial duel, clearance, or deflection
Backpress	Pressure applied from behind the ball after losing possession
Center of Mass	Concept describing the opponent team's overall positional balance and shape
Control Space	Deny or manage areas the opponent wants to use
Create Space	Use movement, width, rotations, or possession to open areas
Exploit Space	Attack available space quickly and effectively



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Glossary

Term	Meaning
Pressure/Cover	Defensive relationship where one player pressures and another supports
Overload	Creating a numerical advantage in an area
Line-Splitting Pass	Pass that breaks through a defensive or midfield line
Direct Play	Playing quickly toward advanced spaces or targets
Recovery Run	Run made to regain defensive structure
Support	Providing a safe passing option for the ball carrier
Compress Space	Reduce available playing area for the opponent
Build	Structured possession phase from the back
High Build	Possession in advanced areas with attacking structure
Low Build	Possession phase beginning from defensive third
Trigger	Predefined cue that initiates an action such as pressing
Trap	Pressing setup designed to force play into a desired area
5 Under	Supporting structure underneath direct play/aerial contests
2-Man Control	Players positioned to secure first and second contacts around direct play